tenderness in your touch

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by colossalEgo

Summary

As a beta, Mydei pays little mind to the nonsense happenings between alphas and omegas. He cares little for their grievances over scenting rituals and grumblings over markings. However, with his people begrudgingly settled in Okhema, he is forced to confront them. Even worse, his people take particular issue with Phainon's presence around him, and insist for him to keep his distance.

But why is it so wrong for him to want a tenderness in his life he never once had?

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Dust billows as Mydei slams a Kremnoan alpha to the ground. He grips the alpha by the arm, looming above him. His muscles flex and sweat drips down his temple as he pushes his weight forward into the alpha's back. After a few heavy breaths and a trembling, meager contest to dislodge from the vice grip, he calls for release. Mydei obliges.

Other Kremnoans are gathered around the open air gymnasium, some standing off to the side while others sit on benches, watching their crown prince instruct on the finer details of hand to hand combat with a live demonstration. The alpha joins the cluster of defeated warriors who jumped at the chance to spar with their prince, nodding his head in approval over his prowess. Great strength, after all, is a valuable feature to possess.

Mydei turns to the eager ones who wait, and calls out, "Who wants to try me next?"

An omega warrior approaches. His shoulders are drawn taut, his jaw clenched in agitation, and his fists ready to spar. Mydei remembers him. He was the one who caused a scene a day ago about his status as an omega—one he had to intervene in before it devolved into a bloody fight. As anticipated, his people struggle to acclimate with their long standing enemy: the city-state of Okhema.

Instead of invading the Holy City, he forces them to live with begrudging passivity. And, as proud warriors, they take issue with his ambitions. Mumblings sprout of how different his rule would be if he were an alpha. He is told he would have been more fierce in his disposition, and taken his rightful role as a conqueror. The thought leaves a bitter taste.

When he wishes for his people to acclimate and not throw their lives away in conflict, they question his decisions. To turn away from tradition and

play house with Okhema—the word blasphemy clings to the tips of their tongues. Grips between their teeth. Yet they follow his decree, for none can best him in a duel to change his thinking.

The omega warrior lowers himself into a fighting stance, and Mydei honors him with the same respect.

In the Holy City, omegas are ones who provide for the home, who help run families. Not join militaries and become soldiers. Mydei once scoffed and called them “pets” when he first learned of this, and Aglaea—a beta like himself—scolded him.

“They are not pets,” she said. “There is a different ideology housed within the walls of Okhema. They are not people who have been instructed in the art of warfare, nor have they been taught the values of ‘valorous death before glorious return.’ Take a careful look with your very own eyes, and see if they are as you say. I am sure someone as keen as yourself will understand.”

Pain brings comfort. It has been his constant companion for a long, long time. The first of his memory is choking on water clogging his lungs. Many more remembrances tear through his flesh, spilling golden blood from every slash, pierce, and hammer upon his immortal body. Every wound taught him lessons words can never breach; and so, too, can he understand others through conflict.

Like how much this omega detests his station as a soldier questioned. He allows for the bout between him and this warrior to extend; allows him to air his grievances over Okheman’s insulting his pride and having no opportunity to defend his honor with a bloody duel.

At first he would have agreed with his sentiments at the notion of omegas being tutted as too delicate for war, but with a different scrutiny, he became aware of something new. For the first time, he witnessed a life beyond never ending strife, and of how much more it can be. How much fondness and warmth came from children running to their parents. How households created a space for safety and love.

The first time he observed and witnessed this life without prejudice clouding his vision, his heart ached with want. Though, his people do not see what he sees. They find no pleasures of simple living where one can return home to a loving family. They wish to brandish steel and surrender their souls to Strife. To die with a wound through their chests as their greatest aspirations. His soul withers at the thought of such aimless ambitions.

Punches land on his torso. His arms are gripped with frightening strength. Even if he allows this omega some grace, he can never let him have the upper hand, for he is the crown prince. He stands alone above his people with no equal.

Mydei pins the omega warrior underneath him, knee to his back, and claims his victory. With every breath he takes, all he smells is dirt and sweat. No pheromones flow through the air, but those around him scrunch up their nose from an invisible thread.

“Who’s next?” He turns to the crowd, and an alpha stomps her way forward. This one, he remembers, is the omega’s companion who bore witness to her friend’s plights of yesterday.

“Your Highness,” she says, pounds a fist upon her chest in salute. “I cannot allow these Okheman swine to continue insulting our honor. They laugh at our omegas, claim them to be weak.” She spits on the ground. “They should be taught lessons on who is truly weak. A single Kremnoan omega can kill ten of their alphas. Let us show them what they deserve.”

A dull ache develops in the front of his head.

There are no more battles to draw spear and bow for. Marching across mountains, through marshes and valleys—it no longer offers a distraction. The mad King Eurypon has been slain by the Kremnoan Detachment. Castrum Kremnos is now a bygone city, no longer illustrious with power.

With no more conflicts to fight as an army, he has to deal with conflicts of society—these strange secondary dynamics he has no interest in.

Before, he was able to wave his hand away at these issues. This strange world of ‘scenting’ and ‘marking’ and how it perverses them. How it bothers them to such intrinsic levels it transforms them into different people. A peaceful living gives way to these different troubles. Those he has no interest in learning.

In an ideal world, everyone would be a beta like him. Reasonable and never once arguing over who smells like what or whom.

“If you defeat me in battle, I shall permit such things,” he says.

Pain may have been a terrible teacher, but it taught him how to win. How to fight against every opponent and come out on top. The alpha soldier takes her steps and stands in front of him, visage twitching with stifled fury.

“You may have the first move,” he offers.

With no hesitation, she surges forth. Her form is perfect from years upon years of training. Nurtured in the art of war before she turned the tender age of five. And he aches with this knowledge, this brutal way of living should be no more.

She manages to trap him in a headlock, her muscles straining in the squeeze, but he twists around and gains the upper hand with ease, then suplexes her onto the ground. The dust picks up once more. He holds her trapped until she has to give in.

“Your strength has no equal, Your Highness,” she says with heavy breaths, subdued by his power.

Though her words are false. There is one person who he claims as his equal: the alpha Deliverer, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae. But the pride of his people disallows them to acknowledge an alpha outside of their tribe.

They met outside the Holy City, and he tested him in a duel. After the grueling death match lasting ten days and nights with no victor, he thought he found his equal, but his people scoffed. He asked his respected alpha teacher Krateros why that was, and he answered thus:

“The crown prince of Kremnos has no equal. Especially not when it comes to an alpha whose very nature demands submission. It is an insult to you to call him as such. It is ignoble to bear his scent and fraternize with the witch’s loyal servant. You must keep your distance, Mydeimos. No good can come from his company.”

The undertow of his words carried him far beneath the surface, and he took them to heart at first; he ignored every belligerent attempt at conversation, every invitation to spar declined. Yet, the sunbeams penetrated the dark river, and he found himself floating towards them, hand outstretched.

And as his fingers grazed the light he questioned: who else would he find worthy to watch his back? Who else in this world could be his equal?

“You are strong,” he honors her, and stands. “I hear and understand your concerns. The plight of our people is not lost upon me. I bear your words, and all the omegas who suffer underneath the Okheman prejudices. But we cannot allow ourselves to be so easily swayed by provoking words. As Kremnoans, we must understand they wish to use underhanded tactics.”

“Pah, as all Okhemans want to do.” She lifts herself off the ground and straightens out, no longer rubbing the bruise forming on her arm. “Those hyenas hide with the knowledge of us following the laws of this land, and think themselves strong. Be it an equal battlefield, they would already be swimming in the Sea of Souls.”

At least his people are subdued from the most recent incident. Mydei stifles the groan bubbling beneath the surface. This will undoubtedly be repeated within a few days. This same bickering over and over again drains him—pulls at every corner of his patience.

With his people temporarily calmed, he turns to patrolling the city in the second quint of Action Hour. Once he steps outside the boundaries of the Kremnoans, eyes of strangers glue to his back. Distrustful Okhemans watch his every step, though quite a few have eased to his presence.

It’s grueling work to gain the trust of the masses. Thankless in many ways. But he needs to set an example for everyone. To show that he and his

people are not war mongering, selfish brutes.

From a distance, he spots two children watching their friend try to climb a tree. At the top branches, a ball wedges between the foliage. The child scampers up until his grip weakens and he lands on his butt with a thud. His friends gather around him.

Mydei steps forward. “What are you three doing?”

“We’re trying to get our ball back!” The one on the ground says, glaring up at the treetop. The other two gawk in surprise.

“It’s the crown prince!”

“His Highness is here to help us!”

“Crown prince?” he mutters underneath his breath. “Are you three Kremnoan?”

“Yeah!” The one on the ground stands. His knees are scuffed.

“Why haven’t you three gotten an adult to help out?” he asks.

“Because our parents are busy, and all these Okhemans are a bunch of wusses!”

“Right…” he chuckles softly. “I’ll help you out, but you have to promise me the next time this happens you won’t try climbing up this tree on your own, and get an adult to help.”

The three of them nod eagerly. With that, he jumps to action, nimbly climbing up the branches. The children clamor in excitement. It barely takes him a minute until he’s at the very top. A familiar, cheerful voice calls out as his fingers brush the ball.

“Why, is that Mydei?” Phainon gazes upwards, a grin plastered on his face. “You really are a cat, climbing up so high in the trees! Are you going to take a nap there as well?”

“His Highness is helping us get our ball back!” the girl with bright red hair says.

“Oh, is he now?” Phainon says, and Mydei ignores the amused lilt in his tone. “How valiant is the prince, coming in your time of need.”

“He’s so awesome!” the boy beside him exclaims, his knees and elbows scuffed with his attempts to climb. “It took him only a minute to climb up to the top.”

“Yeah, because he saw you falling and then yelled at you for not getting an adult,” the blonde girl says with her hands on her hips.

“Hey! I almost got up there!”

“If it took the prince a minute to get up there then it would take me thirty seconds,” Phainon joins in, placing a proud hand upon his chest. The children all glimmer with excitement.

Mydei doesn’t understand the Deliverer’s strange fascination with boasting about his skills in comparison to his. And he doesn’t understand why it gets underneath his skin. His ears twitch with every proclamation of how better he is, and his blood boils.

Without an ounce of hesitation, Mydei hurls the ball down. It impacts Phainon’s skull with a loud smack, knocking him off balance. The boy chases the bouncing ball and scoops it up.

“If you are so eager to prove yourself, then fight me right here, right now,” Mydei says, slinging himself off the branch and landing beside him.

“Did you really have to do that?” Phainon rubs his head as he rights himself. “Talk about pettiness. That’s really unbecoming of you.”

“Hmph, whatever you say, Deliverer. Or perhaps you’ve grown so soft you can’t handle a simple throw.” He crosses his arms before turning his attention to the children. “Go. Enjoy your games. And get an adult if you lose it again.”

Phainon is about to open his mouth to continue on with his bantering, but his pupils constrict into pinpricks, and a low, dreadful growl rumbles through his chest. His lips curl back into a sneer as his nostrils flare in his inhalations. Mydei raises a curious brow over the sudden change in his disposition.

The children go from excitement to squeaking in terror. “Thank you, Your Highness!”

They run off, and Phainon’s gaze never tears from him. He takes a step forward, flashing his fangs in contempt. Another growl reverberates as leans in close, and inhales at his neck. The hair on his nape raises.

“What is with you?” Mydei asks in discomfort, but remains rooted in his spot. To back away would be a sign submission.

“Huh?” Clarity returns to Phainon with a blink. He takes a step back and the darkness eclipsing his visage vanishes. “I—” His eyes dart back and forth as nervousness overtakes him. “Did I do something?”

“You were growling at me like an animal. Did I hurt your feelings?” he mocks, relief easing through him.

“N-No!” He frantically waves his hands. “It’s just—Uh…”

“Spit it out. I don’t have all day.”

He swallows. “Did… Did you have relations with someone?”

Mydei stares at him.

“Like… You know…” He gestures with his hands.

“No, I don’t know. I have relations with my people. I speak with Aglaea and Castorice on the daily. What are you talking about this time?” His brow ticks in annoyance.

“Did you sleep with someone?!” Phainon blurts out.

The exclamation takes him by surprise.

“What are you talking about? Of course I haven’t.” Never once has he expressed interest in such a thing. Why in the gods names would Phainon think such a thing?

“Are you sure?” He squints in disbelief. “You’re covered in the smell of an alpha.”

Of course, these stupid dynamics continue to butt their heads in all aspects of his life. “Do such things matter? I was training my tribe in hand to hand combat.”

“Of course they matter!” he flusters. “It’s distracting. We should head to the baths right this second.”

“Or what? Your eyes will go cross from jealousy?”

“I’m-! I’m not jealous! Don’t say such ridiculous things, Mydeimos.”

“Quit acting like an alpha, we’re still on duty,” he scolds. “It would be unbecoming as warriors of Okhema to run off to leisures when we need to maintain peace.”

“A quick, ten minute dip in the baths is not an invitation to spend the rest of Action Hour soaking. Besides, you’re all dirty from climbing up that tree,” Phainon clings to a minuscule reason, gesturing wildly with his index finger. “We can’t have the crown prince of Kremnos walk around with leaves in his hair.”

“There are no leaves in my hair,” he says, but rakes a gauntleted hand through his hair and dusts his robes. “If you really find problems with a scent on me, we can simply patrol two different sections of the city.”

He takes a step in the other direction.

“No!” Phainon shouts a bit too loudly, and intercepts his stride. “I mean—why not go to your house and take a wet rag to rub yourself free of it? It doesn’t take much to get rid of a scent. I promise.”

The headache from earlier returns. He really doesn't want to be dealing with this.

"Why does it matter so much?" he dryly asks.

"Because-!" Phainon puffs up his cheeks like a child. "You should be more aware of your position. Kremnoans might not care as much, but citizens of Okhema—"

"Who are you implying isn't a citizen?" Mydei glowers. He might let the Deliverer fumble his words, but he will not stand for the exclusion of his people.

Phainon bites his tongue. "That's—You know that's not what I meant." He sighs, shoulders wilting. "Just—can you please be a bit more considerate to your new home?"

And for how much Phainon annoys him on the daily, he hates seeing that crestfallen look upon his visage. It tugs nonsensically at his heart strings, softening him into something he is not and never was.

A deep sigh rattles through him. His belligerence eats at his patience, and he deliberates over what might relieve him from this stress. Then, with careful words he mutters, "Would you be more at peace if you scented me?"

Phainon blinks, the stupid expression on his face almost makes Mydei chortle. "What?"

"I don't wish to return all the way to my home while on duty, and waste my time wiping myself with a cloth," he says, though that unfamiliar sensation coursing through his immortal body hopes Phainon takes the invitation.

"That is—I—Huh—?" he stutters as if the words are lodged in his throat.

"What?" Mydei resists the urge to rub his temple. "Perhaps it would be a good thing for all citizens to see me bearing the Deliverer's scent," he reasons, though his attempt to convince sounds as if he speaks to himself as

well. “A way to symbolize the unification of my people and a willingness to integrate.”

Phainon’s throat bobs in a heavy swallow. His golden pupils dilating the blue expanse of his iris. “If—If you’re sure.”

“I wouldn’t speak it if I weren’t,” he huffs, embarrassment tinges his cheeks with Phainon’s insecure delaying.

He grabs him by the elbow, and drags him behind a building, bringing him underneath an arbor trellis; the flowers bloom above them, bright and vivid purples, and the light from the Dawn Device gives them no privacy.

“You’re *sure*,” Phainon presses again, searching his features as if he proclaimed in jest.

“Don’t make me repeat the same words over and over,” he says. “I already agreed to humor you and your ridiculous alpha ways. If you continue hesitating I will resume patrolling. We’ve wasted enough—”

No more seconds are spared. Phainon grabs his shoulders, invades his personal space, and lowers his cheek to press against his neck. One back and forth rub on the right. Then on the left. The edges of his hair tickle his nose, and he discreetly inhales.

All he can smell is the tinge of shampoo and the flowers hanging overhead.

“There,” Phainon says, cheeks colored red like a delicious pomegranate. His fingers dig into his shoulders. He breathes in through his nose, then frowns. “Wait—No. Just a little more.”

This time, he’s careful. The rubbing of skin against skin is more measured. The softness of his cheek presses against his defunct scent glands on his neck. And, somehow, even he feels the intimacy of this. His heart picks up pace of its own volition, discomforting him. He rubs a thumb across his chest, trying to quell the sudden blooming of warmth expanding throughout his body.

It’s an odd sensation—one he’s never felt and leaves him befuddled. It’s not the searing fire scorching his veins in the heat of combat. It’s not the rush of returning to life after trudging against the current of the Sea of Souls. It’s something calmer… something…

Phainon’s nose buries into the crook of his neck, pressing against his glands, and inhales. A pleasant hum reverberates through his throat. The tip of his nose rubs up against his neck, and the delicate skin of his lips brush alongside, finding comfort in something he cannot. Those hands drift down his shoulders, fingertips brushing his arms.

And Mydei wonders what must have taken his attention; he’s been told in the past betas have their own miniscule, muted scents, but it can’t be this enticing. If he were an omega, these actions would be understandable. After all, their saccharine scents are meant to entice alphas. Lure them in. Hold them close. Make a family together. And—

He shoves him off.

“*Haikas*,” he mutters as he looks off to the side. “I think you’ve imparted your scent well enough.”

Phainon regards him with a look he can’t quite name—it softens the edges of his eyes, and his lips curl up into a gentle thing. Whatever it is, he refuses to meet it; refuses to admit the increased fluttering of his heart. His hands clench in the crossing of his arms.

“I think I can go for another pass,” he says. Mydei huffs and walks off. Phainon follows, trailing after him like a pleased puppy.

As they patrol through the streets the people regard him with a more friendly attitude seeing him walk side by side with Phainon. The man has a natural charisma which draws others to him, and he can’t deny he fell for it as well. By this point he understands it as the way of life: the Deliverer is warm and generous—the type to draw anyone in.

A few omegas grab Phainon’s attention as they pass by their stall of an assortment of foods, and he heads over to make sure everything is alright.

Mydei crosses his arms as he waits off to the side, tapping restlessly against his bicep.

Their giggling annoys him. Their excited cooing irritates him. Their fluttering eyelashes makes him want to cave their faces in. And these thoughts frustrate him. What's wrong with him? These feelings only sprout whenever omegas take up too much of Phainon's attention. Whenever he gives them that damned smile of his.

Which is ridiculous. Nothing they have done warrants such violence from him.

He glances over, and spots Phainon's red face as he denies something with a shaking of his head.

He doesn't mean to eavesdrop, but he hears the omega ask, "Did you— you know," and then does an odd gesture of snapping their teeth at him which causes Phainon to jolt in shock and shake his head more fiercely. They laugh more.

"No!" Phainon's panicked voice rings loudly. "Nothing of that nature! You are all mistaken we're…" His remaining words are left unheard as he returns to a normal volume.

Must be some strange alpha and omega conversation. A flash of fire burns through him, and he clenches his jaw, the muscle along his neck pulsing in the strain, and he fears he may crack his teeth if this continues.

"Deliverer, you can keep dallying if you so desire, but I have better things to do," he calls out, and turns on his heel. He's been ready to leave for the past five minutes.

He hears Phainon say, "Mydei-! Wait!"

A few strides down the street, and hurried steps chase after him. "You are so impatient."

An infuriating sense of relief washes over him, and he quarrels with how much his mood improves.

“Here.” Phainon holds out an apple in front of his face, cheeks still flushed. “A gift. They insisted I give this to you.”

“Why?” He eyes it wearily.

“Who knows,” Phainon scoffs, and turns away. “I don’t think you deserve it after ditching me.”

“Quit being dramatic.” He grabs it and takes a bite with a loud crunch.

Phainon’s gaze flickers between him and the road ahead before asking with an uncharacteristic shyness, “Is it good?”

“Mm.” He takes another large bite. Another loud crunch and explosion of sweetness upon his tongue. His sour mood from moments ago completely dissipates.

Phainon seems too pleased with himself. He decides to ignore it. But, it’s hard to ignore how closely he walks alongside him. How their arms brush. How he can spot the dark bags underneath his eyes with clarity. How Phainon’s voice dips low and he has to lean in to hear. Has he always been this touchy? Maybe the invisible scent he bears emboldens his actions.

And a shiver runs up his spine when Phainon presses a palm against his back as they navigate through a crowded street; right on top of his weak spot.

He roughly shoves him off. “Quit treating me like an omega.”

Phainon startles, then laughs. “I’m not treating you in such a way. I didn’t want us getting separated. Would you prefer for us to hold hands instead?” He waves it around in a mocking gesture.

Mydei narrows his eyes at his pertness.

“Mhm, that’s what I thought.” He steps back close and their shoulders brush. “I’ll stay my hand if it so pleases you.”

He responds with a grunt, and focuses on moving through the street, trying to ignore the soft touch and how it soothes. Ignoring how he didn’t mind the hand on his back and would appreciate its return.

After a few quints they eat dinner together. Such a thing is normal for them, and the owner greets them like regulars. They find a table in the back, and order a variety of foods ranging from meats to fruits.

“You’re not sleeping well,” Mydei states after their waiter walks off.

“Hm?” Phainon tilts his head, pretending to be confused.

“Don’t be obtuse, Deliverer. I see it written all over you.”

“If I didn’t know any better, I’d wager you are worried for me,” he banters. “And don’t accuse me of such things when I can see the same on you.”

His words are founded in truth; countless nights he has spent restlessly staring at the ceiling of his home. How can he sleep with the never ending pressures and responsibilities thrust upon him? When his desires run against a thousand years of tradition.

“Besides, we both know our limits. How many days and nights did we fight without a moment of reprieve? A night or two of insomnia is hardly a thing worth considering.” Phainon brushes off the concern with practiced ease.

Mydei knows he speaks in falsehoods. Such weariness painting his visage does not come from a couple of restless nights. It comes from weeks. Months. Maybe even years for someone like him.

“Hmph. A dull, uncared for blade is the weakest weapon of all,” he states.

“Are you suggesting you’ll oil me up and massage my tense back?” he asks with a glint in his eye.

“No.” He pinches the bridge of his nose, fighting how his stomach flips at the thought of running his hands down his back. Feeling the firm muscle underneath his bare hands. “Quit twisting my words.”

“I think we have bigger things to worry about.” Phainon’s gaze flickers behind him as he stifles his giggles, and the waiter comes back with a multitude of plates filled to the brim.

Mydei gives polite words of gratitude to their waiter as he juggles a row of plates on each arm, and miraculously places each and every single one of them down.

“Alright Mydeimos, let us see who can eat their meal the fastest, shall we?” Phainon throws him a look which never fails to get underneath his skin. The sort of sly smile uncharacteristic of the man known as the savior.

It taunts him fiercely, influencing him to eschew his regal demeanor.

He begins to devour and stuff his face.

“Hey-! I didn’t do a countdown, you’re cheating!” Phainon quickly follows suit.

It’s a playfulness he has never been afforded in this life of his until now. Something so light-hearted and insignificant, yet thrilling. The head start secures him an easy victory. And with victory, he can gloat over how much better he is while Phainon grumbles and whines over his secret duplicitous nature.

Deeper into Parting Hour, they pass by a few alpha and omega Kremnoans. They eye the Deliverer wearily. He grins in return, flashing his teeth, and takes a casual step closer to his side. His people bristle, but they hold their tongues in front of their prince. Their exchanges are curt, and they glare all the while.

At least the betas hold normal conversations, and it eases him from the tense atmosphere. Whatever silent communication happens is lost upon

their innocent bubble of naivety. With nothing out of the ordinary needing to be addressed, they continue on their way.

But his back prickles with their stern looks.

“What did you do?” he asks in a grumble.

“Me?” Phainon innocently points at himself.

“Did you do something I’m unaware of to anger my people?”

“No, certainly not,” he says. “You see, Mydei, if you ever actually do pay attention to what I say about alphas you’d know. There’s this thing called __”

Phainon rambles, and he tunes him out. He tends to go on these long tirades when it comes to the politics of secondary genders. He already has enough on his mind. Paying attention to this dialogue between alphas and omegas, one he has no knowledge of, never incurred any interest.

The final quint of Parting Hour approaches, and they pass through Marmoreal Palace. The baths are speckled with a few people going about their evenings, soaking into the comfortable waters, feasting on delicate fruits.

“ —Are you listening to anything I’m saying?” Phainon nudges him as the elevator brings them up to the Hero’s Baths, voice tinged with annoyance.

“No.”

He humphs and crosses his arms. “Fine, continue to remain clueless. It’s a perfect look for you after all. The Clueless Prince of Kremnos, only caring when it comes to himself.”

Mydei rolls his eyes. The two disrobe themselves, sparing no customary courtesy of covering themselves with bath house towels or attire. After all, they have this place to themselves. They hardly need to cover their nudity when they are the sole visitors.

“I really don’t understand why you refuse to learn,” Phainon continues. “You know how important it is to everyone. Even you have a scent you know, as muted as it may be.”

His people have told him about it before. They say he smells like bread. Bread of all things. The first time he heard it he scoffed and found it unpleasant. Who wants to go around smelling like a pastry?

“And what does my scent say that I could not, Deliverer?” he bites back. “Such things are ridiculous. I don’t need to rely on these nonsensical ways to detect emotions when I can understand them as clear as day.”

They slink into the hot bath, shoulder to shoulder, and Phainon lets out a pleased groan as his muscles relax.

“Well.” Phainon’s eyes glint. “Dare I say it?”

“What?”

“Oh, maybe I shouldn’t,” he teases, slinging an arm across the ledge behind him, hovering near his shoulders but not quite touching. “I might insult the delicate heart of the crown prince. Then his people will really have my head.”

“My people have plenty of other reasons to be cross with you,” he says.

“Well—” the word clings to the tip of his tongue in his enunciation. Then, he bites his lip in hesitation. “I could tell you liked it when I scented you.”

Mydei snorts. “I know you are bold at times, but not to the point of absurdity.”

“You might say one thing, but I did detect the sweetening of your scent.” He taps the tip of his nose. “This of mine works. Unlike yours. You should trust me more on these things.”

“You are playing mind games with yourself. I know alphas and omegas can’t detect such things within betas. We are stable, unlike you lot.” He

leans away and turns his nose up at the audacity. “I don’t need you to be a hound.”

Phainon barks out a laugh. “I have to disagree! After all, I was as close to the source as I could be.” He shifts forward, invading his space with a grin. “You *liked* it. It’s alright to admit it, Mydei. I understand. I am quite amazing after all.”

“I am told the Deliverer is a humble man,” Mydei says as he shoves his face away. “Why don’t you practice some of that humbleness they speak of?”

Phainon grips his wrist and twists his arm. “I am certainly humble. I listen to the wishes of others, unlike a certain someone who refuses to listen to his dear companions' attempts to assist him.”

“Listening to a hyena speak is akin to surrender.” He grapples Phainon’s arm with his free hand, forcing himself out of the twisting of his arm. Their muscles strain against one another in the beginning of a small bout of wrestling. “And Kremnoans never surrender.”

“Maybe you should try it! It will be a good look for you.” Phainon pushes him back.

They devolve into a slippery match in the baths. The water sloshes around between them as they punch and push. Nothing with any amount of real force—a playful, familiar banter. In the back of his mind, Mydei craves this type of normalcy. Craves the simplicity.

A space where he holds no worry about ruling and governing; a space where he can enjoy himself without the scrutiny and expectations of his people. Where he can enjoy the simple squabble of nonsensical drivel from Phainon.

And, in the back of his mind, he wonders what Phainon must smell like right now. His smile is grand, his laughter echoes through the baths in his exultation. Is it sweet? He’s heard people describe it—something akin to fresh linens toasting underneath the sun sprinkled with a pleasant citrus. Is

it ripening right now? Is it becoming more with every contact of wet skin against skin?

He wants it to be.

Every grip and touch upon his muscles sears with a pleasant heat—especially when the Deliverer presses his hands against his chest. His nipples harden with accidental brushing. His heart rate spikes when he's grabbed by the waist and shoved. And every time he grips him in return, the shape of Phainon clings to his skin. It's… nice. It's nice to be able to grin without worry.

Phainon does that gesture he witnessed earlier—snapping his teeth at him in a playful bite. It's cute in a strange way. If there is a meaning to it, it is lost upon him, but he mimics it in return. In that moment, Phainon flusters, his grip slips, and Mydei uses it against him to gain the upper hand.

Unbeknownst to Mydei, the air laces with sickeningly ripe and potent pheromones; sharp enough to make any alpha scrunch up their face and omega to choke on the headiness. No one will know.

"Okay, okay!" Phainon clamors when he's pinned against the edge of the bath, the ledge digging into his sternum. "You don't smell like fresh honeycakes covered in jam when you're happy!"

Mydei hovers behind him, pinning his arm against his back as he leans in closer to murmur in his ear, "Good. I'm glad you finally see reason, Deliverer."

A shiver travels up Phainon, and he opens his mouth to respond—

A clicking of heels interrupts their contest, and both of them swivel their heads to face the intruder.

"Boys," Aglaea's stern voice carries through the hall. She's dressed in a light robe, ready to bathe in the waters, and carries two extra sets in her arms. "What did I say about bathing in the nude?"

Mydei sinks down so his ass is no longer exposed in the air, then lets go of Phainon.

“That it’s only allowed during Curtain-Fall Hour?” Phainon offers.

“No,” she corrects with exasperation. “That you two are to be respectful and mindful to everyone who wants to partake, and dress yourselves.”

Mydei reclines against the ledge, face flushing in embarrassment as he crosses his arms.

“But no one reserved it. I checked the list before we entered.” Of course Phainon continues to try to find an out. “I wouldn’t be so careless to discard my attire if I knew someone wished to bathe at the same time.”

“And why does the reservation list exist in the first place?” She tosses the extra sets of robes and it lands on their heads. Mydei promptly starts dressing himself.

“That was one time Aglaea! We’ve been good since,” he continues to protest.

“One time is all it takes for rules to be set into place. Hurry up and dress yourself, Cas wishes to join.”

“She does?” Phainon tilts his head, his voice wavering with sudden nervousness.

“Yes.” Aglaea gestures with her hand for him to hurry.

He wraps it around himself, fumbling with the edges of the fabric. For once, the Deliverer has no witty retort. Aglaea calls out to Castorice, and her delicate footfalls thump against the marbled flooring. Maybe his silence comes from the fact Castorice is an omega. Okheman alphas always tend to act odd around them, especially with any amount of revealing skin.

Mydei quite likes the fact Aglaea is a beta like him. It supplies him with an amount of confidence in himself as a leader. She has governed for a millennia, and proved to be effective. If she can, so will he.

And when Castorice steps inside, dipping her feet into the baths a safe distance away, her eyes flicker between Phainon and Mydei.

“It’s good to see you joining us, Miss Castorice,” Phainon says with a forced smile, drawing her attention.

“Likewise, Lord Phainon,” she says and settles in. “It has been a long day.”

And so a light discussion between all parties begins to brew. For Mydei, he always finds it odd how rarely they speak of grueling conquests or the desire for glory of days long past. Instead, they fancy topics about delicious foods, Castorice’s hobby for crochet and writing, and gossip over mundane happenings.

Phainon for once is awkwardly quiet. His attention focuses on his hands clasped on his lap, oddly tense for the banter moments prior. His face is flush from what Mydei assumes to be caused by the heat of the bath.

The Deliverer’s silence bothers him. Normally, by this point, his ears would begin to ring from how loud his voice carries in his excited yapping. Instead, he stares at the water in front of him still as a statue.

Mydei elbows Phainon underneath the water, and he glances over. “Yes?”

“What is wrong with you?”

“Nothing is wrong,” he assures. “I think I’m starting to get a bit too tired to keep up with the conversation.”

“Then retire to your chambers,” Mydei says, though he can sense his lies. The way he holds himself is too stiff, as if he has something else on his mind. But he decides against pressuring him if he’s too uncomfortable to speak on it.

“I think I will.” He stands and bids farewells to the entire group with a smile plastered on his face. Mydei’s gaze trails his departure until he turns the corner and is no more.

Castorice turns her attention to him. “Did something happen between the two of you?”

“Nothing unusual. Why?”

She hums and taps her chin in thought. After a brief moment, she decides to say, “Lord Phainon’s scent is quite strong today.”

“Is it not strong at all times?” he responds dryly.

“Yes, but today is different.” She offers a gentle smile. “It’s nothing to worry about. He must have enjoyed himself today.”

Her refusal to elaborate leaves him frustrated, but he refuses to ask why out of stubbornness. He’s not that interested in whatever the Deliverer fancies from day to day. And he tends to act odd at any given moment. Though, he’s not stupid. The only difference today was the fact he allowed himself to be scented.

Did it seriously make him so happy even Castorice could tell from this distance?

“If you say it is nothing to worry over, then I’ll pay it little mind,” he says, and she covers a giggle behind her hand.

“Maybe you should pay it more mind. After all, Lord Phainon is often hard on himself. Bringing a small piece of joy makes the world a little bit brighter in these trying times. Wouldn’t you agree?”

“I…” Whatever he wanted to say dies before it can be uttered. The scurrying of the High Priestess Tribbie interrupts their conversation, and she cannonballs straight into the baths. The tide from their impact splashes against all of them.

She giggles and proclaims, “We got all of you!”

Mydei wipes the water off his face, watching as Tribbie makes her way to his side and sits on the ledge next to him, splashing her feet in the hot water. He remains quiet as the others speak in earnest about their days, about the

rumors spreading on their teleslates, about how Aglaea wishes to maim Caenis.

“Are you alright, De?” Tribbie asks him suddenly while the other two continue chattering.

“Hm?”

“You seem like you have a lot on your mind.”

“Ah…” He closes his eyes and takes a breath. “It is nothing worth worrying over. Thank you for your concern.”

“If you ever need someone to talk to, know that we are always happy to help!” she beams.

“I appreciate the sentiment, Lady Tribbie.”

When he leaves for home, Castorice’s words continue to echo through his head. They reverberate as he lays on the kline. They scream as he stares at the ceiling when sleep refuses him. He raises a hand forward, tracing the tendons connecting to his knuckles before bringing it down to rub his eyes.

Maybe he can let him do it again…

No, he shouldn’t. These strange alpha omega politics should be avoided at all costs. He already has enough on his plate to worry about—putting his people first, making sure they can integrate into the Holy City. Soften the prejudices against them. Defend against the black tide. Hunt down Nikador and slay him. Those are his first and foremost priorities, not making the Deliverer wag his tail over scenting.

So, with his resolve settled, he continues about his duties as normal. He trains with his people first as is customary for him. A spark of relief flashes through them when he stands beside them, and his scent proves to be untainted.

Before training commences in full, Krateros pulls him aside, a frown marring his features.

“What is it?” Mydei asks.

“Mydeimos,” he begins, his grave tone indicating his disapproval. “I’ve heard rumors and whispers of what occurred yesterday.”

“And what has happened which gives you pause to pull me aside for a private conversation.” He bites back the groan threatening to spill through. He knows exactly what he intends to bring up.

“Do not let that low-born soldier scent you again. It is unbecoming as the crown prince of Kremnos.”

Of course it is. If he didn’t respect his teacher, he would have rolled his eyes and dismissed his impudence.

“How is it so unbecoming? We should show more of our willingness to work together with the Holy City. We can’t let ourselves hold onto this belief of segregation,” he tries to reason.

“Your words would hold merit if he were an omega,” Krateros rebukes. “But he is not. I understand your unwillingness to subjugate yourself to these dynamics, but an alpha scenting is not so easily dismissed. It is a sign of power to the alpha and submission to the recipient. Our people cannot see you in such a light when they already protest your unwillingness to plunder Okhema in rightful glory.”

“Having the Deliverer scent me is hardly a sign of difference in respect and strength. We have already proved ourselves on equal footing with our long conflict which ended with no clear victor.” He grinds his teeth and holds his tongue on speaking about conquests and razing Okhema—their eternal enemy—to the ground, and reaping their wealth.

“If only it were so simple.” He shakes his head. “Our people revere you as their prince, and wish for you to ascend to the throne as king. A king has no equal and stands proud above all. You cannot bow your head and let the authority of an alpha wash over you.”

“I am not,” he says. Images of Phainon’s soft smile after scenting him flicker. Was that really the face of someone imposing a claim? “The Deliverer will never hold such ground over me, this I can promise.”

“Good.” Krateros relaxes as his worries ease. “I am glad you understand.”

But he does not understand. It’s just a smell, one he can’t detect. It lingers in the empty space he can’t breach. It creates unrest within his people—unrest within himself, casting disruptive thoughts, penetrating his structured semblance of peace.

Alpha Kremnoans crowd around him more that day, corralling him into the center of their pile during their training and skirmishes. They request more close quarter combat, brushing upon his skin with an air of pretendful ignorance.

He figures what they attempt to do after an hour: they wish to impart their collective scents upon his skin by proxy. Remind Okhema of his Kremnoan nature and status. Repel any form of idea of integration with their ways of life.

And it irritates him. He pretends their plans go unnoticed for their sake, but a calm fury roils within. This separation his people continue to impose. The desire to return home, to follow the ideals which have driven them to untimely deaths over and over again. Why do they cling to it so readily when Amphoreus trembles upon the brink of annihilation?

What sort of pride can they find when they throw away the last moments of their lives to an endless battle covered in blood instead of enjoying their moments with their kin? Where can pride linger when they perish against an enemy with no beating heart, with a will only knowing destruction, and leave their families behind with an unfillable emptiness? He wants his people to change.

Maybe if he were an omega they would listen to such principles more readily. Maybe if he were an alpha he could exude his will and herd them into his line of thinking. He needs to go speak with Phainon. For the sake of his people, he can’t let the Deliverer scent him again.

His feet carry him to Treasure of Ages as he ruminates, and, from a distance, he spots Phainon appraising antiques with intense scrutiny. The clang of his greaves against polished stone grabs his attention.

“Mydei!” he beams, placing down the amphora. “What brings you here? Excited to see me again are you?”

“Actually, I did come here to find and speak with you,” he answers and folds his arms.

“Oh.” Phainon blinks in surprise. “That’s… always an honor when you do. Do you want to join me for my lunch break?”

“Sure.”

Phainon shouts to Theodoros about his break, and invites Mydei further into the shop, sequestering into a room with a table, chairs, and countertops. Even here antiques litter throughout.

“All of these are fakes, so you don’t have to worry about breaking anything.” Phainon gestures around before digging through a basket, and pulls out fruits and dried meats.

He takes a seat by the table, watching Phainon plate his food and pour juice into a blue goblet. “You know, today I had to deliver the unfortunate news to a client about how her precious heirloom was an imitation relic and not the real thing. It's always so disheartening—I’m not fond of it, but…”

When Phainon sits beside him, his gaze lingers on him with clouded judgement, nostrils flaring subtly with irritation. His spine straightens out and his jaw sets.

“What is it?” Mydei asks.

“Nothing,” he answers too fast and focuses on his plate of food. “I have cheese if you want some.”

Mydei furrows his brow, but says nothing. Instead, he carefully picks at the grapes, making sure to not squeeze hard enough for it to burst. Phainon

shifts in his seat. His leg anxiously bounces as he stuffs his face.

“Are you sure it’s nothing?” Mydei repeats his question seeing the anxiety mountain upon Phainon.

“Yes.” He nods once, tears at a piece of jerky, and chews. “It’s just—well—”

“What?”

“Why do you smell like a bunch of alphas this time?” he huffs childishly, as if the reason he smells like this is because of him. Ironically, he’s not wrong this time.

“My people were not fond of me walking around with the Deliverer’s scent,” he says.

“That’s ridiculous,” he scoffs. “What happened to the whole ‘our scents don’t matter’ rhetoric they always speak of? Surely it shouldn’t matter this much.”

“It shouldn’t,” he agrees. “But, I cannot control what they think.”

“I guess I should be honored they see me as some sort of threat when I am not,” he mutters.

“No. I wish they did not have such viewpoints. Like you said, it is nonsense.”

“Then let me scent you again. That’ll show them—” Phainon dares, then blanches into mortification over what he uttered. “I don’t say that as a means to attack you or your people. Just—Frustrated is all.”

Mydei rolls a piece of cloth between his fingers to wipe away remnants of food. His people would not approve of such a thing. They expect him to comply with the ideals they’ve set upon him. To maintain the image of the crown prince they hold dear; to be the false symbol of a home he never lived in and heard only through songs and stories.

He came here with conviction to deny such a thing from occurring again, yet he can't bring himself to speak it into existence. Maybe, taking on his frustrated suggestion will help them understand his commitment to leading them to Okhema and not back to the ruins of what was once the marvelous city of Castrum Kremnos.

And… maybe he can enjoy the fleeting sensation of warmth tingling and prickling his skin when Phainon approaches him with a tenderness he never received in his violent past dictated by the hand of Strife.

"Go ahead," he decides, gaze flickering to the goblet of juice as his mouth parches.

Phainon sucks in a breath and gapes. "Seriously?"

"Like I said, I don't have issues with it."

He breathes out a laugh, "Because you *like* it."

"I take it back. You cannot scent me," Mydei deadpans.

"Nuh-uh! No taking it back!" He pulls Mydei's chair and brings him closer, the legs scraping against the wooden flooring. "You have to go through with your words."

"I very much regret them." He focuses on the table, ignoring how his ears burn.

Phainon presses against his neck once more, and his heart thuds against his ribs. Goosebumps travel along his arms at the sweet, gentle caresses. And when Phainon's lips brush against his skin, he can feel the smile curled up at the edges. He takes his time, soaking in the sensation, breathing in whatever paltry scent he has to offer.

"Why are you so tense?" Phainon murmurs. This close, his voice sounds impossibly loud even when speaking delicately.

"I'm not tense," he grits out, hands clenching the edges of his seat, the tips of his gauntlets leaving scratches in the wood. "I will hurl you into the wall

if you continue speaking nonsense.”

Phainon’s soft chuckle provokes a shiver to travel down his spine. “My apologies. I will cease in speaking my ‘drivel’ as you so like to put it.” Another caress against his neck, and he swears Phainon puckers his lips to plant a discreet kiss. He dare not mention it. The beating of his heart against his chest pains him. “You’re not breathing though.”

“I am,” he replies almost petulantly, and remembers his body needs air in order to function.

Phainon’s shoulders tremble, and Mydei fears he might burst into laughter. His shaky hand crosses his lap to hold his exposed hip, thumb tracing the bone. A heat settles in the pit of his stomach over the warmth of his palm. Butterflies flap their wings and flutter to his throat.

“If you even think about laughing, I will destroy you,” he mutters underneath his breath, forcing down a swallow.

“Laughing? No-No, definitely not.”

“Then why are you shaking?”

“I’m not shaking.”

“Yes, you are.”

“No, I’m not.”

“You are.”

“Mydei, I will bite you if you don’t stop.”

He elbows him roughly and Phainon lets out a small, “Oof.”

But then he breaks out into a small laugh, and Mydei finds his own lips twitching upwards into a fond smile. The tension seeps away, happiness unfurling like petals greeting the sun as he accepts the added weight on

him. Snow-white hair tickles his cheeks. His nose. His neck. And it feels… nice. Nice in a way he cannot place or name.

Here, hidden in the back of an antique store, he relaxes. Unwinds as Phainon still trembles in his scenting. Mydei takes in a deep breath, the smell of old papers, wood, and clay filtering through his lungs. His eyes slip shut, and he rests his head against Phainon's crown. Phainon momentarily stiffness, the fingers upon his hip pressing into his firm muscle.

He resumes, a purr rumbling through his chest.

A foreign feeling washes over him. It is not akin to the violent piercing of arrows through his flesh. It is not similar to the gasping breaths for life as water clogs his lungs. It is not comparable to the shivering coldness which leaves his lips blue.

Mydei exhales, warmth blooming and spreading all the way down to his fingers.

It's… nice. It brings a lightness he never experienced before. A pleasant sensation tingling up and down his spine with every caress. A nervous spike when Phainon shifts to the other side. A shaky breath when the affection returns. A squeezing of his eyes as he bites his lip.

Is this what intimacy feels like? Sudden and delicate. He fears it will shatter if he dares to press into it. So, he remains stiff as a board, unsure what to do with his hands. He tightly grasps his robes.

His people will be upset. Krateros will reprimand him. But this changes nothing between Phainon and him. There is no magical switch that makes him submit. They are equals, and everyone is daft for not understanding that. It's just a scent he cannot sense.

He cannot… smell it. At all.

A prickling sorrow ebbs through him like a gentle tide coaxing him towards freezing waters. He thought he had grown accustomed to all pain in his life,

but this is new. This leaves no wound which could be treated with a salve. No wound to cover with a bandage. No wound to right with a splint.

If he were an omega… There would be no wound at all. He would breach this unknown world, cross the threshold, and enjoy it for all it can bring. And Phainon would enjoy it more as well. It made more sense for an alpha to do this with an omega. He's never even heard of an alpha desiring to scent a male beta.

He'd even be able to scent him back. Enjoy a closeness he never once had.

"Everything alright?" Phainon whispers as he shifts away, eyes flickering about his face in worry.

"Why wouldn't it be?" he says, surprised over the small lump in the back of his throat, and conceals it.

"You stopped smelling like honeycakes and jam." Phainon traces his fingers along his neck.

Mydei grips Phainon's hand until it turns white and he winces in pain. "I told you I do not smell like a pastry."

"Ouch! Okay, okay—can you let go of my hand? Your gauntlets really hurt!" he whimpers.

"Worry about yourself first, Deliverer," he scoffs and releases his hand.

His tongue feels heavy inside his mouth, and he rubs it against his palette in a meager attempt to quench the dryness. He steals Phainon's cup, and, while Phainon whines about his juice, he drinks.

It is wrong of him to do this—this scenting from an alpha. Especially when he is neither an omega or a female beta. Such things are unbecoming. He gently places the half empty cup down.

"What did you want to talk about?" Phainon asks, and he pales.

“I…” he starts, but the words lodge in his throat. Emotions begin to fray, and he takes in a deep, steadying breath. This, too, is unbecoming of him. He must contain himself.

Phainon uses his pause to resume his meal. But, when he drinks, Mydei’s eyes widen of their own volition—he drinks from the same spot he placed his lips upon.

Does he know what he’s doing? They are suddenly too close. He becomes too aware of the warmth radiating against him. Their legs touching. The lack of distance between their faces. The speckles of grey in his sky-blue eyes. The sun within his golden irises. Upturned lips stained red from pomegranate juice. The—

“Hello? Mydei?” Phainon raises his brow at him, leaning even closer. Their foreheads almost touch. He wants to close the distance. To rest his weary soul in the comfort of the Deliverer. “Are you still with me?” His voice is so pleasant. Low and melodious.

Mydei stands abruptly, gauntlets hammering against the table with a loud thud. He curls his fingers, the tips scratching the wood and collecting slivers.

“We can speak of it later,” he mutters through clenched teeth. How can he say he wishes to not be scented when he already fell?

“Oh,” Phainon eloquently says in the face of his restrained outburst. “Alright. You know I will always make time for you when you wish to speak.”

Mydei throws a vicious glare in hopes of making him cower. Instead, Phainon continues on as if nothing happened, and drinks more from the same spot again. Curse this man for acting so nonchalant. Curse him for imposing these confusing, flustered feelings upon him. A Kremnoan has no need for desiring softness. His entire being is a weapon.

“Hmph. I’ll see you around,” Mydei grumbles, trying to save face, and marches off.

“I’ll come find you during Descent Hour,” Phainon calls out. “I better not catch you napping again!”

“I’ll take back my key if you disturb me,” he threatens in return, and hears Phainon’s muffled laughter bouncing through the hall.

Mydei prepares himself for unbridled disapproval. He has placed himself in a difficult position, but perhaps he can sway the minds of his people with belligerent stubbornness. The very same stubbornness he carried with every step down the winding road of his life.

Chapter End Notes

> hiii! thanks for making it all the way through this <3 i told myself to not write more omegaverse... but here i am... writing more omegaverse... this fic won't be too long. like 3 chapters probably. does anyone even care for alpha/beta or is it just me? There will be smut in the next chapter at least hehe
>
> find me here on twitter!

Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

> “Enough,” Mydei cuts in before Krateros has a chance to interject, before the argument devolves into vicious quarreling, “Kremnoans are prideful in their traditions, and we have always been insular. Unless you intend to challenge and defeat every willing soldier, you will not be considered as one. Even then I doubt you will be graced with the courtesy of recognition.”
>
> Phainon scrutinizes him before asking quietly, “Is that what it will take?”
>
> “I— What?”
>
> “Is that what it will take?” Phainon repeats with more determination.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

As he steps out towards the front of Treasure of Ages, the light from Kephale’s Dawn Device soaks him with its warm rays. He inhales a deep breath, unwinding himself from the bizarre interaction from mere moments ago. To his left, Theodoros hums and busies himself with adjusting the display painted dolias.

A tinge of guilt pinches him. He did accidentally put a few scratches and cracks into the man’s table without reason. Well, that’s not true. Much to his embarrassment, Phainon’s inappropriate behavior aggravated him to the point of acting out. Finding a priest of Oronyx to help fix his mistake becomes a high priority.

“Theodoros,” he says and approaches the man.

“Lord Mydei!” he jumps to attention. “A pleasure to see you, as always. The dolia depicting you has been selling extraordinarily well!”

The statement leaves him perplexed, but the prideful side of him basks in the unsolicited compliment. After all, he is the greatest warrior in Okhema. The Deliverer can protest the notion all he wants, but in the end he will claim victory. Just like how he’s currently ahead in their competitions.

“I wager you must assume only Kremnoans purchased the works, but I’ll have you know they’ve been quite popular with Okhemans as well.” Theodoros grins, pride etched into his words. Though, after a moment, his demeanor falters and he staggers a small step backwards.

“Is there something wrong?” Mydei asks.

“N-Not at all.” He clears his throat. “I—ah— didn’t mean to act so surprised! I— Are congratulations in order?”

“Congratulations for what?” He tries to hide his incredulousness, but his brow pinches in confusion.

“Lord Phainon’s…” He gestures vaguely, redness creeping up his cheeks then he coughs into his hand.

Ah, that’s right. Theodoros is an omega—he must be smelling Phainon’s pheromones upon him. Though, his reaction adds on to his befuddlement. Scenting is a common ritual, he shouldn’t be acting so odd.

“I wanted to tell you the table in the back has been lightly damaged. I will be requesting the services of an Oronyx priest to come and mend it, so you need not worry,” he says, deciding it best to move on with the subject and not linger.

His words have the opposite intended effect, for Theodoros’s face reddens even more and he chokes on his tongue. “I— Thank you for the kind gesture!”

“Right,” he says, he must be missing some vital piece of information for his peculiar behavior.

“You’re still here?” Phainon interrupts from behind as he steps out and parks himself beside the counter. “I didn’t realize you’d stick around because you missed me so much.”

“I was simply telling Theodoros about how I will be finding a priest to repair the damage I left, and I will be on my way,” he scoffs at his impudence, annoyance building with every repeating of his plan.

“Are you sure?” Phainon continues to tease with an amused lilt in his voice. “I wouldn’t mind if you stayed for a bit longer. You know, it’s quite nice when you wait for me.”

As pleasant as staying sounds, his royal responsibilities demand attention and loitering about a shop will not aid him. Plus, Theodoros adds on an awkwardness with how fast his eyes dart between the two of them. What is with him today?

“I—” He turns on his heel to face him, ready to argue, but he loses track of everything he wants to say when he sees how Phainon regards him. He leans against the countertop bearing a soft smile similar to the one from the day before; so tender is his gaze—so absolutely lost in his own little world. It strips every layer of armor, peels it until he’s left transparent. And for once he wishes he wore more clothes upon his person.

“What is it?” Phainon tilts his head. “Have you perhaps decided to stay?”

Is it even appropriate for him to stare in such a way? Before Mydei can process his own thoughts, his body reacts with a will of its own. He clenches his hand into a tight fist and hits Phainon’s face. Well, he tries too—Phainon is too seasoned of a warrior for a clumsy surprise attack to land.

“Now, that’s just rude!” Phainon lets out a faux gasp before laughing.

“*Haikas*,” Mydei grumbles underneath his breath before marching off once again, ignoring the small yelp from Theodoros. He can’t let Phainon keep

flustering him like this, but he can’t help his reactions.

“I— Uh… Congratulations, Lord Phainon?” He hears Theodoros say the same dastardly thing again.

“No need for congratulations. We’re… We’re not like that,” Phainon answers, using the polite tone when being professional.

And what is that supposed to mean—not like *what*? His neck burns where Phainon scented him, and he rubs at it, the coolness of metal a welcomed relief. He’s missing something crucial. Of course he must be. No one has acted so strangely towards him before this scenting ritual.

As he traverses down the street, his hair stands on end. Eyes upon eyes upon eyes land on him, and his skin crawls with every pointed stare. Years of living in constant danger trained his senses to detect such attention.

Every step he takes, his confidence slowly dwindles. He wants to scoff, to roll his eyes at the unwanted attention like he always has before. Ever since he walked through the gates of Okhema, strife followed in his footsteps. And, as the prince of strife, he understood how to bear the burden.

Many wished to spout opinions about his mantle; of how they perceived him as a brutish barbarian feasting upon the blood of his enemies. Every tartly whisper about his reputation came from a place of expectation and he cared little for baseless gossiping.

But this—it’s far more intimate. Something he is unfamiliar with, yet everyone else around dangerously so. They spy invisible traces upon his neck, taking in what he cannot. And that unwelcome, ugly despair roots itself in him. What he thought right chips away with every concealed point and hushed whispers. However, his temperament never betrays his internal struggles.

When he speaks to a priest of Oronyx about the repairs, she regards him with barely concealed awe, and he finds his sorrow prickling with frustration.

“Is that Lord Phainon’s scent upon you?” she dares to ask as if he could detect it. As if he could enjoy it as much as she does.

“Here are the coins for you to perform your miracles.” He places the Balance Coins upon her outstretched hand.

She at the very least understood he has no interest in answering her.

He stops by the Kremnoan district, and converses with a few of his generals and sergeants. The betas speak with him like they always have: an air of politeness, reverence, and ease. They not once raise their brow at him or barely contain their sneers.

The alpha and omegas are another story. They try to conceal their opinions, but they cannot hide the way they recoil at the scent upon him. How the omegas almost choke on their breaths and the alphas scowl. How they grumble underneath their breaths in disapproval.

He is not afraid of their reactions, for such a word does not exist in the Kremnoan language. He does not shorten their conversations, nor does he flee from the disdain hovering throughout. He ignores the chain of whispers traveling down from alpha to beta. He bears their scowls with indifference.

But deep within, he hates and angers. Hates how he alone enjoys the intimacy shared with the Deliverer. Hates how no one from his fallen homeland can spare joy for him and this bond. Hates how his simple desire creates so much strife.

But, perhaps they sneer with disdain because he is no omega. There is no real bond to speak of, and there never will be. It is not right for him to want such a thing. To crave the impossible. There will never be a moment in time where he can indulge himself in the lavish scent of the Deliverer.

When he stops by the Fruit and Veg Store to procure supplies for dinner, the old woman named Demetria bears a slight glimmer in her eye when she hands him the pomegranates he purchased on the daily from her, and it discomforts him.

“Do you require assistance with anything?” he asks as a formality, and in an attempt to dissuade her from indulging in her thoughts.

“Where is that friend of yours?” She glances around for Phainon. “You two come together quite often, yet he is here only in scent.”

“We are not inseparable,” he grumbles, already wishing to depart, but cannot bring himself to be so rude.

“Some might question such a statement. Though, it is sweet you have finally let him scent you. I could tell he has been wanting to for quite a while.”

Ah, the butterflies return at the affirmation. If only he could pluck out their wings to cease their fluttering.

“How… Can you tell?” He settles the pomegranates on top of the cabbage and carrots in his calathus—a basket woven from reeds he likes to carry his groceries in—trying to hide his unease.

“Life must be difficult as a beta,” she muses. “The way an alpha carries himself, the way scents change. The older we get, the easier it is to tell these subtleties. Tell me, did he look happy once it was done?”

And his gut twists in remembrance of Phainon leaning against the counter bearing the fondest look he’s ever seen. If only he was allowed to remain, but his duties took priority.

“I fail to see the connection,” he grumbles. “I’m no omega to enjoy such things and sharing scents, from what I understand, is a common occurence.”

“You’re right,” she hums a laugh. “It must be lonely to not be able to perceive the colors of your friend.”

“How can I miss and long for a color I cannot name?” he says. “I have lost nothing for my lack of perception.”

“But is that true when most around you can— especially for the most important person in your life— and you can’t?” she returns the question

back to him with the wisdom of a woman who has lived far more years than he. “If you were an alpha or omega, would you want to return the scenting?”

The audacity! The gall! Naming the Deliverer as someone so precious as to rank above all others. If he were a brute like the rumors want to believe, he would have spat out his shock.

“You are mistaken,” he calmly says instead, avoiding the poisoning of his mind with her musings. “We are rivals. Brothers in arms. To speak as if we are beyond anything than that would stoke false rumors.”

Demetria laughs and shakes her head. “I see. Ah, to be young again.”

He is about to question her—defend his statement—but she interrupts by handing a few figs, the ones whose prices have soared for their scarcity.

“I can’t accept this,” he says.

“Consider it as a thank you for supporting my shop. Your patronage has boosted my sales—the Kremnoans follow your footsteps straight to my pomegranates." She dispels the argument with a laugh, and waves her hand.

“Thank you,” he manages to say, fighting the urge to continue this dreadful conversation, and takes her dismissal with reluctance.

Her accusations are false. Never would an alpha take interest in a beta. He understands how perfect the omega is for the alpha. It’s nothing a beta can compare to. He needs no hopes for anything more, and he doesn’t. It is merely a friendly gesture.

And why should he hope? The Deliverer is his rival first and foremost—an annoying one at that. How many times has he wished harm upon that man? Too many times have they beaten one another bloody in their sparring, encouraging to not hold back and enjoy the thrill. The rushing of blood, wide grins taunting for more.

But the nagging question eats at him. If he were more than what he is, would he scent the Deliverer in return? Would Phainon be… happy… if he did? His grip tightens on his calathus, splintering the reeds underneath the tips of his gauntlets, and he throws such thoughts away before they anchor. No matter how hard his heart beats, there is no reason to dwell on the thought of caressing Phainon's neck for scenting. No reason to imagine Phainon bearing his scent, marking his claim for all to know. Then those omegas from the market wouldn't giggle and beckon him over.

There is no reason at all.

☼

With supplies for dinner procured, he returns home. Away from stares tracing the invisible scent upon him. Away from the eyes which glimmer with knowledge he lacks. Perhaps he should have remained resolute in the face of the Deliverer's pestering and denied his begging.

As he turns the corner, he pauses in his stride. There, underneath the archway of his home, Krateros leans against the pillar, arms crossed and a stern look upon his visage. A tightness envelops his chest, but he continues on with confidence.

"Krateros," he greets. "To what do I owe your company so late in the evening?"

The older man peers through his one working eye, scrutinizing him before lifting himself upright. "Mydeimos. It is good to see you return. Let us speak in private."

Mydei controls his body to show no reaction. Not even a twitch breaks through. He steps forth and enters his residence, Krateros following close behind.

They travel towards the back, past the communal area bearing a painted mural of Nikador, the closed curtains concealing his bed from the ever-present light, and the small luxury of a private bathroom. The spartan nature of his abode speaks of his migratory, wild lifestyle of days past. The few things he owned were gifted from Castorice, the triplets, or forced onto by Phainon.

They enter the kitchen—the air tinged with the flavor of smoke from frequent use— and he drops his groceries off at the counter. Dinner must wait.

“It appears you have not kept your promise,” Krateros starts, making his way beside the table. “A disappointment which is unbecoming of you.”

Mydei sucks in a breath, fighting his indignant thoughts before he answers, “I understand why you regard it as such, but I don’t think you understand my intentions.”

“Your intentions hold little value in the name of how things are. Nothing is more important than the legacy and tradition of Castrum Kremnos,” he answers with a gruffness spelling his disappointment. “You, of all people, should know as such.”

“I know them well,” Mydei answers, keeping the bitterness out of his mouth. “But times have changed. We cannot keep clinging to the past until our nails splinter and fingers bleed.”

“Why did you let him do it?” Krateros cuts straight to the point, and a part of Mydei would appreciate him speaking plainly if he were not dreading the subject. “Why did you fold so easily to that alpha errand boy?”

The tightness of his chest returns, and he bites the side of his tongue between his molars. He flexes his grip, tensing and relaxing, transfixed by how the joints of his gauntlets allow for flexibility.

“Because,” he says, resting his hand against the limestone countertop. “I have stated it before, I wish for our people to accept our residency into Okhema. They need to learn this new way of life, or it will be our undoing.

The council has been gracious to let us—conquerors as Amphoreus knows us—inside their delicate walls. A peace is maintained here between all the different cultures, and I believe we can thrive here as well if we give it a proper chance."

"You did not answer my question," he presses what Mydei desperately avoids. "Or have you been spending too much time with that witch? Have her luxuries and opulence altered your perception away from the realities we bear, and softened you into a cub?"

"No," he refutes quickly. "What I say are my own words. Never will I repeat claims made by another. I only speak for the wellbeing of all Kremnoans."

"You say never, yet you fell on the blade of your promise so readily. So, answer me, Mydeimos, why did you let that boy have his way with you?"

A fury grips Mydei at the insinuation of Phainon making a mockery of him. The moment in the antique shop was nothing of such—it held a gravitas of companionship he never had. His being craved the closeness, the gentleness of soft hair tickling him, the warmth spreading throughout him.

But he answers naught, for how can a Kremnoan speak of such softness when his body is a weapon for destruction? To admit to these gentle notions is akin to speaking of weakness. And weakness is tantamount to death.

"Your silence leaves much to be desired," Krateros dismisses his idleness. "So, instead, tell me this. *Where* did he scent you?"

A chill runs down his spine. What other ways are there to scent a person? There were multiple ways in the first place? Every straying thought tells him the truth will awaken something he does not wish to face. His hand twitches, yet he refuses to bashfully lift it to trace his jugular.

"I…" he murmurs first, then faces Krateros with confidence. "My neck."

If he thinks hard enough, he can still feel the sensation of Phainon close within his space. The soft brushes of skin upon skin and how pleasant it

felt. That imagined moment of him leaving a kiss upon his neck. How his body relaxed into the touch, and his soul sang to the sun.

“Hmph. Despicable,” Krateros scoffs. “And *how* did he apply his scent?”

He breaks eye contact, and fixes his gaze upon his purchased goods. He does not wish to answer something so intimate. Something he wants to keep to himself, and for no one else to know of. Reluctance involuntarily paints his features with gentle strokes.

“Is that really so important?” He plucks the pomegranates out of his calathus, arranging them in a clay bowl of older fruits. He may be able to stay his hand, but the brush dips its bristles into a soft hue of red, and continues to dictate his expressions.

“It is. These things are important rituals,” Krateros says, a slow bloom of realization dawning upon him as he takes in his prince.

“He,” Mydei sucks in his bottom lip and scrapes it against his teeth, “with his… face.”

“I see.” The air between them hangs thick and unnerving. And even someone as clueless as him knows what he uttered was wrong. Blasphemous, perhaps, to some.

“You cannot—”

The door bursts open, and he jumps to alertness at the loudness, fists clenched and ready to fight.

“Mydei!” Phainon greets with a grin as bright as the sun, and makes his way towards him, unaware of Krateros’s presence. “Finally found you! You sneaky little rascal, hiding away in your kitchen. At least I didn’t have to wake you from your napping. I was readying myself to lift the kline with you in it.”

“Deliverer,” Mydei sternly says, and he stiffens. Phainon’s gaze sweeps across and notices the extra company.

“Krateros. My apologies. Did I interrupt a conversation?” He switches to his polite tone—the one he uses in front of most—and straightens out his back and shoulders.

“You did. A very private and important conversation.” Krateros keeps Mydei pinned, then shifts his attention over. “Leave. We have not finished our discussion.”

“I—” A frown tugs at him, fighting the impulse to stay by Mydei’s side. “I understand. I apologize for bursting into Mydeimos’s room at such an inappropriate time.”

“Indeed.”

Phainon shifts on his foot, and throws Mydei a sideways glance. And Mydei wishes he could remain. He wishes he did not need to deal with the consequences of acquiescing to Phainon’s frustrations without a fuss. If he were true to his word, none of this would be happening.

“Leave,” he says what he wishes to not.

“Can we meet later?” The hopefulness in his voice is not lost upon Mydei. Even through the formal tone, it is whispered in such a delicate, fragile way, that it pains to deny him. The wound which cannot be touched deepens, carved by the knife of duty.

“No. Tonight, I have other concerns which need to be addressed.” He crosses his arms, protecting himself from the truth he hides.

“Right,” Phainon says, the smile gracing him not reaching his eyes. “I suppose I shall see you tomorrow then.”

Mydei says nothing in return, and watches him leave. But, to his surprise, Phainon turns around underneath the archway.

“You know,” he begins, and Mydei knows that tone of voice, the one where Phainon can’t let something rest, “I think it is rather unfair you two are talking about me in private.”

“How did you…?” Mydei’s breathing stutters for a mere moment from surprise.

“It’s rather obvious,” Phainon says defiantly as he steps forward. “I think I can pick up a thing or two when everyone on my way over looks like they want to skewer me with spears and throw me into the abyss.”

Mydei rubs his forehead at the petulance. This is not what he needs right now, not another reason for Krateros to bark his reprimands.

“I don’t understand— we have fought one another to a draw. I thought such things held value in Kremnoan traditions.”

“Hmph. You may have done such things, boy, but you are an outsider. You are not, and never will be, Kremnoan,” Krateros scoffs in response. “You will never understand what it means to be one, no matter how hard you try.”

The hurt etched onto Phainon at the declaration pains Mydei further. Phainon has never been one to restrain himself from how he feels, he wears them upon his sleeves. The words gouge him deep, but they don’t deter him. He never falters, always pushing forward.

“That’s–!” Phainon huffs, “That’s ridiculous. I know you are an advisor, but who made you arbiter of what it means to be Kremnoan? I have proven myself to be an equal to Mydei—” Krateros’s jaw tenses and nostrils flare as he inhales sharply at the casual way he refers to Mydei “—through our duel, which, might I remind you, ended in a draw. What other means must I take to prove myself as a warrior?”

“Enough,” Mydei cuts in before Krateros has a chance to interject, before the argument devolves into vicious quarreling, “Kremnoans are prideful in their traditions, and we have always been insular. Unless you intend to challenge and defeat every willing soldier, you will not be considered as one. Even then I doubt you will be graced with the courtesy of recognition.”

Phainon scrutinizes him before asking quietly, “Is that what it will take?”

“I— What?”

“Is that what it will take?” Phainon repeats with more determination.

“That… That was not an invitation,” Mydei stumbles, he said that as a throwaway statement, not as a lifeline!

Phainon thinks his words over, grimness tugging at the corner of his lips, before saying, “I see. Then, I think I will be taking my leave. Have a good night.”

The two quietly watch Phainon depart, his footfalls thudding against tesserae flooring. The door opens, and closes. The room remains deathly still.

Once Krateros makes up his mind he speaks, “Do not let him use your ignorance of these dynamics. He is taking advantage of you.”

The notion seems almost laughable. The Deliverer taking advantage of him? Preposterous.

“He is doing no such thing,” Mydei says. “Phainon is not the type of person to do that.”

“Hmph, perhaps you should educate yourself in the ways of an alpha.” Krateros closes the distance between them. “You reek of him, and he continues to try to pull you in with his innocent demeanor. Pretending he does not know what his actions entail. He is attempting to claim through your ignorance and folly, and upend the ways of our people.”

His words sting with truth, Phainon knows far more about this than him. Before this, he didn’t know of the different ways of scenting. But a side of him preens with knowledge of being claimed; it warms and soothes, for perhaps Phainon wants him close.

“An alpha making such a bold move for a beta is laughable behavior. They twist themselves for omegas in hopes of finding their true mates. This must be the plans of Aglaea to extend her controlling reach,” Krateros reasons to convince his prince.

And the icy river washes over him once more. He doubts Aglaea has any such plans. After all, he is the one who ordered Phainon to scent him after much incessant whining. But the fact remains: he is no omega. Confusion rattles and sweeps through him, grabbing his throat and squeezing.

Krateros glares before heaving a sigh. “I do not fault you for your lack of awareness. You were denied a rightful upbringing as a proper crown prince. You had no time to brush up on this knowledge when conflict was a constant beneath our feet, and you presented as a beta. What was once a blessing has turned into trouble.”

Even if Krateros speaks harshly, he always has the best intentions in mind. They disagree on many things, but his kindness in this moment is not lost upon Mydei. He can’t remain with his vision clouded by darkness. Every guess and wonderment leads to a solution of nothing.

“Your concerns are heard,” Mydei says carefully. “Perhaps it is time I invested myself into this knowledge.”

Krateros remains stiff and tense. “Do not fall for an alpha playing the pretense of prey. They are beasts who need to be contended with.” He clamps his hand upon Mydei’s shoulder. “You are the lion. It is time for you to bare your fangs and claws; exert your strength to rake and tear.”

The words split him in half. Years of upbringing with Kremnoan ideology tell him he is right; but, that quiet part of him wishes to brush it off. To go back to the privacy enclosing just the two of them in a quiet, small room. To bask in one another's presence not in the violent punches and slamming of sword upon metal, but the tender, soft touches of companionship he craves.

And that damned fluttering of his heart overtakes him at the thought. He winces and shakes his head. Krateros cannot be truly correct in his statements, but there may be a sliver of truth to grasp. He cannot desire for such intimacies, for he is no omega. He is no fated partner to an alpha.

“I will look over texts,” he says. “And come to my own conclusions. I will see if the things you speak of are true.”

“Such is your duty,” Krateros says. “As much as I wish for you to take my words at face value, it is noble of you to seek out information on your own right.”

Krateros, seemingly satisfied, departs with a nod of his head. Mydei leans against the counter on his hands, fingers splayed, and takes a deep, steadying breath.

There is only brotherhood between Phainon and him. To desire the tenderness would mean to set himself up for disappointments; ones he cannot carry in the face of all of his responsibilities. Perhaps, if he were an omega, such things would be more palatable to consider. More reasonable.

Mydei grips a pomegranate, projecting such thoughts onto the fruit. He crushes it, watching the arils burst, and soak the bronze metal of his gauntlet with red. The juice drips between his fingers, down into tiny puddles on the countertop.

He squeezes harder until chunks break apart, collapse, and only a small clump of white flesh studded with seeds rests on his palm.

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In the morning, he lethargically goes about making his breakfast; three eggs are cracked over the pan, meat is seared, and vegetables lay on the side. A well balanced meal. Every motion he takes sways with laziness, dragging his feet through mud.

Nerves tremble through him at the thought of reading any sort of text on alphas and omegas, and he can’t quite place why. All he understands is the pit nestled into the bottom of his stomach makes it difficult to eat.

He stabs through the cut dromas meat with a fork, and presses it into his mouth. Every bite and chew is deliberate. He swallows, and fights the

lurching of his stomach. He knows there should be no reason to feel this way, and no matter how hard he tries to reason it away, it sinks its talons deeper and refuses to let go.

Mydei manages to finish his entire meal, downing it with his favorite drink of pomegranate juice with goat milk. Even that goes down unpleasantly, but it helps the heavy food slide.

To soothe his woes, he convinces himself today he will not see Phainon; today, he will go to the private library afforded to Chrysos Heirs through Aglaea and learn. Normally, if he wishes to read, he'd simply go to a book store and purchase scrolls on the histories of Amphoreus. The stacks of them in his bedroom are a testament to that.

Instead of joining the other Kremnoans in either the training grounds or gymnasium, he travels down the cobblestone path. His people question his destination, and are bemused over his response of the library. Most of them care little for such things, but understand the importance of knowledge.

Speaking to the librarian is out of the question. He cannot divulge this embarrassing information of him seeking to understand the biology of omegas and alphas. His anxiety spikes at the mere thought, and he would like for his food to remain in his stomach.

He gazes at a multitude of scrolls and tablets. Papyrus and parchment; clay and stone. Rows upon rows. Columns upon columns. They intrigue his interest, but he refrains from indulging himself in the captivating histories inscribed upon them. He has his strict mission to adhere to.

After what feels like five quints of searching, he finds a section of biology pertaining to his interests. He delicately takes a few scrolls and tablets in his arms, and finds a table.

He unfurls the first scroll and reads. It speaks on the simple factors of life: scent glands on the neck and arms which he knows, but the inner thighs surprise him. He spares a quick glance at his legs, then shakes his head.

It continues on to speak of presenting, and how arduous it potentially can be. Volatile emotions, bodies changing and restructuring through painful means varying from person to person. Especially for female alphas and male omegas. He winces over the painful texts, and wonders if his body never presented because of his healing factor.

The scroll within his hand flaps down on the table as he scratches his stomach, gauntlets tracing the firm muscle of his abdomen towards his side. If that were the case, then his curse of immortality went further than he thought. If his status as a beta stayed because of the intense, rapid healing factor and never letting his organs develop and ripen… If he were to actually be an omega…

A dimness crests his visage, and he maneuvers his hand back to grasp at the end of the scroll. Such meandering thoughts are unbecoming of him. He's never cared for presentations before. But the little voice in the back of his head whispers of how his life would be easier, how it would make more sense, and how…

He swallows down the lump in his throat.

How his connection with Phainon would go deeper than comrade in arms. More than what is allowed now. Sure, he believes him to be the only man who is worthy of having his back, but there is a whole world he is barred from. That intimate connection between alphas and omegas goes deeper than words and flesh. It is a bond so deep it can never be described in speeches.

Poets wax, songstresses sing, and orators captivate with their stories of the omega and alpha joining in union. They jingle the possibility of true mates; a bond so pure it can move mountains and part oceans.

Mydei rolls up the scroll and moves to the next, stuffing those thoughts away. He has no desire for such things. He can't.

The next text he finds dull. It speaks of ruts and heats—a topic he is more familiar with considering how many headaches it gave him when the Kremnoan Detachment travelled around Amphoreus. Memories of

frustration over his best warriors being incapacitated and perverted makes him put the book away. He doesn’t need to read over this. And he will never admit the anatomical diagrams fluster him too much.

The longer he reads, the more the ink on papyrus blurs. Truly, the subject is dull with the dry, intellectual language. He finds many things ranging from the different types of scents to matin bites. A strange, old Okheman ritual of alphas hunting omegas for mating during the Era Chrysea—before the titans of Strife, Trickery, and Death made the frolicing unacceptable.

While the information is useful, it lacks what he needs: how these rituals translate between peers and the underlying societal meaning of those activities. He picks another scroll, unfurling it with a bored scowl. Yet more dry, intellectual ramblings to parse through.

“Lord Mydei?” Castorice peeks around a bookshelf, and he jumps out of his skin, juggling the scroll to save it from dropping to the floor.

“Castorice!” he exclaims in embarrassment. He clears his throat, trying to steady the rapid beating of his heart. “What… What are you doing here?”

“I often visit and find things to read.” She joins him on the opposite side of the table, eyes tracing the text of a loose scroll. “I didn’t expect to find you here.”

“I… was doing research,” he says and hopes the embarrassment of his tone has tapered.

She picks up one of the scrolls, and smiles to herself. “Are you perhaps trying to understand more about second genders?”

“Is that an issue?” He crosses his arms, defending the vulnerability placed on display.

“It’s not,” she assures. “I think it’s a good thing you’re finally gaining an interest in these things. There is much for you to learn, and I think it will help you with understanding your people better.”

He grumbles a sigh. “I understand them well enough. I have been around them for more than half my life.”

“Of that I have no doubt, but this is a different type of understanding. One that is more personal, and closer to the soul rather than the physical nature of war.” She picks another scroll, and skims across the text.

She has a point. One he can begrudgingly agree with. He relaxes, and flicks one of the parchments, watching it roll away from him. The awkwardness of this topic continues to bother him, but if he has to have this conversation with one person, at least a gentle soul like Castorice is palatable.

“I’ve read through much already,” he says, easing out of his tense disposition. “Though, it lacks a more societal explanation of things.”

“Societal?”

“Yes. These texts speak of biology, and why things function the way they do. It hardly discusses what the things I see in the day to day mean.”

Castorice brings a hand to her chin in thought, then ventures, “Like what scenting means?”

Heat creeps back his cheeks, and he desperately tries not to stutter, “Y-Yeah. That.”

She giggles behind her hand. “There is nothing to be ashamed about, Lord Mydei. It’s natural to be curious.”

“This… is not a *thing* Kremnoans talk about. What we value is the art of the battlefield; the strategies we employ, and the ruthless tactics for victory. Not any of this,” he gestures with a hand, “nonsense. This is considered stereotypical Okheman behavior.”

“Is that why you’re here all alone, and not asking for guidance?” She skewers him with practiced ease.

Ugh, he hates it. Is he truly so predictable?

“... Yes. Having these discussions would be considered far out of character, and many would not indulge.” He leans on his elbow, and shadows his eyes behind his hand.

“I see.” She softens with a hint of pity, and it annoys him. “I’m happy to assist you in these ‘Okheman ways’ then. Perhaps, if you are willing, I can bring a few… novels I am quite fond of to help you understand these things.”

“If you think it will be of help,” he says with a begrudging sigh. “I will not deny your aid.”

“I will return with a couple of my favorites then. The genre of romance is a really good way to understand the nuance of— Oh, Lord Mydei, don’t make such a face!” Her giggles brighten.

“There is no word for ‘romance’ in the Kremnoan language,” he mutters stiffly and fixes his expression.

“Perhaps you will invent it after reading my recommendations,” she says with an accent of amusement. “I’ll be right back.”

And so he waits, face buried into a hand as he groans. Great, now his mission includes reading dreadful romantic stories. It certainly can’t get any worse than this. At least the Deliverer will never know. He must never know.

The empty seats before him fill with memories of his fallen friends. If they were here, they would tease him, rib his cluelessness, and appease him with answers. He would have felt at ease in asking these sorts of questions. They have always looked after him.

The illusions of his old friends vanish with Castorice’s return. She sits across him, places two scrolls down, and pushes them forward with the tips of her fingers. Once her hands retract, he picks one up, unfurls it a few inches, and squints at the title.

“These are very traditional alpha and omega stories. I think you will enjoy them,” she says, then points to the one on the table. “This one depicts a true mate bond. It will help you understand more on scenting and the implications, as well as the intricacies of a mating bite and nesting. While that one—” she gestures to the one he holds “ —is from the perspective of an alpha. From what I understand, it’s quite accurate.”

“I will take your word for it.” The scroll weighs heavy in his hand so he sets it down. “May I ask a personal question of you?”

“Of course. What’s on your mind?”

“Forgive me if this is rude. If you do not wish to answer I will understand.” He pauses, and finds the words to continue, “If you were to scent me as a friend, how would you do it?”

“Ah.” Her smile pinches at the corners, and her hand stiffens. “I don’t mind answering. I’ve often thought of such things myself; how it would feel to share my scent, and bear others upon my person.

“But, to answer you, I would apply it on your wrist from my own.” She turns her hand over, and presses her fingers down the tendons of her arm. Her fingers lightly twitch of their own volition. “That is most customary between companions. And if we were closer—like how you are with Phainon—it would be considered normal for me to scent your neck with my wrist.”

“I… see…” His throat runs dry, trying to not let memories of Phainon’s closeness overtake him.

“Is that an issue? You look a bit pale.”

“No. It’s no issue.” He shakes his head, snapping himself out of his daze. “Thank you for answering me. I never wish to remind you of your curse in such a crude, selfish manner.”

“You worry too much,” she says. “I’ll be alright. Though, If I may ask in return—did Lord Phainon scent your neck?”

“He… did,” he answers.

“No wonder he was so happy then.” Her features brighten to an incredible degree. “Even through all of his bluster, I can see how much you mean to him. Even if you did not know the meaning entirely, I’m sure you understood the intimacy to some extent.”

Maybe… Maybe Phainon did take advantage of him. The way he scented now seems completely inappropriate considering their stations. He should have used his wrist, right? The question hangs on the tip of his tongue, but he refuses to continue the conversation. Elaborating on the intimacy invites too much scrutiny.

“I did,” he says curtly, then begins to gather his borrowed texts. “Thank you for your assistance. I will read these in the privacy of my home.”

“Tell me what you think about them,” she beams in her unique, gentle way. It’s always nice to see her express such joy, for her life to not be a cocoon of misery.

“It’s the least I can do,” he says in earnest, and escapes after they exchange farewells. There is only so much embarrassment he can handle.

☼

His day drones on as he is forced to sit in the amphitheater of Dawncloud. Leadership of previous city-states as well as Okhema’s own domestic governance gathers to discuss and debate the runnings of the city on a smaller scale. A few citizens perch against the seats, raising a keen ear to their discussions.

He stands beside Aglaea who maintains her neutral disposition, never once letting her emotions through in her words. Though, how much of it is because of her curse he cannot say. The topic of the black tide is spoken: a

recent sighting near the southern entrance of the city which was efficiently dismantled by Castorice.

“I would like for us to station more guards in the area as a precaution,” Aglaea says.

“The city is in need of guards throughout to maintain order. We cannot spare the extra headcount on baseless frets,” her rival, Caenis, speaks out against her. “Or is this an acknowledgement that your underling has done a poor job and you require additional aid from us regular people to handle the troubles your precious Chrysos Heirs fail to?”

“It would be unwise to leave things to chance when we can increase our defenses temporarily for a week's worth of time. The black tide is dangerous and unpredictable, no matter how thorough we are,” Aglaea counters.

The crowd murmurs, some acknowledging the threat, for they had their own tumultuous encounters before finding sanctuary in Okhema.

Caenis narrows her eyes. “You already exude plenty of influence throughout the city; our guards maintain a valuable effort in defense throughout the entire city, as well as the location you are allegedly worried for. This is a petty attempt at inducing our colleagues with fear to extend your reach where it is not needed.”

“Then let the Kremnoans offer a hand in this issue,” Mydei says. “My people itch to rise from their listless stations. If there is the potential for conflict, they will be more than willing to be at the ready.”

Aglaea hides her smile as Caenis chokes back a displeased grunt. “And how can we trust Kremnoans with Okhema’s safety in mind?”

“We are citizens like everyone else here. There are no better warriors than my tribe, and I, as crown prince Mydeimos, swear they will defend with honor in their hearts and steel in their hands.”

The crowd murmurs throughout the amphitheater, at first hesitant, but in the end, they decide to allow the Kremnoans to bolster defenses in the potentially endangered area. His ears prick towards the wanton whispers naming them “brutes” and “savages” who are only good for wetting their hands with blood. The meeting moves on to other dry subjects, ones he has little opinion for, and patiently waits for it to conclude.

All of these people love to hear themselves talk, droning on and on about this or that. If he weren’t trained for this, his eyes would glaze over and his mind wander. Well, it does that from time to time, but he manages to catch himself.

At the very least, he can appreciate the fact that Okhema treats these discussions with a reverence. Any alpha and omega must wear scent patches upon their necks and wrists as to not influence one another, and to not let themselves lay their feelings bare.

Caenis picks at the one on her neck when she’s irritated. Usually the tick occurs after a bout with Aglaea. And at times like these, he is thankful for his status as a beta. Never must he worry over concealing a scent, or have precarious instincts sway his thinking.

The meeting adjourns into the first quint of Parting Hour. A few straggling questions caused it to spill into overtime, and everyone had to remain in place until all parties were satisfied. He has half a mind to begin reading those books Castorice recommended to him.

“Thank you, Mydeimos,” Aglaea says as they walk down the long road of the Forecourt and towards the entrance.

“For what?”

“Offering to assign the Kremnoans to defend Okhema’s walls, even if the chance for any invasion is minute.” She offers a polite smile to a citizen passing by.

“They have been restless. Even a chance at a battle will stir excitement within them,” he mutters. The same citizen eyes him wearily, and whispers

unkind words to his companion.

“Well,” her blank gaze focuses on the road ahead, and she deftly steps out of the way to avoid a crowd stopped in the middle of the path, “As a thank you, I will offer you this: it seems Phainon has been stirring up a bit of trouble at the training grounds with them.”

His eye twitches, and he stops his stride.

“What?”

“He still hasn’t mastered controlling his emotions quite yet,” she says, her heels clicking against stone until she halts and turns to face him. He tries not to heave a sigh. “I’m sure you are well aware of his tendency to take things to an extreme when he sets his mind to something. Especially in the heat of the moment.”

“That I am aware of,” he crosses his arms, a scowl marring his features.

“I take it you are also aware of what he must be doing then?” she questions.

“I unfortunately am.”

Aglaea gestures for him to follow, and leads them off to the side where Phagousa’s water flows. The golden liquid cascades down the plateaus, pooling into canals they walk alongside until they find a pleasant spot beside green thickets decorated with violet blooms.

“What are your intentions with this situation?” she asks, tracing one of the petals with a delicate hand.

“I will be telling him to stop, naturally,” he tries not to grumble.

She hums, taking a moment to process her thoughts before saying, “Perhaps it would be in your best interest to let this play out.”

“I— I’m not sure I’m following.”

“Phainon and you are close, anyone with a working pair of eyes can see it. All of Okhema sees it aside from the Kremnoans. Whether people like it or not is a different story. But, perhaps this could be an opportunity to crack through their stubborn pride. If there is anyone who could manage to, it would be Phainon.”

“I…” While he respects her, he has doubts over her reasoning. Nothing can be so simple, not even with the Deliverer pushing through.

“I hope you consider these words,” she continues once he fails to say anything in return. “You have dedicated yourself to the Flame Chase, and I wish the best for you two. I just ask for you to try not to antagonize one another.”

He cannot promise her such a thing, so he remains quiet. Undoubtedly, they will get into an argument and fight. All of this started because of him, because he couldn’t handle Phainon’s pouting over a different alphas scent upon him. If he never allowed him to be scented the first time, none of this would be happening.

But, then he would have never known how tender Phainon could be. How his chest vibrated with a delightful purr when he let him do it again. How he could smile so blissfully it made Mydei malfunction.

He wants it. He wants to experience it all again. But he can’t act on his individual desires, not when Castrum Kremnos looms upon his shoulders, weighing him down with responsibility.

Mydei lets out a heavy sigh. “I will speak with the Deliverer, and see where his mind is at.”

“Of course.” Aglaea smiles gently, her blank gaze piercing him, seeing through to what he cannot, and makes him bare.

☼

The sharp crack of wood smacking against wood and the heavy thud of a body hitting the dirt are the first things he hears as he steps into the training grounds. From a distance, he spots a crowd of people observing a duel which lasted a measly ten seconds at most.

One moment the fierce Kremnoan alpha charged forward to strike, and the next he lay on the ground beneath Phainon's feet. Another person stepped forward, and lasted a tad better than her compatriot. A few slashes, a few desperate jabs, and she too meets the ground. Like with the previous individual, Phainon shoots a pleasant grin and thanks her for the fight.

"Deliverer," he calls out.

The sea of Kremnoans part for their scowling prince, and he walks straight towards him.

"Mydei!" Phainon glimmers with excitement. "You're here quite late."

"And I see you have taken a liking to fighting my people."

Phainon lets out a forced, stiff laugh. "Nonsense! I'm merely partaking in what they love most."

Mydei refrains from rubbing a hand down his face. Instead, he turns to his people and issues a single command: "Leave us."

The crowd disperses after a few minutes, a few grumbling over the interruption. Phainon assures them he'll be around tomorrow to continue, and Mydei bites his tongue to not immediately protest.

Once in the clear, he sharply asks, "What are you doing?"

"What am I doing what?" Phainon blinks. The bags underneath his eyes have only deepened, standing out against his pale skin.

"This. When I spoke of dueling my tribe, I did not extend it as an invitation."

Phainon studies him, weariness etched into his features. His gaze settles right above his shoulder then traces his jugular. He sighs, placing a hand on his hip, and shifts his focus towards the Dawn Device.

“It seemed like the right thing to do,” he finally says. “You were afflicted with their grievances. I learned how much they truly despise my company around you, and I…” Phainon waivers, scratching at the bronze studding his white coat. “This is the right way to go about it.”

Mydei folds his arms, briefly noting the destroyed training dummies: wood splintered, straw strewn all about. Some of them have been cleanly decapitated.

“What did you want to talk about earlier?” Phainon tosses a glance from his profile, not allowing a moment for Mydei to respond, and strains a rehearsed smile. “From yesterday.”

“Ah… that.” The word lays heavy on his tongue, steeped with his internal conflict.

“Yes, *that*,” Phainon says, putting on a cheerful disposition, a breathless giggle bubbling out. “It warranted you to seek me out, it must be important.”

Mydei looks at Phainon, doubt overtaking him. He knows he needs to say it —to utter it into existence. To not let the warm rays of the sun penetrate the bone chilling river. He heaves a sigh once more, steeling himself for the inevitable of what must be said. As the crown prince, he can’t afford the luxury of selfish desires. He represents so much more than a sole individual, and this is another example of such.

“Deliverer,” he begins with trepidation. “This is an important matter, so do not toss it to the wayside.” The words are wrong, but they can no longer be held within.

“Alright…” Phainon faces him properly. “What is it?”

“You…” Mydei hesitates, heart sinking to the bottom of the river bed, and releases the sigh he held within. “You cannot scent me—” Phainon instantly flinches “—Not again. As Mydeimos I cannot allow for such a thing.”

“What?” he asks, the air churning with a tenseness. “What does that have to do with anything?”

“It has to do with everything.” He focuses on the brightness of the Dawn Device, tracing how the rays dance in their circular patterns, omitting the soft light. “The restlessness of the Kremnoans over your scent will escalate things even further. I cannot afford the Okheman council to have another reason to pick us apart.”

“That’s ridiculous.” Phainon grabs his attention with the sheer venom in his voice. “What does that even mean? Not scenting you? Even standing this close imparts a small fragment of me. Are we not allowed to spar then? Am I not even allowed to place a friendly hand upon your shoulder?” He demonstrates by clasping a heavy hand down on him. “Would this count for you as scenting? This is absurd.”

Mydei shrugs him off. “It is not absurd. It is a matter I must adhere to, even if I do not agree with it.”

“So why not ignore it then? You have no issue ignoring so many other things and bearing the brunt of unpopular opinions.” Desperation fills Phainon. That insecurity he harbors rearing itself through.

“Because I must choose the battles I fight. You of all people know what I represent. And you, of all people, should know the way you scented me means more than a simple gesture of brothers in arms.”

The words slash Phainon, and he grimaces as he takes a step back. His breaths come out heavy and shuddering, his hands clench so tight his nails threaten to cut open his skin and drip golden ichor.

“Maybe if you listened to the things I say, you would understand,” he says, and invades Mydei’s space. “I do not refrain from withholding my opinions. You are the one who tunes me out whenever I try to speak them.”

A gnawing guilt sinks its talons into him, but he perseveres. While he may have a point, Mydei can’t accept his belligerent attitude.

“That does not matter,” he says with finality. “I have spoken on what must be.”

“So, you do not think this is worth contesting?” Phainon mutters.

“We have gone our whole lives without it being the case. It will simply be a return to what we were before.”

Phainon takes him in, his hands twitching in his restraint, arms trembling from contained anger.

“I don’t…” he begins, but bites down on his lip. A wetness covers his eyes, and he blinks heavily.

“I’m not an omega for you to scent,” Mydei gently says, reminding himself of a bond he can never have for he never will be. “Nor am I an alpha who can contest the declaration of being scented. As the crown prince, I must stand on these principles. With that you must understand our differences.”

“I see.” Phainon purses his quivering lip, and takes in a deep breath through his nose. “You have been brainwashed into believing such things because you are ignorant, and wish to remain as such without consulting me.”

“I am anything but ignorant,” he defends himself.

“I know it's not my place to act as your advisor on these matters, but your understanding is primitive and follows traditions, for that is what you’ve been taught by others.” Phainon grips the strap upon his chest holding his pauldron, and tugs at it.

“Why must you make everything so difficult?” Mydei groans. He knew this conversation was going to be unpleasant, but he never anticipated such a strong reaction. “If anything, you scenting my neck instead of my wrists is what brought this upon us.”

“I’m not making things difficult,” he petulantly responds. “I’m making a statement—one I observe as a fact. And the other thing I’m observing is how much of a coward Mydeimos is.”

“Excuse me?” This insult he did not expect.

“Indeed.” Phainon grabs his wrist, and he tries to tug away. “Instead of finding a solution, you decide to run away with your tail between your legs. Unless you forget—which I believe you haven’t—you enjoyed it. So why shouldn’t I fight for it? I know it's what you want.”

“Unhand me, Deliverer,” Mydei growls in their tug of war, his frightful strength digging through the hard metal of his gauntlet, pressuring and squeezing his wrist.

He throws fist against Phainon’s head in an attempt to dislodge himself. Phainon dodges with ease.

“Or what? You’ll defeat me in a battle? Need I remind you of our equal strength,” Phainon taunts him.

His heart skips a beat at the reminder, and his blood burns. Punches and kicks are thrown, blows are parried, and bruises are given. Their exertions convey what words cannot; the language of combat speaks of desperation in Phainon. The frustration of being denied and how it boils him leaves his stance wide and full of holes. The exhaustion plaguing him slows his movements.

“You will listen.” Mydei cracks his forehead against the alpha’s, pain splintering through his skull towards the back of his head.

“I only listen to Mydei,” Phainon grunts as he wraps his arms around Mydei’s torso, securing his hold with a tight grip.

“Idiot, I am Mydei,” he grunts out through gritted teeth.

Phainon hunches down and presses forward, using all of his strength to push him down onto the ground and air knocks out of his lungs. Mydei

glares up at him as they both heave. Phainon holds him down by the shoulders, and a red bruise blooms on his forehead.

“You…” Phainon starts, sun eclipsing the sky-blue expanse, and a wild grin stretches across him. A familiar, uncomfortable heat settles itself in his groin. They’re close. Close enough for warm puffs of breath to ghost upon his face. “Looks like I’ve scented you again by sheer proximity this time. Won’t people be upset?”

“They… will be,” he mutters, plopping his head against the ground in defeat. “Phainon, I…”

Phainon lets go of his shoulders, and leans further down to rest his weight against his elbows. They are so close like this, chests almost flush. He can feel his heat engulfing his exposed skin. He bites the inside of his cheek in an attempt to quell the confused fluttering of his heart. They were never this close before, and he has no idea where it comes from.

“I don’t want to give this up,” Phainon murmurs so quietly he wonders if he is meant to hear the confession. “It won’t matter that I do this since you already have my scent upon you, and it's quite late into Parting Hour.”

He presses himself up against his scent glands, and Mydei’s breathing stutters. It's soft, gentle. Just like how he remembers. The will to fight saps from his bones, and he lays heavy against the dirt. Vines wrap around his limbs, gripping him into submission, feeding upon his strength with greedy gulps. He gives in, allowing Phainon to caress him. Allows him to pour himself over.

He wonders if he even has the courage to shove him off if his frustrations willed it. But this warmth, this closeness, it intoxicates him. Makes him wish to wrap an arm around him and close the tiny distance between them. To feel Phainon’s weight upon him, and ground him to the earth underneath.

Mydei exhales a shuddering breath.

“You don’t need to worry,” Phainon whispers against his ear, and his toes curl as his groin pulses with desire. “No one will know.”

“I will,” he says, and finds the roughness of his voice surprising.

Phainon leans up, and their noses almost brush. “The only one who matters.”

Close—too close! Strength surges through him, and he shoves Phainon off. He hears him laughing over the loud thudding of his heart. Ah, how it thrashes and bewilders him. Mydei rubs his chest underneath his bulky necklace, trying to calm it down.

Phainon lays beside him, pleased and quiet. A soft breeze rustles shrubberies and trees around them. No sounds of sparring, chatter, or footsteps interrupt the intimate air. They are here—alone. And Mydei melts from knowing his lonesomeness is broken by the Deliverer’s ceaseless persistence.

“Mydei,” Phainon breaks the silence after a few beats.

“What?”

“I’m not going to let this go.”

He dryly chuckles. “Why did I hope you’d let this be easy for me? Fine. I cannot dictate your actions, but I do not approve of them.”

Mydei shifts to look at Phainon, and his eyes widen as he realizes the other is already watching him with ardent determination.

“That’s fine. I don’t need your approval for this. I apologize in advance if it causes you trouble.”

And he can’t fight the smile tugging at his lips. Warmth invades his core, seeping its way through his chest and up his ears. But spikes of anxiety wedge between the spaces of his ribs for indulging these soft desires. He’s no omega, he should not be enjoying the presence of an alpha, for how can an alpha ever feel the same for a beta? They share no special, intrinsic bond.

He’s so close. If he willed it, he could outstretch his hand and reach forward —touch the rays of sunlight breaking through the darkness of the bottomless sea he lives in. Breach the surface and gasp in air his lungs burn for.

He sits instead.

“Don’t get full of yourself, Deliverer,” he scoffs in his bluster. “You act as if I want such a thing. I’d be more pleased if you stayed beside yourself.”

“I can’t afford to this time,” he says with a small, humorless laugh.

Mydei moves to stand, but Phainon grips his wrist, halting his action.

“Can—Can we stay for a little while longer… Please?” His question borders on begging.

And Mydei… always has a hard time denying him.

“Fine. But I’ll be leaving after a quint,” he huffs as if it’s some terrible inconvenience. Allows himself to be yanked back down to the ground.

Because the smile Phainon gives is always, always worth it. Every single time. And if they sit closer than they usually do, pressing their shoulders together, heads tilted towards one another, he’ll keep it to himself.

Chapter End Notes

> first off, i didn't expect so many people to read this fic so thank you all so much!! i'm crying happy tears. alpha/beta is love.
>
> i said there would be smut this chapter, but it turned out it will be at a later chapter lol. i got too excited in my writing! i was yapping about this fic with one of my lovely friends, Snoo, and they helped me outline better and internally i was like "oh no, this is going to be longer than i originally planned." doesn't it always end up like that? hahahaha
>
> question for the readers, do you guys like the longer chapters? they take a bit for me to work through, and i feel like i could've updated

more often if they were shorter... i told myself to write 6-7k worded chapters, but here i am at 10k again lol.

find me here on twitter!

Chapter 3

Chapter Summary

> With determination, Phainon launches himself against his opponent, swinging his wooden greatsword with practiced ease. The surge of adrenaline brings him to victory at his normal pace, and he turns to Mydei, still shining like a beacon of light.
>
> "*Did you see that?*" Mydei can hear his arrogance. "*And you thought I wouldn't be able to handle this.*"
>
> Mydei hides behind the pillar before Phainon can get any ideas to make a fool of himself. Though, he can't help the soft smile adorning his features, the warmth prickling through his chest and radiating outward. He hides the upturning of his lips behind a hand, and stalks away.

Chapter Notes

> **small disclaimer for this chapter**: canon typical violence
>
> **tags updated**: masturbation, feelings realization, virgin mydei

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"What is 'bitching?" Mydei asks, eyes narrowed as he reads across the page.

"That's-!" Castorice's face flushes instantly, transcending her pale features into something akin to blood soaking through linen bandages. "Lord Mydei, why don't we forgo reading that one?"

"Is there something wrong with it?" he asks dryly. Ever since he began his venture into reading romantic novels, Castorice waxed and waned between eagerness and apprehensiveness. Her fingers wiggle in desperation as she inches closer to take the scroll from him.

“There’s nothing necessarily wrong with it,” she squeaks and scoots back before she gets too close. “I don’t think it is a variety you will appreciate.”

He stares at her. Hard. She squirms in her seat.

“What I mean is, you don’t seem to have an appreciation for… umm…” she presses her fingers together, “reading the more… intense and intimate aspects of romantic literature.”

“You’re talking about sex,” he deadpans, and threatens her by unfurling the scroll further.

“Yes! That!” She clasps her hands together and mumbles, “It’s… a popular trope of an alpha getting together with another alpha or beta and… changing them into an omega through a lot of… you know.”

A small flush reaches his cheeks, and he shifts his attention to the parchment. While he has no issues talking about the biological matters of sexual intercourse, reading the more flowery language describing the acts of “thrusting” and “slick drenched loins” leaves him absolutely flustered. The first time he happened upon such a thing, he startled like a newborn fawn, tried to get through a few sentences, then clasped it shut as steam rose from his head.

Unfortunately for him, most works have a fascination for heat and rut cycles; they create entire plots and genres where protagonists have to deal with impulsivity, going as far as to make one of the reasons they get together being through the lens of “assisting” one another in the name of either friendship or convenience. He tried so hard to stomach such stories, but the second the narration heated up, he sped across the text, running away from the impending shyness enveloping him, until he couldn't take it anymore and closed it.

To his shock and horror, Castorice loves those types of works. When he was about to complain about it, he witnessed her excitement, and decided against airing his grievances. Instead, he explained in a calm, demure fashion that he harbored no desire to continue reading such works. The last thing he wants to do is upset her.

However, whispers flood his mind over this unique premise. They nudge him towards a possibility he never considered, begging for this reality to be true. “Can such a thing even exist?”

“It’s a work of pure fiction. It can’t actually happen.” She exhales a shaky breath as she clutches her chest.

“I’ll return it then.” He stands, and allows her privacy to recollect herself.

A hollow sadness envelops him as he walks towards the shelves where he found it. Delicately, he slides the scroll back into its proper place, and gazes about the section once more. Being Aglaea’s library, she has a treasure trove of romantic literature, but no matter how hard he searched, he couldn’t find anything else playing upon the coupling of an alpha and a male beta.

This story was the only one, and even it transforms the beta into an omega.

And he does not know why it fills him with a sense of melancholy. Did such things really not exist, or did Aglaea’s collection lack it? Maybe they were destroyed in the homelands of other city-states as citizens ran away from the plaguing black tide. He traces the shelves, fingers bumping against the indents of wood, metal, and parchments, and picks one out at random.

Another alpha and omega coupling. Another perfect, harmonious bonding. Another slice to the gaping, festering wound he bears. And he wonders why it matters to him at all. Why such a fact leaves him anxious and saddened. Even though he wonders, he does not dwell; he cannot dwell. He pinches such feelings between his fingers, and nestles them deep within, and forgets they ever existed.

He inserts the scroll back, and returns to Castorice who has now composed herself.

“Welcome back,” she smiles as if their earlier conversation never happened, “I think you’ll like this one.” She hands him a new piece, sliding it across the table like always, and he unfurls it. “It’s a fluffy piece—it goes into about nesting and what makes it special to both the omega and alpha.”

He skims the first few paragraphs, and finds it decent enough. “Alright, I’ll give it a read.”

She grins in her excitement, swinging her feet underneath her chair. “I quite like that one a lot. It’s very cute and elicits so many soft emotions.”

Right. Cute and emotional. That is what he is known to like. Mydei bites down the sigh from within, not wanting to upset her. Historical texts are his preferred readings, for he can learn through them and apply himself to become a better leader. Reading about the world which eludes him, of things he can never experience, leaves him with a sense of longing.

To make matters worse, they poison his mind with inappropriate dreams. Too many times has he woken from either a fitful nap or sleep with lingering memories of what the night graced him with, colored by the flavors of text he most recently read. Such as the soft, sweet sensations of Phainon pulling him into his lap, nuzzling the crook of his neck, scraping his fangs against his skin, planting kisses all the way to his lips, breaching his mouth with the slip of his tongue as strong arms encircle his waist.

Though in his dreams he can never feel such tenderness, for he has never known such touches. But he remembers the vivid, soaring ecstasy bursting through him, erupting in ardent need. His own eagerness clutches Phainon, digging his nails into the muscles of his back, bringing him even closer while leaving imprints of reddened crescents against his pale skin.

And every time he awakens—panting and covered in sweat—he shakes those sticky thoughts away. He’s had reprehensible dreams about his friends before, this wasn’t anything new. Nothing special to such thoughts; it’s what he tells himself to assist in ignoring the neglected ache between his legs.

☼

For the past few days, Mydei has stopped by the training grounds to observe Phainon duel against his people, and today is no different. He stalks behind the crowd onlooking the latest fight, avoiding the section Krateros—whose hawkish gaze never once lifts from its judgment—and his other advisors reside in. Leaning against a pillar, he watches as the latest warrior falls to his feet. Phainon, stripped of his white outercoat and armor, pants heavily as sweat drips down his temple.

He looks terrible. The fighting has been constant, day in and day out with no end in sight. Even from this distance, Mydei deduces his exhaustion by the sagging of his shoulders, the way his head wilts slightly to the side, the fidgeting grasp on the hilt of his blade; all born from the never ending exertion from the past few days. Signs others can’t tell, but he knows him too well.

The crowd around him never thins, and everyone eagerly awaits to test their might against the one who bears his name in supposed prophecy, and as a symbol of Okheman ways. Though, his ears perk up over a few voicing their approval of his prowess, some even mention it directly to him.

And it eases a gentle smile out of him. Perhaps Phainon can convince them through this spectacle.

Another fight commences, and Phainon no longer defeats his opponent in the blink of an eye. Instead, it continues for an agonizing, long thirty seconds. Far too long for someone of his rapport. He wipes the sweat off his brow with the back of his hand, sends his defeated opponent a cheerful grin, and calls for his next match. Never once showing any weakness. Pretending he bears no fatigue.

The next person steps up, and readies himself. They exchange a few polite words before standing on opposite ends. Phainon scans the arena, and spots Mydei watching. His exhaustion shifts to excitement, and the grin he bears shines as radiant as the sun. Mydei stares impassively, reigning in a scoff.

With determination, Phainon launches himself against his opponent, swinging his wooden greatsword with practiced ease. The surge of

adrenaline brings him to victory at his normal pace, and he turns to Mydei, still shining like a beacon of light.

"*Did you see that?*" Mydei can hear his arrogance. "*And you thought I wouldn't be able to handle this.*"

Mydei hides behind the pillar before Phainon can get any ideas to make a fool of himself. Though, he can't help the soft smile adorning his features, the warmth prickling through his chest and radiating outward. He hides the upturning of his lips behind a hand, and stalks away.

Before Phainon breaks out into an episode of showboating, Mydei hides behind the pillar, pressing his back against the cool, smooth marble. What an idiot, he thinks to himself as he brings a hand to hide the upturning of his lips, such an idiot. Before he departs, he catches the azure blue of Phainon's cape laying upon a bench tucked into the corner of an alcove. Accompanying it his white coat neatly folded over itself, and his few pieces of armor.

A nagging coerces him to extract it, tempting him to take. Perhaps, he can offer Phainon a kindness of his own. He may not have the right as the crown prince to encourage his actions and must remain impartial, but if he steals his attire without notice, and uses it as a means to conceal a meal, who's to say he was the one to do so?

So, he snatches it away before doubt overtakes him. Before his mind can realize he takes without such altruism, and more out of petty selfishness to indulge himself. Phainon will continue on with his distractions and he will not know. He cannot know.

But he wants Phainon to know what he will be doing for him. He wants to show his support in a quiet, small way, and not have his actions be misconstrued for a stranger's. When he returns to his dwelling, he throws it upon his bed, glaring at the article of clothing as if it is the harbinger of his struggles, and hurriedly places his scrolls on the nightstand.

One falls, colliding against the floor and unravelling itself. He bites down a curse, and snatches it before it traverses an annoying distance. He gathers it

in his hands, tucking the parchment back into itself, and spots a particular word: “nesting.”

Mydei pauses, and reads a few sentences. The passage describes an omega covering their nest with their scent, rubbing their face, wrists, and even thighs upon every pillow and blanket within their domain. Purring at the highs of having their own space marked with their presence.

Right, this was what Castorice recommended for him to read. Cute and emotional. He sighs, and takes a seat upon his bed, leg bouncing anxiously as he reads more. The scent, he reads, will make anyone know it is theirs. No doubts can ever be levied, for scents are a unique essence to every omega.

He steals a glance at the ombre blue cape beside him, and swallows. He could… potentially try scenting it himself. Though, from what he understands, a beta’s scent hardly leaves an imprint of themselves; something about the quality of their pheromones being too weak.

Mydei reads, reads, and reads some more, lost in the temptations of the story; of how the alpha coos over their omega building a nest, of how perfect they are for one another, and how much their scents immaculately combine into something idyllic and harmonious. Envy cascades like a turbulent storm, crashing ships upon jutting bedrocks, destroying and breaking hulls as masts splinter.

In a fit of childishness, he chucks the scroll against the opposite wall, gathers a multitude of his pillows onto his bed, pulling them from every corner of his house, and plops down on top. In a fit of embarrassment, he discards his armor and rubs his defunct glands all over, chafing his skin against the soft fabrics of silk and cotton.

Once done, he lays out of breath in the center of the pile, staring upward at the cold ceiling, bare hands placed upon his stomach.

This is stupid. So utterly stupid and unbecoming. Sure it feels comfortable enough, sure it brings a sense of comfort. But nothing like how it is described in the novel. There is no bone deep gratification surging through

him. No surroundings of his scent filling his lungs to soothe him from his greatest woes. No… Phainon to praise him.

He rolls to his side, and glares at the azure cape half fallen off the bed. Unfortunately, glaring does not dispel the burning desire to soak it in his supposed scent. To feel its texture rub across his skin. And the thoughts fluster him. What is wrong with him?

So, with a trembling hand, he grasps and pulls it close to his chest. Curls into it as his heart beats to an unknown rhythm. His tongue presses against his pallet and rubs as anxiety etches its way into every inch of him, tying him with string until pins and needles prick every layer. And he quivers once the course fabric presses against his nose. He inhales deep. So deep his lungs begin to burn.

There is no elusive scent filling him. Only a hint of sweat and earth lingers upon it, and he frowns in disappointment. It claws at him nonsensically—this feeling of wistfulness which plagues him. If he were an omega, this would be paradise like no other.

In the novels he has read, the alphas would never dare to intrude into an omega's nest without permission. They went on their knees, begging the sly omega to be let inside her domain. The coy back and forth, the push and pull, the cloying desire between them both as their scents shifted between lasciviousness and harmless banter.

When he glances to the side, he can imagine Phainon whimpering with his big blue eyes shimmering, begging to be allowed inside. And he'd have all the power, all of the control, smirk and taunt him with the privilege of being allowed in.

His pants tighten against his crotch, and he huffs in frustration, finding it uncomfortable. He grasps himself to adjust, and sucks in a breath at the firm hardness he sports beneath a couple of layers. This isn't right, it shouldn't be this way. He shouldn't be thinking such things.

He rests on an elbow, kneading and massaging his stomach in discomfort, trying to will away his growing excitement. It's all this damned capes fault.

It is the thing causing all of these inappropriate thoughts of how the Deliverer would whine and beg for him. Plead on his knees. Tug on his clothes until his incorrigible childishness wears on Mydei's patience.

He scratches at his stomach, drifting further down, slipping underneath his belt, dragging his nails against his skin as he draws in a gasp, a spark tingles through his lower abdomen. Trepidation catches in his chest, but this strange desire continues to course through him. It's wrong. This is no dream which he can eschew responsibilities of.

But, oh, how fun that would be to torture the Deliverer in such a contrived way. Of course he'd want into his nest, the man begs him for simple compliments already. He'd be able to smell the emotions emanating from his glands, souring from desperation, sweetening from excitement. The rise of his shoulders as hope glimmers when Mydei would pretend to think it over.

The thoughts evoke a snicker out of him, imagining the sweetness, clutching the cloak and burying his face into it to hide his shame. To hide how it elicits such joys out of him. How his stomach tightens and jolts. His fingers itch a centimeter lower, scratching through the soft patch of blond curls.

It… It would be really fun, he tells himself, curling into his own person to hide himself away from the world. To pretend he never dares to think of his friend in such a perverted manner. The same one who fights to remain close to him, to not leave his side even when it is demanded. Would… Would he be mortified if he knew he harbored such thoughts?

Mydei flips to his other side, tangling himself in the cape, thighs pressing into his growing erection and he gasps at the newfound sensitivity. A shyness envelops him. Guilt seeps through with how heavy his cock fills. It shouldn't be this way. It cannot be this way. He is no omega to dream of an alpha in this sad imitation of a nest.

Yet it is. Wrapped in the Deliverer's clothes like this, it's as if he's held close by him. He may be no omega, but there is still a small hint of his person upon the clothing to enjoy—the ones he can detect. The walls of

pillows around him conceal him from the open air, masking him with a sense of privacy. And, with a shaky hand, he dares to unbuckle his belt and release himself from the confines of his pants.

A shaky breath trembles out of him, his cock twitches as it meets the cool air around him, thick and proudly on display. He screws his eyes shut so tightly colors dance behind his eyelids, and he inhales sharply again.

Titans, it would be so enjoyable to tease him. It's all he wants. To have him crawl into this bed with him, to witness that bright grin of his directed at him and only him. To know his status as a beta meant nothing, and that he'd find pleasure in his close company as much as he does. To be wrapped around in his arms, and purr over how delicious he smells.

Something better than what he is now. Not the dastardly smell of bread or—or honeycakes or whatever the Deliverer blabbed on about. But a real sweet scent, something like delicious pomegranates mixed with honey or vanilla. Even lavender sounds nice.

"*You smell so sweet, Mydei*," the Deliverer would say with a barely concealed whine as he inhales deeply into his neck. "*You made this all for me? I'm touched.*"

Mydei's breath hitches as he grasps himself fully. No more tentative scratches at his skin, no more fingers playing with his soft hairs. He stifles a groan into Phainon's cape, and his hips buck of their own volition.

And knowing Phainon, he'd taunt him for such an amateur reaction to pleasure. Tease him for the way he grips the sheets so tight his knuckles turn white from a single scrambling thrust into his hand. His blood burns at the snark, knowing he's better than this. It's not as if he's never pleasured himself before.

Phainon would nibble on him, teeth grazing across his neck, hold him close as if he were less than his title as crown prince, and just a man. A man who scoffs, yet enjoys these caresses. Pretends to not preen into the affection, but never lets him leave if he tries to pull away.

His hand works himself eagerly. Feels warm hands ghost about his sides, pressing their firm palms into his skin. A dribble of white works its way out of him, coating his cock with every eager stroke of his hand. Phainon presses soft kisses upon his head, crosses the plane of his forehead, peppers against his cheek. And he'd hold his face so tenderly, thumb caressing his other cheek, as their noses press together. Close, just like how they found themselves deep into parting hour before he shoved him off.

Mydei shoves his face into the cape—the salacious sounds of his pumping and fabric shuffling interrupts the quiet of his room—and he bites into it, the gentle wisps of warm breaths from his panting caressing his face, and he tries not to drool. Sensitivity buzzes across his chest, the roughness of his own chiton scratches at his hardened nipple, sending thrums of pleasure straight through his core.

And—and Phainon would kiss him so tenderly upon his lips, grip onto him so tight in fear of losing him. Whisper promises into his ear of how he'll always stay, always protect him, place a hand across his one weakness to defend it against all in this world. It's all Mydei desires. To be held, to be cherished in such a way he never was. Phainon would give it to him. Phainon would kiss him like he meant something less than a prince. Phainon would hold him. Phainon would scent him. Phainon would claim him— He'd—!

A groan gasps and stutters from him as the coiling pressure erupts in a sudden release, painting his hand a sticky white, and a pleasant static hums throughout. His body twitches as he chases the remnants of hot pleasure searing through him, turning to sensitivity with every extra stroke of his hand. Heavy breathes heave from his chest as he rolls onto his back, and a blissful warmth fills him.

Phainon would rest his head against his chest, listening to the thumping of his heart, wrap himself around his side, and everything would be right. He'd be able to bring forth a hand, card through his snow-white hair, and forget where he begins and Phainon ends. Enter into a reverie where no worries find them, and only they exist.

The buzz of life ebbs out of him as coolness replaces the warmth of his skin. As the flush leaves his cheeks. As his breathing returns to normal. The ceiling above enters his vision, quiet and cold. There is no pleasant pressure atop his chest. There is no Phainon kissing his collarbone in warm adoration. It’s just him, and only him.

A disgusting version of him. He reaches upward with his soiled hand, watching as the clumps of white ooze down his palm. What is wrong with him? To think of his rival and friend in such a debauched manner. Imagining him in a way he should not be, and bringing himself to completion in less than an embarrassing thirty seconds of effort. What is he, a teenager with no self respect?

He checks the cape, and breathes a sigh of relief once he finds it untouched by his indecency; a wet bite mark at the top is all that remains, and it will fade with time. He shuffles off and takes a step back, sweeping his gaze upon the unfolded stupidity.

A bed clumped with feather filled pillows and woolen blankets. The Deliverer’s sky blue and golden cape twisted upon itself from his writhing. He stands there, gaping at his own creation. A moment of weakness; a moment of madness.

He is the crown prince of Castrum Kremnos. He cannot be regarding an alpha with such lustful visions. He needs to stuff these desires down, never regard them with any sense of worth, cage them into shadows for the light to never touch.

Mydei wipes himself clean upon a cloth, rubbing at his palm until it reddens. Works on creating a simple meal of maza, goat cheese, and a few things of grapes to bundle within a linen cloth tied together by twine. Nests it within Phainon’s great cape, concealing it from sight. Stalks back towards the arena where sounds of conflict stirs throughout. Places it where he found what he had stolen, and departs without a second glance, for shame clamps its jaws around him.

☼

Days pass by with the same routine: patrolling through the area where the threat of the black tide stirs, negotiating between the council and his rights as a citizen, and sneaking a healthy meal to the Deliverer. The fighting continues on, and he cannot bear to speak with him, humiliation over his deed clinging onto him like a second skin, disallowing him to face the Deliverer with his usual stoicism.

Though, there is another he avoids.

As much as he tries, he cannot dodge Krateros forever. The alpha traps him during the tail end of Descent Hour in the Garden of Life while he sits on a chair, feeding a chimera some cookies with one hand, and holding a piece of literature recommended by Castorice in the other.

They discuss mundane topics, ranging from training to the growing younger generation. As always, Krateros pesters him to step up towards the mantle of becoming King—after all, he slain his father and the throne is vacant—nothing he hasn't heard before and dismisses it easily. A tension lingers between the two of them, the topic of Phainon hot on Krateros's tongue, but he holds it until he's exhausted his discussions.

"He will fail," Krateros says, conviction laced in his smugness as a Kremnoan should be. "The boy thinks he can defeat an entire army on his own. Then you will see he is no true equal of yours—you who have faced a real army and won."

Mydei remembers the Battle of Aenionus when a hail of arrows blotted out the sun, and he bested the undefeated Klytius with a strike through his throat and tore it open. A battle where no Kremnoan's fell.

"It is a different circumstance," he says, and pets the chimera resting on his lap.

“He will fail,” Krateros repeats, a sternness edging through, “And you will give up on these thoughts of yours—these nonsensical desires of viewing an Okheman dog as an equal.”

Mydei scratches behind the chimera’s ear, and it chirps in delight. “He is a fine warrior who has bested many already, these insults you throw at him are unfounded.”

“Unfounded if he were a true Kremnoan. He will never understand our ways, what it means to be us, no matter how hard he tries.”

“If you think in such a way, then we have no reason to continue this discussion,” Mydei mutters, irritation flooding through, but he grabs its reins and contains it. This stubbornness is exactly why Okhema continues to view them with distrust, why they hiss words of contempt and sling vicious glares.

“The boy can’t even care for his own body, rusting his blade with no proper maintenance. His steps swerve with a malaise, his strikes grow dull. You hold him in too high regard for how he carries through his convictions.” His tone is almost chastising. “You must relinquish your thoughts, and carry them no further.”

Frustration bleeds to a tinge of concern; if Krateros can discern his exhaustion, so must his other advisors and generals. They are too experienced in the realm of conflict to let such things go by unnoticed.

Finding his silence as an answer, Krateros continues, “When he falls, it will dispel these illusions you hold.”

“I hold no illusions,” Mydei responds gruffly, focusing on petting the chimera on his lap. “You refuse to see what I see, continuing on clutching these ideals of a home we no longer have.”

“But we do still have it, Mydeimos. Under your command, we can reclaim it all. All it would take is a single order.”

“No.” Mydei gently grasps the chimera—the creature chirps in confusion—and lowers it to the ground. “There is no home to return to. Only a desolate ruin of Castrum Kremnos remains. I will not subjugate Kremnoans to a false hope.”

“Hmph,” the answer irritates Krateros. “I see you are not ready for this truth either.”

“We can argue all the way through Curtain-Fall hour, and my answer will not change.” He stands, and grasps his scroll. “I will be taking my leave.”

Slumber eludes him as it has so many nights before. He tosses and turns, trying to allow the darkness to bring him into the realm of dreams. Krateros’s words rumble in his ears, and the festering worry grows. This type of fighting is unsustainable, no matter how gifted an individual Phainon is.

He needs to talk to him, make sure he is well.

But such thoughts carry their own heaviness upon his shoulders. Talking with the alpha discomforts him—not after what he’s done. Even if Phainon will never know, his guilt continues to eat at him. How will he manage looking him in the eye after his imagination ran rampant, unable to be reigned in like normal?

Mydei huffs as he sits, clenching his fists tight. If anyone saw the crown prince of Castrum Kremnos roll around like a shy maiden in distress, he’d have to honor his father and throw himself off a cliff back into the river of souls. How embarrassing, he thinks, that mere fantasies bring him to his knees and falter his convictions. It is still before Curtain-Fall Hour, he can drop by his residence for a stern visit. Subjugate him into taking care of himself if he fights against his concerns.

So, he first decides on stopping by the training grounds to throw a few fists against a training dummy and erase the jitters. Then, he will pay Phainon a visit.

He spares dressing in his royal armor and attire. Instead, he drapes a red, silken chiton, the edges embroidered with soft golden thread, wraps sandals around his feet, and adorns his bicep with a golden band. Before departing, he examines his appearance by studying his reflection in the standing mirror. Even if a few souls drifted about the late night, he needed to uphold his appearance as prince.

Much to his surprise, when he enters through the grand hall, he spots a familiar head of white hair from the corner of his eyes, just out of sight, tucked away in an alcove. He leans forward to gain a better view. There Phainon sits, gaze downcast as he brings his blue cape to his face, rubbing it underneath his nose before sighing and letting it fall to his lap.

He leans against his elbows, back curved into a hunch, his far off gaze drifts to the floor, tiredness etched into every facet of his being. He looks so, so tired. Exhausted and drained. Mydei wants to wipe it all away; all of his previous worries forgotten by the pitiful sight.

But what should he even say to the alpha in this moment? Offer him a drink? Maybe invite him to the baths. Or perhaps assure him. All of the options weigh heavy, and none of them sound right.

The irritating, noisy nagging in his head taunts him over how effortless it would be if he were an omega. All he'd have to do is offer his scent, and it would put Phainon at immediate ease. No words would be needed. Oh, how he wishes he didn't need to use words.

Taking a steadying breath, he gathers his courage to cross the distance, his sandals padding against the stone flooring and signifying his presence. Phainon twitches back to reality and swings his head towards him. His grim expression transforms into bright life, grin pinching his cheeks as his eyes crinkle in delight.

"Is that— No, Mydeimos?"

Mydei stands in front of him, and crosses his arms. The facade he wears breaks by the dark circles underneath his eyes standing out like ink blots on fresh parchment.

“Did a herd of dromas run over you?” he asks.

Phainon lets out a tense laugh. “I don’t look that terrible!” Then, quieter, “Do I?”

“You look like you haven’t slept in a week.”

“Well, I may not have been run over by a herd of dromas, I have been run over by a battalion of Kremnoans,” Phainon says, all cheerful and delighted. “Are you here because it is your turn for a duel? Though, I have to say, as lovely as your clothing is, it’s not quite suited for battle.”

“No.” Mydei narrows his eyes at the forced playful banter. “I have come to wield a wooden weapon against a training dummy, and clear my head.”

“I wouldn’t mind, really,” Phainon offers with a half shrug.

“Deliverer,” Mydei grumbles a sigh. “Why are you still out here? There is no one around to fight. Go, rest.”

Phainon releases a breathy laugh, gaze drifting down to the training grounds behind Mydei, hopping from pillar to pillar, until settling on the refurbished dummies. “I was having trouble sleeping, so I figured some fresh air might help.” A hidden answer lies behind the tense quirking of his lip and the way warmth departs from his gaze like the flame of a candle wick, fluttering and threatening to vanish. “And you?”

“I am of the same,” he says, and takes a seat beside him, leaving enough space for a chimera to sleep between them if it so wished.

“And not to witness me fight for your hand?” Phainon asks, pressing a hand against his chest and feigning insult.

Mydei scoffs and reclines against the backrest, swinging an arm behind. “I've witnessed and sparred plenty with you myself.”

“Oh, c'mon. Here I am, fighting for my life, and you can't even be bothered to give me a single compliment?” Phainon turns to him and pouts. “Unless

you happen to be allergic to them? My apologies, I didn't intend to give you a skin rash.”

“You…” Anger spikes through him at the taunting, at the childish demeaning, and he forces it down, smooths it out until not even a ridge remains. “You're ridiculous.”

Phainon opens his mouth to continue his torment so he clamps a hand down upon his head, ruffling his snow-white hair until his strands poke out from every odd angle, acting as a punishment for his immaturity. With a satisfied smirk, he pulls his hand away, but Phainon grasps it, holding it firmly in place.

“Say it.”

“Say what?”

“Say you appreciate my efforts.” The grip on his wrist tightens, and Phainon grasps his forearm with his other hand.

“I…” The right thing would be to say that he doesn't. How he wishes him to stop and cease his childish antics. Everyone would be better off. “I—” *don’t*, the correct word lingers on the tip of his tongue, but instead he says, “—do.”

A grin breaks across Phainon’s face. However, whenever Mydei gives him a crumb, the alpha demands the whole slice. “Now say it fully with your chest.”

“Where are your manners? You are addressing royalty,” he huffs as heat prickles across his visage, trying to tug his hand away.

“Oh? That suddenly matters now?” He hears the smirk in his voice. “If you say it again, I promise to retire to my chambers and rest.”

Mydei heaves a sigh at his relentless pursuit, staring down at his hand tangled within his hair. The very same hand which was covered in his

depraved fluids. A guilt creeps through him once more, shaming him for such debasements of his closest companion.

“...I appreciate your efforts,” he says, ruffling him with a gentle touch.

And Phainon’s smirk softens into a smile as his eyes slip shut, pressing into his palm. As if possessed, he continues to ruffle his hair, though his pace softens into something more akin to a pet.

“Your hands are so soft,” Phainon murmurs, tiredness creeping along the edges as his hands fall to the bench and he leans closer in. “Are you sure you’re a warrior?”

“Can’t you keep your mouth shut for even a minute?” he grumbles in return.

“Mydei…”

“What?” he asks with a harshness he didn’t intend.

“Can… I hug you?”

The suddenness of his request gives him pause. Phainon never voiced such thoughts before, always teasing and goading, never earnest and quiet. Never this… meek. It is not a word that should ever be used to describe someone like him, yet here he is, viewing his rival as such.

“Tch.” He looks off to the side. “... Fine.”

Of course he acquiesces. Of course he allows Phainon to wrap his arms around his shoulders and pull him in. Did he ever have an option to reject him? To reject this tenderness his body curls into, betraying its status as a tool and weapon for destruction.

And Phainon trembles in the hold.

“You better not be laughing,” Mydei huffs in embarrassment.

“What? No— No. I just…” Phainon tightens his grip and whispers, “I can’t believe you’re letting me do this…”

“What don’t I let you do?” He wraps his arms around Phainon in turn, awkwardly pressing his palms against his back, unsure of what he should do with his hands.

“I promise I'm not scenting you,” he murmurs, the tip of his nose pressing into his neck.

“I would push you away if you were,” he says, rubbing his hand up and down along the long expanse of his back. “I can't allow you to every single time.”

“You smell so sweet,” Phainon inhales deeply, lets out a content sigh, the warmth of his breath ghosting along his nape as he exhales, and goosebumps rise across his skin.

He grasps the fabric of Phainon’s shirt, bunching it into his hands, as the rate of his heart picks up. Such words should not elicit this pleasant of a response, but they do. Oh, do they call for him to bear his neck, allow for it to be scented, scoot closer and throw his legs across Phainon’s thighs. Then, they’d be closer to the intimacy he craves.

“You smell like sweat,” he says.

Phainon wheezes laughs, squeezing him before his arms drift down to his sides, and rests his cheek against his shoulder. With a sniffle, he asks, “I’ve always wondered—what does that smell like?”

Mydei takes in a breath, for once focusing on the empty space around them. Aside from the Deliverer’s natural musk from a full day of exertion, he can sense something in the air. It lingers all about him, fuzzying his nose, clinging to the back of his throat providing proof of its existence, but he cannot name it. It must be Phainon’s pheromones permeating throughout.

“It smells like—” Hands brush against his sides, and he reflexively jolts away, biting his tongue down at the odd sensation.

Phainon lifts a curious brow, and brushes his side once more. He squirms away again, pushing against Phainon’s shoulders to stop him.

“Are you ticklish?” Phainon asks, tone rising in amusement.

“Don't be ridiculous, I am not.” He shuffles away, and Phainon follows until he's trapped at the edge of the bench.

“How about we test that?”

“How about we don't.” He leans further away until his back hovers off the edge.

The two stare at one another. Mydei narrows his eyes. His lip curls in disdain, and Phainon lowers his brow as a coy smile plays along his. The air is dreadfully still. A single nymph flutters about, weaving lazy circles as it searches for a spot to settle. No muscles twitch, neither utter a single word to break the silence. The nymph lands.

Phainon lunges—Mydei springs away. And Phainon ends up swiping the empty space of where he once was.

“You're not getting away so easily!” he arrogantly proclaims, shaking a fist.

“You'll have to do better than that to catch me.” Mydei steps back, arms stretched wide, and smirks.

Mydei turns on his heel and sprints. The two bolt around the empty training grounds, ducking and weaving between pillars, using the training dummies as obstacles, springing over ledges. And whenever Mydei glances over his shoulder, Phainon nips at his heels even through his exhaustion, lost in some sort of trance. It’s as if it dissipated entirely—solely focused on chasing the crown prince in a hunt.

Fun, he thinks as he rounds a corner, hand gliding across the pillar to catch his weight, this is so, so fun. To run carefree, to feel the wind in his hair flutter with the rush of freedom. Unbounded is he to stand atop the marbled

balustrade dividing the halls and the earth, and taunt the alpha with pretentious words.

“I thought you had more fight in you, Deliverer,” he jeers in gleeful bliss.

Phainon lets out a heartfelt laugh, panting as sweat drips down his brow, and sets on with fierce determination.

To say he intended to lose would be a lie. He truly did intend to escape the Deliverer’s pursuit. However, as he turns sharply from a sprint, the ground picks up against his heel and he skids, losing his balance, and crashes face first into a weapons rack. The wooden beams snap from the sudden impact of force, and weapons scatter all around. Phainon, never one to lose an opportunity, lunges at him, crashes down on him like a tidal wave, pinning him into place between his thighs.

“I win,” Phainon boasts, low and deep, something on the edge of a growl, and Mydei shudders.

Fingers dance across his sides. He squirms and struggles as his body betrays him and he laughs. Laughs, laughs, and laughs. His stomach aches, tears sting the corners of his eyes, and he swears he will kill Phainon for agonizing him in such a way. His body is a weapon, meant for suffering wounds and death for others, not to glimmer and glow with joy!

Phainon’s tickling eases, his gaze turning serene as he watches him laugh so readily.

Mydei surges forward, pushing Phainon off balance and forward until his back thuds against the ground. He looms overhead, clasping his wrists against the ground, and straddling his stomach, panting heavily as he catches his breath. His chiton slips off his shoulders, hanging by his elbow and exposes more of his skin. Phainon pants in turn, his face flush a crimson red, wild eyes flitting about his face, neck, and chest. His canines protrude far more than normal, fully unsheathed and on display for him to see.

It is wrong to enjoy such an expression on him; to imagine how painful his bite would be upon his nape. How his blood would flow.

Phainon, beneath him like this, heaving for air, snow-white hair splayed and a mess, is a different sight to behold.

“Mydei, you are so…” Phainon starts, and he prepares for a jab to come, to disperse the intimate air.

He wants to memorize this image, imprint it into the core of his soul, pull out a photostone and capture a picture, whatever it will take to never forget. Before Phainon ruins it. Because the sight before him is so… is so…

He swallows. A fuzziness permeates in the air, tickling his nose and clinging to the back of his throat.

He is so…

Beautiful.

“Beatiful…” Phainon breathes, uttering the word like a confession.

The two freeze up; Mydei stares as a hum of static fills his ears, and Phainon’s eyes go wide as he chokes on his tongue, strangling him from saying anything else. He shoots up, shoving Mydei off.

An awkward beat passes, and he glares a hole into the ground, jaw set so tight a muscle pulses, fingers clawing into the dirt as he clenches them into fists. Tiny pebbles dig into his palms, grounding him back to reality.

“I—Uh—” Phainon rubs the back of his head, bringing up his knees to his chest. “I think I’ll go and get some of that rest you spoke of.”

He says nothing in response. Phainon shuffles to his feet, and scampers off, glancing back only once across his shoulder. Mydei’s tongue twists upon itself, his heart continues its erratic drumming, and no air enters his lungs.

A warmth spreads through him like dim embers of a hearth stoked by the shifting of charcoal, encouraged by the soft blowing of wind until a fire

sparks within and grows. So uncontainable it is, he sits for a long while, feeling it engulf every extremity and spread to his ears.

So still he is, a nymph mistakes him for a marbled statue, and climbs across his leg, snapping him out of his stupor. With a gentle touch, he brushes the beetle away, and releases the sigh held within. He’s been called many curses, many slanders, and many critiques before.

But never an adoration so delicately whispered in reverence for him; the one who committed patricide and left a slew of wars in his wake. As he returns home, he crosses his arms, hiding how his hands tremble. Hiding, even from himself, how his spirit rises and touches the sky itself.

Yet he sleeps so well this night. Curled up in his bed surrounded by a multitude of plush pillows—face buried into one as he clutches it—and dreams of Phainon chasing him again. And when he catches him, he presses him down against the earth, and kisses him instead, fingers intertwined.

☼

Dangerous, he decides and furrows his brow, Phainon is dangerous. He draws inexplicable fantasies, probing his untouchable wound with the sharp tip of his quill. The jet black ink seeps through the cracks, rewriting everything he knew about the alpha. Trianne walks alongside him in his patrolling, peering at him with curiosity every so often.

An omega Kremnoan soldier stands, ready for any sign of the black tide, alongside an Okheman guard. They glare at one another, throw snide remarks as if it were a sport, and Mydei ignores their bickering where he would normally intercept to maintain a peace.

“What’s wrong, De?” Trianne asks, “You look like something is troubling you. Is it because Snowy is fighting?”

Has he really become so easy to read? The thought unnerves him.

“No, I’m not worried about him,” he says as evenly as he can.

“But you’re scowling so much.”

“I’m not.”

“He’ll be okay,” Trianne assures, “Snowy is strong when he puts his mind to something.”

“That’s not—” he sighs, and leads her towards a side of the building, climbing the stairs nestled against it for a good vantage of the block. “I’m not worried about whether he will lose. I know he is more than capable.”

“Oh.” She presses a finger against her chin. “Then what is it?”

A familiar sense of unease creeps through him. Kremnoans move throughout the blocks designated by Aglaea as high risks, their coordinated strides bringing calm through familiarity, yet talking to Trianne about his worries make sure it lingers.

He rests his palms against the bannister, and says, “Even though Phainon may be a strong warrior, he has been neglecting himself. Proper maintenance of both body and mind is important, yet he rejects it in his mindless pursuit. I know he has been neglecting sleep.”

Trianne nods thoughtfully. “He has always been like that when he has something he focuses on. It used to be worse in the past, and he’s gotten better with it.”

“I don’t see why he won’t give it a rest,” he heaves a sigh. “Scenting me is not so important for him to duel every single Kremnoan.”

“I don’t think he views it that way,” Trianne softly says. “You are important to him. Ever since you’ve come to Okhema, he has gradually improved to be what he is now. Maybe, to him, it’s an attack on your bond he wants to protect.” Then, almost teasingly, she continues, “Not everyone can stuff their feelings down like you, De.”

“I’m not stuffing away my feelings.” He scowls, though her words echo through his head, bringing a clarity to a subject he desperately wants to ignore.

“You always come to the conclusion of isolating yourself to be the right path when it’s not. And you always look so happy when you are with him,” Trianne offers her gentleness, coaxing him out of his tension.

He remembers such a happiness once, when his five companions were still alive. How they sat around campfires in the late nights, spinning tales, laughing amongst one another until one by one their group dwindled and he alone remained.

“Sometimes it is,” he murmurs. “For the sake of peace I alone can handle burdens no one else can. This curse of immortality makes it so.”

“What does your curse have to do with Snowy wanting to be close with you?” she asks with a tilt of her head.

“I…” And ties his tongue. He can answer he does not wish to outlive the Deliverer, but such a thing matters not. The prophecy foretold that Phainon alone would witness the miracle of Era Nova. He will make it to the end. Where he will end up he does not know.

“How about we make Snowy a pie to cheer him on?” She grins in her delight. “You promised us to bake, so let's do something nice to make Snowy happy. Maybe if he feels like you support his efforts he will be so relaxed he can sleep.”

The idea… doesn’t sound half bad. Though, presenting a hand made pie with the three Tribbies brings an ounce of embarrassment, but with them around, he can cover his real intentions. And he knows how the Deliverer will brighten as if he handed him the sun. The image stokes a warmth within, and a soft smile crests his lips. Maybe then, he will finally listen.

“I suppose that’s not a bad idea.”

“Yeah.” She grins and giggles. “He’ll be so shocked and touched. What kind of—”

A crash explodes from the other side of the street. Roof shillings, and stone flies, colliding into the ground, and cracking apart. Tapestries tear apart. A pillar topples over, and the crowd around the vicinity scream and panic. Abominable black tide monsters slither through, slashing and swiping with reckless abandon, leaving a wake of black in their paths.

Mydei snaps to attention, and shouts commands to his fellow soldiers who jump to their feet.

“Lady Trianne, help the civilians escape,” he orders, and she flies to do her part.

He charges forth, clashing with a Tide-Eroded Blade that whirls its edged arms with intent to kill, and the corruption seeps through into his skin. The civilians within the area follow Trianne’s orders as she zips about and leads them to safety.

It slashes his torso, and his golden blood flows out of the freshly made wound. He takes the opportunity to land several blows upon it, breaking and chipping at its blackened construction. The sun upon its head glows with pain, whirring in frustration.

An Okheman guard finds purchase with her blade as Mydei distracts it, delivering a devastating slash across its back. And another guard follows her example, striking with firm resolution. He whirls a kick as the creature stumbles, bisecting it in half.

However, no moment can be spared as another burst of black tide creature erupts.

Mydei spots those two omegas from the markets—the one he felt a needless rage towards as they cooed over Phainon—cowering underneath a fallen stall. A Corroded Axe rushes towards them, eager to kill and spread chaos. They scream in terror as they grip one another, tears pouring down their faces as they pray for salvation.

Without thinking, he intercepts the charge, the black axe the monster wields cleaves through his shoulder to his sternum, and he grips it tight to hold it in place. Golden blood floods his lungs and throat, he hacks it out and strains to maintain his hold.

“Go!” He orders the omegas, but they are too paralyzed in fear. “Run!”

The creature tries to pull back its weapon for another slice. An arrow from a Black Tide Decrepit Bow whizzes past and the girls scramble to the left as they clutch one another. Another arrow pierces his shoulder and blood drips, drips, drips.

A coldness blooms from his tenth thoracic vertebrae, flowing through to his extremities, and his vision blurs. When he opens his eyes, the familiar river greets him once more like a spurned old friend. Souls travel down the current, following the west wind, seeking where it ends.

But he cannot follow, for there is still so much to do. So much to fight for. So many regrets he will leave in the world of the living if he lets go.

One step after another, he trudges against the current, pain wracking through his body, tearing him apart with every stride. His golden soul glows from exertion, and he focuses on what he still must do. His people need to be led to a better life and treated as proper citizens. He needs to defeat his maddened god and return the coreflame of Strife for the Flame-Chase journey. Strength pours through him, and he reaches forward as light sparks through his vision once more.

He needs to assure Phainon he will always love him no matter what comes between them. No matter how many deaths he suffers through. No matter who or what tries to separate them.

His heart accelerates, pumping blood through his veins, and lifeforce surges through his spine, plugging his soul back into his body.

When he comes to, a roar rips through his lungs and throat, grasps the creature by its arm, presses a foot against its chest—and pulls. The limb cracks and frays as it tries to dislodge him. Tries to fight against his

strength. With a sickening snap, he tears it asunder. The axe lodged within his shoulder begins to dissipate as the creature stumbles back. In a joint effort, Kremnoan and Okheman soldiers bring death to the creature.

A glob of blood coats his mouth, and he spits it out before righting himself with haggard breaths. The soldiers around him celebrate the victory. Shrill exultations of the omegas behind him grabs his attention.

“We’re alive!” one exclaims as she holds her friend by the shoulders. “Lord Mydei saved us.”

The other one cries and cries, not having come to the sudden calm around her.

“Don’t cry now, we’re alive,” she says, and wipes her friend's tears away with a thumb.

And his eyes widen as she kisses her full on the lips, leaving him gaping. The other omega buries her face into her shoulder.

“Thank you, Lord Mydei,” she says to him.

“You two… are together?” he says. Blood loss always leaves him delirious, and he worries in believing his vision.

“We are,” a breathy laugh escapes her, tears stinging the corners of her eyes.

“How? You two are omegas. You are supposed to be with alphas.”

She strokes her lover’s hair, her own hand trembles in the soothing gesture. A small laugh escapes her as she says, “That may be what others want from us, but we don’t follow tradition.”

Blood gurgles through his lungs as his body begins the arduous process of healing. And a coughing fit envelopes him. These two omegas who left him in a confused, trembling rage had no interest in the Deliverer this entire time. His mind created scenarios which did not exist, and upset him so.

Golden ichor splats onto his palm, freeing him of the drowning within; the pattern evokes memories of his debased actions, of the thoughts which brought him across the threshold to life, of his dreams he pretended did not exist. Of the warm, comforting fire only Phainon could bring. Of the rays of light he wishes to grasp. How they illuminate the darkness of the river he sinks and suffocates in.

Oh.

Aquila's wings freeze in the sky, rushing rivers stall, and the lion stills in its hunt of the oryx. The world comes to a halt as if blessed by Oronyx themselves, allowing him a precious moment to realize. To let it fall into place.

Oh.

He’s in love.

Distracted by his new found revelation, he does not recall Trinnon holding his hand and leading him to a clinic. His head flies in the clouds as his wounds are dressed by a doctor. His healing factor works and aches his muscles as they stitch together, and his body itches deep through his layers of flesh. Thankfully, no casualties are reported, and he relaxes at the success.

He lays on the kline, staring at the ceiling above, as he allows this newfound feeling to settle and hum. How could he not see such a simple thing before? In hindsight, it glared in its blinding truth. But, even as it percolates, doubt continues to shadow him. Is a beta allowed to fall in love with an alpha?

Can a beta ever compare to an omega whose entire being molds for the alpha and the same in return? He stands as an outcast to these dynamics, lost to their language of love. He may wield great power as a prince, but he lacks experience of gentle desires. All he has known, and will ever know, is violence.

The other wounded Kremnoan and Okheman soldiers rest across from him, and for once, their conversations do not drift to arguments and curses. They boast of their combat prowess, and dismantling the black tide creatures together.

The omega from before enters after a gentle knock against the door, bearing a calathus of pomegranates in her arms and a sheepish smile.

“Lord Phainon told us these are your favorite,” she says. “We wanted to give you a proper thanks for saving us.”

“... Thank you.” He takes it from her. The fruits jostle and settle into place. “Where is your… lover?” The word tastes odd on his tongue.

“She’s recovering from the shock of it all,” the omega answers with a smile.

He stares at the fruit, head still fuzzy from blood loss, and asks, “Does it not bother you that she’s not an alpha? From what I understand, an alpha and omega are meant for each other as a bonded pair, yet you give it up. Is that really okay?”

The omega blinks at his spilling of words, then bursts out into laughter. “You and Lord Phainon are truly similar for asking the same question. Of course it is okay, we love one another.” She places a hand upon her chest, and a reverent smile graces her. “I can’t imagine giving myself up for an alpha simply because it is what is expected of me and being told it is right.”

“Phainon has asked something similar?” He perks up in curiosity, and a hope he never wished to foster, glows.

“Maybe it is best for you to ask him,” she says as if she knows the answers to all of his questions.

The thought of asking something so forward terrifies him. These feelings should never be known, but the look she gives urges him to throw such thoughts away. And perhaps he should stop being such a coward, running away because they are new and never before felt. He has fought creatures of

the deep, endured the onslaught of armies, yet these simple human interactions terrify him so.

In a fight, he knows what to expect. In dealing with Phainon he may as well be a lost pup digging through sand in hopes of finding treasure.

Yet, Phainon is the one who fights for their bond while he runs away. Braves the thundering storm as it bashes him with hail and burns him with lightning for days on end without shelter. How can he consider himself a man when he cannot stand beside the Deliverer and offer his support?

The crown prince of Castrum Kremnos cannot know fear. He is resolute in his resolve. Steadfast in all of his actions.

And so, in this quiet clinic, he comes to this: he will show his open, selfish support for Phainon. Fight alongside him in this battle not meant for spear or sword. His people live in days of old, and he pushes for the new, and this will be another example of such.

☼

After the doctor approves of his leave, on his return to the arena where Phainon continues his battles, he encounters a Kremnoan father and son who grab his attention. He knows them well, for they are the elder and youth who traveled with the original detachment; the time when they bore no Kremnoan flag and had yet to defeat his father.

Now the elder’s wrinkles have deepened, and the youth has grown into adulthood. They exchange a few pleasantries before one speaks up.

“Your highness,” the elder omega, Milo, says, “It is a shame you have an alpha fight for you with such ardence, yet you refrain from showing support.”

“Of course he doesn’t,” his alpha son, Lampros, interrupts. “This is no Kremnoan Festival, but a classic show of Okheman pageantry.”

Milo chuckles, years of wisdom laced through in the way he shakes his head. “This is no pageantry. It is a fight for what he believes in, and isn’t that the most honorable way to show what you stand for? No waiting for a festival, and showing urgency for what matters.”

“Do you despise Phainon for what he is?” Mydei abruptly asks, and the two raise their brows in surprise.

“No,” Lampros’s voice raises in shock, “There are many of us who disagree with how this ordeal is playing itself out. We don’t need the alpha Phainon making a show of Kremnoan weakness by defeating so many of us.”

“And, many of us don’t need such extravagance to see how much he cares for you. He has already proven himself worthy in your first bout with him,” Milo adds on.

Mydei’s lip quirks up of its own volition, and their admissions leaves him light.

“I have been too consumed in thought to see what is right in front of me,” he says. “Your words are a kindness to hear, thank you.”

“Don’t thank us! Just get him to stop so he can finish embarrassing us,” Lampros cringes while Milo laughs heartily.

“And show him your support. That poor lad looks like he’s about to collapse at any moment.”

“I will.” Mydei stirs with conviction, and marches forward with steadfast steps.

For too long has he cowered in the shadows of tradition. Shielding himself with it in protection from these newborn feelings of romantic love, ones he has never experienced before. No more, he decides, pace increasing as he

strides past the hollering market sellers, past the bickering screams about inventory, and past the laughing women sharing in their gossip. No more.

And light crests his vision as he enters the training grounds, no longer hiding behind pillars and lurking in the shadows. His people separate to create a path, and he steps forward to the front.

A metal greatsword arcs through the air, spinning erratically until it stabs itself through the earth upright, the hilt a splintered, crushed mess.

“Yield,” Krateros orders, the tip of his blade pointing at Phainon’s forehead who stares up with widened eyes and heaving manic breaths.

The crowd behind him erupts. The earth quakes underneath the stomping of their feet. The wind reverberates with a cacophony of piercing cheers and whistles. The light reflects off the bladed edge as it gleams in victory. Excitement sways and dances around him, goading him to join in the celebration, yet he stands petrified before it all.

And vehement desperation carves itself upon Phainon’s visage as he loses, to the ovation of all.

Chapter End Notes

> uwaaaa drama! sorry for the cliffhanger ending lol. it didn't start out like this i swear. thank you all for the lovely comments! it makes me so happy knowing other people are enjoying my self indulgent fan fic. 30k words and i'm still not at the scene i wanted to write hahaha I'm also happy i was able to finish this up by sunday! it was such a busy last two weeks for me, and on top of it all my job made me work 10 hours of overtime, bluuuuugh. i apologize for any typos!!
>
> I was mulling over my previous question i asked you guys, and I think i'll keep the slower release, and longer chapters. But, I do post updates and sometimes snippets on my twitter if people are curious and eager to see the progress. sometimes i just post my first draft stuff too cuz its always so dumb loool. other than that i mostly repost myphaidei stuff cuz i'm so hyperfixated on them.

Chapter 4

Chapter Summary

And when he stands next to him, he realizes every exhale is not a snore, but a gentle purr. Good. At least the Deliverer finally rests, he thinks as he swallows. Yet, he can’t bring himself to break his gaze—can’t bring himself to retreat away from this sight before him.

The mattress dips as he sits beside his sleeping companion, entranced by what he sees. In this moment, witnessing the staining of reddened eyes and drying wetness on the pillow, he sees a reflection of himself in his sleeping visage—as if a rough and imperfect mirror reflects what he holds beneath the drowning surface. Gently, he brings two fingers, and tucks a bang of white behind his ear.

Chapter Notes

Disclaimer for this chapter: we're finally at the smut bit! but it is a little bit questionable. if you don't want spoilers, feel free to skip this section. if you like being prepared before delving into reading, please read the drop down.

▶ Content Warning

Tags updated: Mating Cycles/In Rut, Phainon has a Large Penis, Marathon Sex, Forced Proximity, Knotting

NSFW specific for this chapter: Nipple play, intercrural sex, hand job, blow job, rim job, anal fingering, anal sex, painful sex, multiple orgasms, copious amounts of cum, overstimulation

I think I have everything listed, but let me know if I missed something!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mydei needs to act. Now. Before the situation dissolves into a mess. Phainon's glare screams he's about to act on a reckless desire; the thunderous cheer dims to a quieter celebration, spreading as eager chattering about the concluded duel.

But how can he act? Thoughts of violence spring to his mind—a duel, a ravage pummeling, snapping that sword in twain—for this is his heritage, but he hates the senseless violence it brings. He can scoff at this display, leave Phainon to fend for himself at the turn of his heel. After all, he is the one who decided on this course of action no matter his disapproval. Or he can accept the outcome of Krateros's victory, decree it and let Phainon deal with the repercussions of his actions.

The crowd's attention shifts to him, and his skin prickles underneath their scrutiny. They wait for his reaction; wait for the crown prince to speak. Phainon turns in confusion, and the whites of his eyes become clear as panic overtakes him.

And it settles upon him: he never wants the Deliverer to look at him in such a desperate way again.

"Everyone has witnessed your defeat," Krateros begins, stowing his blade at the side of his hip. "You will honor what you have wagered in the loss of your contention. You will not approach crown prince Mydeimos anymore." And adds with a sneer, "You will not delude him with opulent luxuries of your master or your beguiling alpha ways."

Irritation snaps through Mydei, searing through his veins and roiling his blood. Phainon opens his mouth to voice his contention, and Mydei storms towards the fray. He cannot stand there, mouth agape like a child.

"Have these games finally come to an end?" he says, distaste dripping through every word and pooling into a dark tide underneath his feet. He stands above Phainon, noting the bruises upon his exposed arms. "Have you all finally beaten the Deliverer to your satisfaction? Voiced your discontent with him and Okhema?"

A hush falls upon the audience, and Krateros's jaw flexes in the gritting of his teeth.

"This farce has gone long enough," Mydei crosses his arms and scowls.

"Farce—!?" Phainon startles.

He silences him with a glare, and Phainon snaps his mouth shut. Though, he twitches, fingers scraping and heels digging against the ground. And Mydei prays he listens, to have his trust in what he is about to say.

With a reluctant sigh, Phainon holds his tongue and rises to his feet. Mydei takes the place by his side, where he wishes to be most, and Phainon gently amazes for it.

"I should have put an end to it before it even began. Phainon has been my equal since the day we met—since the first night of our ten day duel to the death," he continues steadily, gaze drifting through the crowd until it settles on Krateros. "This excuse to exercise a form of revenge against him has festered and grown into mindless strife. Perpetuated by a false cause, exacerbated by the Deliverer himself who only desired to be treated as an equal; as one of us. A desperation bred from the faults of ourselves."

Krateros speaks with urgency, "Mydeimos, the rules of these duels have already been established by all. You can't—"

"I can," Mydei interrupts him. "I, as crown prince of Castrum Kremnos, hereby decree the outcome of this duel invalid. It never held merit to begin with, and was an excuse for senseless violence."

The crowd gasps, and rumbles with hushed opinions. His ears perk up from whispers all around, yet he focuses his gaze on Krateros.

"And if anyone wishes to contest my judgement, they are welcome to try me," he concludes, and gestures with his head for Phainon to follow.

"What is the meaning of this, Mydeimos," Krateros hisses in disdain, "to come right on the eve of his defeat and bail him out of what he could not

succeed in?”

“Like I said,” he says, and yanks the greatsword out of the ground, then tosses it to Phainon who disappears it in a shower of sparks, “if anyone takes issue with this outcome, they are free to try and best me in a duel.” He bites back the comment of knowing the forgone conclusion of his victory.

Krateros studies him with a cool gaze, the fists at his sides trembling in their white knuckled clenching. Phainon follows after him, head kept low as bangs shadow his eyes, and he strides through the parting crowd.

Murmurs surround them. Some of bemusement, some of anger, and barely any of approval. He does not know what the consensus will be by the end of the day, but he does know wild tales will be spun. As they always are.

They continue on towards his house, but Phainon's footsteps whisper against the ground, and he worries the alpha lost his way and drifted off. Yet, he does not turn around to confirm if he remains, for doing so will make him appear weak in his determination.

Only when he thrusts the door open with a forceful swing does he allow himself to look back, and relief floods through him at seeing Phainon, even if his head hangs low and his disposition bleak.

“Did you finally get it all out of your system?” he asks after ushering Phainon inside.

“You're hurt,” Phainon says instead.

He thumbs at the bandages dressed across his shoulders and torso. They are unnecessary for the wounds underneath have healed, but he let the doctor worry over him to soothe his fretful ego.

“I heard of it earlier today,” Phainon continues, his tone tinges with panic then laces with bitterness. “And I couldn't do anything to stop it.”

“The wounds have already healed,” he assures as he always does whenever Phainon agonizes over his health.

“Did you die?” Phainon presses.

Even through his pale visage, the darkness underneath his eyes, the hunch of exhaustion tugging him down, he worries for his health. Still holds Mydei's immortal life like it's meant to be cherished, and not sacrificed. It frustrates him.

“I did,” he answers with an unusual amount of reluctance.

Phainon inhales sharply, and holds it deep within his chest. “I should've been there— You wouldn't have died if I were.” He groans and clutches his head as he agonizes. “But this is—was important too! If only I could split myself in two, make another copy of myself or something then I—”

“Enough.” Mydei grasps his arm and yanks so hard he almost topples over. He drags the Deliverer towards the private bath in his dwelling; one afforded to him as a royal gift from Aglaea. A fountain in the shape of a seashell affixed to the wall flows warm water into the small pool, though it lacks Phagousa’s blessing, and cycles through a drain allowing it to always remain fresh.

“Strip.”

“Excuse me?”

“You will clean yourself and rest. I've had enough of your recklessness.”

“Oh.” There’s that tick of his brow, the one where he is frustrated and looking to fight. “So you get to be the one to tell me what I—”

“Strip,” he repeats with a condescending sneer, having little patience for Phainon's attitude. “Or I will do it myself.”

Phainon glowers in return, calculating the worth of the argument. He stands there, deliberating to himself while Mydei procures an extra set of evening clothing for the alpha to change into once done.

When he returns, he thanks Kephale seeing Phainon soaking in the pool of water. He places the clothes to the side, grabbing a wash cloth to help scrub

the Deliverer’s back, strips himself of his boots and settles at the ledge, the water soaking his calves.

“I should be the one taking care of you,” Phainon murmurs, wrapping his arms around his legs and tucking his chin between his knees.

“Shut up.” Mydei lathers soap into the cloth, and rubs it against his back with too much force, leaving the pale skin red. “You talk too much.”

“You are the one who died, and then I failed at the one task I set out to do. I wasn't there by your side like I swore myself to be. And I—”

Mydei grasps Phainon's hair, and plunges him underneath the water, irritated by the self depreciation. His arms flail about, bubbles of gurgling water float to the top and pop, until he manages to find Mydei's shoulder and gives one, two, three rough slaps against it. He resurfaces with a dramatic gasping for air.

“What was that for?” He squawks in his indignation.

Even if the Deliverer carves words etched with loathing against himself, he wants no pity. So he will give him none. He will keep it to himself, encasing it within a shell so hardened, his teeth would crack and break if he dares to bite into it to taste the underlying sweetness.

“For being stupid,” Mydei huffs and crosses his arms. “Clearly, you needed a good thrashing.”

“That's a bit of an overreaction,” he says, turning away from him with a crossing of his own arms.

“Your entire being is an overreaction.”

“I would like to disagree with that assessment.”

“Vetoed.”

“And who said you get to decide what is final?”

“I'm the crown prince. Whatever I say goes,” he scoffs. “Perhaps it will do you good to listen to royalty.”

A quiet hovers between them, only interrupted by the soft hum of splashing water from the everflowing fountain affixed against the wall.

“You didn't need to bail me out. I can live with the consequences of my actions,” Phainon mutters, refusing to meet his gaze, entranced by the suds of soap washing away as fresh water takes its place.

And Mydei can't hold the sigh within. “You act as if you're speaking for me as well. Do you really believe I wish for you to keep your distance?”

The water gently laps against the ledge as Phainon rotates ever so slightly to look at him. Pearls of tears gather at the corners of his eyes, and wet hair clings to his skin; his visage bears a striking resemblance to a sad, wet dog.

“You will stay here and rest,” he says with a finality, much like a decree, while leaning over to fetch the shampoo and lather his hands with it. “You did not ask for permission, and fought. You never had my approval, and brazenly ignored my regards—” Phainon wilts with every reprimand “—You are lucky we are no longer in Castrum Kremnos, or you would have been beheaded for such insolence.”

“Yet you're requesting me to stay…” Phainon says with a gentleness unbecoming of him in this depressive state.

“Unfortunately. Now come closer.”

Phainon hesitates, but scoots back in front of him. Mydei runs his hands through his hair, washing all the dirt and grime out of it. Massaging his scalp with the press of his strong fingers.

“Why?” Phainon murmurs, his eyes slipping shut. “I don’t deserve this kindness from you.”

“Does it matter?”

“Sometimes.”

Because of so many things. His love, his desire to see him everyday until he no longer can, stand side by side as equals in battle, and in domesticity. To pretend in this doomed world he can hold warm kindling without being burned.

“Because you are an idiot who needs to be watched over, or you will be the end of yourself,” he grumbles out instead.

Phainon slips out a laugh, lolling his head against his shoulder. “Of course.”

Yet he says nothing else. No more quips are spoken, no more retorts snipped. The quiet of lapping water, and the hush of rubbing suds permeate throughout.

And so he continues washing Phainon, ignoring how his heart pounds against his chest, feeling dirty for taking advantage of his weakened state. Yet, Phainon relaxes and ends up dozing, unintentionally bringing a comforting relief to know he's not conscious throughout this whole ordeal. He refrains from rubbing his thumbs against his jaw to feel the slight prickling of a not there yet stubble and the sharpness of his bone, to not feel the soft give of his cheeks he knows must exist.

The water line hovers across his chest, dipping in and out of every curve. And his mind betrays him with wonders of gliding his palm down, and pressing it against his sternum to see how such a thing would feel. If it would be firmer or softer than his.

He chases such obscene thoughts away.

This serene moment cannot last forever; Phainon needs to wake and leave the waters. So, Mydei picks up a pitcher, fills it, and twists it above his head, enjoying how the waterfall drenches Phainon and snaps him awake.

“Rude.” Phainon rubs his eye and yawns. “Are you done washing me?”

“Yes. There’s still shampoo in your hair you need to wash out first.” He stands, and flicks the water off his hands. “I’ve left you a spare change of clothes.”

And after Phainon finishes cleansing himself, and the two are standing face to face by the archway of his bedroom in their nighttime attire, he asks, “Are you gifting me the kline in the living room?”

“No. You will rest in my bed,” he answers as if it were the obvious conclusion.

Phainon hesitates and swallows.

“Do you really think I’d give you such an easy opportunity to run away? I’m making sure you don’t end up doing anything foolish, and will be guarding the door.” He crosses his arms and puffs up with pride as if he’s concocted the best strategy of war. “Don’t think you can creep past me. I can detect anything even when I sleep.”

Phainon’s gaze drifts towards his bed. The curtains against his windows are left parted, allowing light from Kephale’s Dawn device to spill through and illuminate the room. And a sudden embarrassment flushes through Mydei; he forgot to remove the extra pillows strewn across his bed. It had grown as a comfort to him these past few nights, and he prays Phainon misses the resemblance to an omega’s nest.

“Can we…” Phainon clenches his hands as a soft, sharp inhale breaks his thought. His eyes flit between him and the bed before he shakes his head and sighs. “Nevermind. Are you sure about this? I’d be leaving my scent everywhere. I can take the kline in the living room, and swear to not try any escapes.”

“I’m sure,” Mydei says. “Don’t fret over your scent. I’ll be making sure no one has issues with such a thing again.”

Phainon wets his lip before biting it. “I—” he coughs into his hand, “Yeah. Okay. Okay. Sure. That’s good.”

Mydei raises a brow at him, and he bears a weak, nervous smile in return. The sight is endearing, and a warmth only Phainon can invoke spreads through him once more. “Hmph. Try not to hurt yourself falling asleep.”

“I’ll do my best. Sleep well, Mydei,” Phainon says oddly quiet. But, when Mydei takes a few steps away he calls out a— “Wait!”

He glances over his shoulder. “What is it?”

Then he fidgets with his hands in such a timid manner unbecoming of the Deliverer. He shifts his weight from foot to foot, and awkwardly rubs his palms together as he tries to mouth words, but no sound filters through.

And Mydei waits.

Because he always does in his unyielding patience, for Phainon always stutters and hesitates whenever it comes to gentle matters concerning himself.

“Nevermind,” he finally forces out, and withers like a wilting flower denied sunlight.

“If you need anything, you know where to find me,” Mydei says, and lingers for a second longer before departing, in case the Deliverer finds his confidence.

As he lies on the kline—the windows covered by a hastily thrown blanket—he stares and stares at the smooth stone above, rest unwilling to embrace him. The world outside this small safe haven trembles with the rage of his people over his choices; for following his desires and not upholding the outcome.

But how can he, when he does not wish for Phainon to leave his side? Standing away, and holding silent weepings is not him. There are little things he can control in the grand scheme of Amphoreus, yet he can allow himself to nudge a few in his favor. He will figure out what he has to do. He must.

In his restlessness, he makes his way over to his bedroom—to make sure Phainon sleeps, he thinks in an attempt to convince himself of no ulterior motives. But, as soon as such thoughts enter him, he throws them into the abyss, for they are the weakness of his insecurities of love.

He goes because he wants to see him. To know he rests and is safe where he should be. In his bed.

The curtains have been drawn, shading the room with a darkened shadow. A soft, quiet snore breaks the silence, and he pads over with gentle steps. His eyes, already adjusted to the darkness, spots the wide length of Phainon's shoulders, the white mess of hair draping over a pillow he clutches close to his chest.

And when he stands next to him, he realizes every exhale is not a snore, but a gentle purr. Good. At least the Deliverer finally rests, he thinks as he swallows. Yet, he can't bring himself to break his gaze—can't bring himself to retreat away from this sight before him.

The mattress dips as he sits beside his sleeping companion, entranced by what he sees. In this moment, witnessing the staining of reddened eyes and drying wetness on the pillow, he sees a reflection of himself in his sleeping visage—as if a rough and imperfect mirror reflects what he holds beneath the drowning surface. Gently, he brings two fingers, and tucks a bang of white behind his ear.

Phainon's desperation has led him to fight his people; to enter a world he cannot behold, torn himself asunder for such a thing. Yet, is it not the same for how he cannot cross the threshold into his world? Phainon cannot grasp what it means to be Kremnoan in the same way he cannot grasp what it means to be an alpha or omega.

Both worlds are hidden by curtains that can only be tugged open by ethereal ropes they cannot grasp, barring them from gazing at the stage of the lives they wish to be a part of. And the thought brings a darkened cloud overhead, pelting him with rain and hail. Why must every turn at life be a cause for strife?

Phainon mumbles something in his sleep, and a drowsy hand brushes at his lingering fingers away from his temple, and a low, rumbling chuckle escapes Mydei.

Ah, what a pathetic prince he is, falling for the alpha Deliverer in such a way. So strongly he wishes to slip underneath the covers and hold Phainon close to his chest. To assure him he need not struggle to be in his world, for he already is. And he always will be, no matter what may come.

Saliva pools in his mouth as the desire to lay a kiss upon his head creeps and looms. Such a simple gesture, one he has seen dozens upon dozens of times before amongst his tribe, yet never given or received by him. Would Phainon wake? Is he allowed to permit himself such a selfish act?

In a manner unbecoming of him, he trembles. Shakes in such a way not fit for a Kremnoan, much less for the one who should be king. Oh, how easy this would have been if Phainon requested him to stay and sleep beside him. Share a bed. Then, he could permit these selfish desires.

Yet, even when asleep, Phainon strips him of his restraint. Every exhaled purr beckons and hypnotizes him, brings upon a desire so strong he cannot resist. He leans on an arm, bends at his elbow, and holds his breath as he presses a kiss upon the crown of his head.

And, oh, it feels so, *so* right. As if he were always meant to do this. Warmth runs through him, curling his edges, softening his sharpness. Leaning up and away, resisting the siren call urging him to press another one on his cheek, needs to be marked down as one of his greatest feats of strength. Bards need to sing of his bravery for such an act, for all he wants is to stay. To slip underneath and beside. To feel the vibration of his purr reverberate against his body.

Phainon mumbles something again in his sleep, and his heart thunders against his ribs as he swears he heard his name.

“Phainon,” he whispers in response with an uncharacteristic quiver.

But he is asleep, the world around forgotten and unheard. Mydei shudders in a breath, and forces himself to rise away from these delusions.

“Rest well,” he murmurs in all ways affectionate, and lifts the covers to properly drape across his shoulders.

☼

The Hero’s Bath rumbles with the flowing waters blessed by Phagousa, cascading down into different pools, and swirls into glistening spirals as it drifts throughout the room. Aglaea stands at the center, arms crossed as she contemplates his reporting of the black tide attack within the city walls.

Once he concludes, a half smirk breaks upon her once stony expression. “Fantastic. No casualties to be spoken of, and earnest work has begun to repair the surrounding damages.” A bout of haughtiness crosses her features. “And Caenis chews on her fingernails and pulls on her hair for saying my worries were unfounded. Truly, things went well in all the right ways.”

“It was the right call,” he agrees. “If that is all, I’ll be taking my leave.”

“No, actually,” she says, and quiets her voice as she steps closer to him. “I wish to know of your situation. The one Phainon has stirred up.”

He frowns. “What is there to speak of?”

“I wish to know, and for you to promise, that this will not affect the Flame-Chase journey in any negative capacity.”

“You don’t need your golden threads to dictate my truth in this statement: I have it handled,” he says with an underlying grumble.

She takes a deep breath, steadies herself before finding the words to voice her thoughts. “I believe that you have it handled with your people. What I want is assurance in how this will shape your relationship with Phainon.”

“I… haven’t spoken to him since last night. When I woke in the morning, he was asleep. When I checked on him during Action hour, he remained asleep. He’s not fit for a conversation now, and most likely not for a while.”

“At least he is resting now,” she says with a hint of relief washing over her, and the relief floods to him as well. “I held my tongue for a while, but it is his first bout of sleep within the week.”

“Oh.” And he feels stupid for neglecting such a thing when it was right before his very eyes, screaming at him to take note of his poor health.

“Indeed. I have a small request to ask of you,” she says, and that small amount of concern she always holds for Phainon seeps through her gentle visage. “Please, watch over him in this time and tend to his needs. He may fight you about it, but he needs the support.”

“You don’t need to request such a thing. I intend to do so already.”

A delicate smile grows upon her. “We all worry for him, and desire for him to take care of his health. But, he is prone to not listening to the words I say when he puts his mind to something he cares about. However, I do believe he is more fond of listening to you when it comes to this sort of thing.”

And the warmth glowing in his chest comes unabated at the compliment, and he fights his visage from softening. Restrains from letting a delicate smile of his own creep along his cheeks.

“So, please, take care of him in our stead. Make sure when he wakes he will suffer no more of these unpleasantries.”

“I will.” The promise comes out as light and easy as air, and the tender smile breaks through his restraint. “You have my word.”

They share the sweet air together before she turns away, and places a hand upon her chest. “I’m glad. Even if my curse prevents me from feeling true joy these days, a small fragment of it remains. The two of you joined the Flame-Chase together, and I believe there is meaning to it. If there is someone who can understand Phainon, it is you.”

And perhaps she knows of his insecurities, detected it through her omnipotent golden thread. The thought does not startle him, for he views

her as a fine leader, but it strips him of the armor he so carefully crafted. And that he does not like.

So, he turns and says, “You don’t need to decorate your words with flowers. I said I understood.”

“Of course.” He hears the satisfied smile in her voice over the thudding of his greaves as he exits the Hero's Bath. “I wish you well.”

Unsurprisingly, the sentiment amongst his people is one of disapproval. They speak it not in words, but in how they carry it upon their bodies. They tense around him, their gazes drift away as they bite their tongues. None dare to voice their opinions in front of him because they will have to fight him. And they all know they cannot win such a duel.

But, there are the very few who do not share such beliefs.

“It has been a long time since we’ve seen our crown prince so happy,” says an alpha named Stergios; one of the people he knew amongst his earliest days upon land. “I hardly recall a time before now seeing you smile so much, and yet your spirit is free with that Phainon of yours.”

And Mydei swallows. Crosses his arms to soothe the sudden onset of his heart racing. To hear Phainon be regarded as his brought upon a joy he wished to keep private.

“I do not smile,” he says in a petulant defense.

The alpha laughs, and if their stations weren’t so different he might’ve pounded a rough hand against his back. “Nonsense. You may not show it with a quirking of your lip, but all of us who have known you since you were a child see it in the gait of your stride and in the way you always seek him out.”

The words sound like utter nonsense to him. It was Phainon who always chased him around Okhema, pestering him until he latched on to a single thread of conversation which he showed a slight interest in. Hounded him into the baths during random intervals of the day without rhyme or reason.

“It is good you have found someone who brings you joy,” the alpha says. “We were all worried for you after Hephaestion’s passing.”

Ah, Hephaestion. What would his once closest confidant and companion have thought of his predicament? Most likely tease him for being so blind to it all then try to wrangle him into understanding. How he wishes he could have his company still, but he cannot wish for the dead to come back to life.

“So, don’t hold yourself back from happiness, Your Highness,” Stergios concludes with a sagely smile.

And he is right. He can no longer delay the inevitable, and must face the one who despises all of this the most. His beloved and respected teacher, Krateros.

He questions over where he resides, and he is pointed in the right direction. In the Kremnoan district, he finds Krateros staring off into the distance, arms crossed and a scowl creasing his features.

“Krateros,” he announces his presence.

“So you have come,” he says, not bothering to turn from his distant gazing.

“I have.”

“And what is it that you wish to say?”

Mydei stares at the ground, fighting through the dread building within, then speaks with confidence, “I understand your position and where you come from, even if I disagree with it, but I cannot stand to the side and let the old Kremnoan way influence us.”

At this, Krateros faces him. “So, you cast away from what it means to be Kremnoan. Tell me, Lord Mydei,” Krateros scoffs the insult of his Okheman title, “You turn your back to us, but let that Aglaea trample her way across, influence you with golden threads and luxuries only Okheman ilk love to feast upon. They know nothing of the spirit of Strife, nothing of our ways, yet you embrace this toxic decadence.”

Mydei resists the urge to release the heavy sigh within his chest. How many times have they had this discourse? It grinds at his bones, pulls at his spirit, yet he must persevere through. “I’m not abandoning the spirit of Kremnos. This… Is what I desire. By law, there should have been no contest to prove his worth to me as it already has been.”

“Hmph. You abandon laws when most convenient to you, and claim them again when needed. Ridiculous. You cannot tell me you have been so swayed by an alpha for you to abandon your principals. You, as a beta, who have little understanding of the finer dynamics at play here.”

But he is wrong, Mydei thinks, after so many things he has read, so much knowledge he has absorbed, he understands much more. Not all, but more. There are boundaries he knew existed, but didn’t know could be broken. And, how there is nothing wrong with wanting to experience this emotion called love.

“I asked him to scent me,” he confesses and his mouth parches. “This whole ordeal did not start because of him, but of me. If I never requested such a thing, we would not be standing here.”

Krateros takes him in, his one working eye studying his demeanor, and says, “You are a fool.” He turns to watch Kremnoans walk on by in the distance. “You have the stubbornness of your mother, and the pride of your father.”

A twinge spikes through him at the comparison of his father. He never knew the man, and felt no joy in ending his life, yet he did not want to be likened to him.

“I have already said, if you have issues with my decree, then try me in a duel.”

Krateros stares at him, the air tense between them, and gives a single nod.

No words are uttered as they walk, yet heads turn as they walk side by side. Murmurs cascade down, whispers and utterings of a conflict afoot. Many

are excited, filled with energy as they watch their strongest warriors proceed. And the crowd follows behind their shepherds of conflict.

The two make way towards the very same arena Phainon sweat and bled over. The same one he refused to watch and give his open support for; hid away in the shadows from the fear of himself.

But now, he steps into the light, facing down his opponent on the other side with a crowd holding their breaths, beholding, for the very first time, their prince committing an act of selfish desire. He who has given them everything; bled for them, fought for them, died for them, and never asked for anything in return.

The two clash with weapons, and their language speaks through the scrapings of metal and thuds of their feet against the earth. Krateros has always been one of the strongest warriors, knighted with the title of King's Aegis, a position so revered only few held it. Mydei has little wonder why he managed to beat that idiot when he deprived himself of sleep and ran on fumes.

Metal meets metal with a reverberating clang. It travels through his gauntlets, prickling his skin and muscles of his arm, and it always makes him surge with life. Adrenaline aids his every strike, dancing through his legs in the sudden movements for evasion, billowing loose dust as he surges forward in retaliation.

And with this conflict, he understands his teacher more. They both share the same worry for the Kremnoans, wanting to do right by both of them in their own ways. For that, he could never hate Krateros, no matter how many times they come to disagreements.

But, he will never understand why wanting something so tender in his life fuels this conflict. No matter how many blows he parries, how many scratches bleed with golden ichor, will Krateros's efforts convince him.

He wants to be scented. He wants to be held. He wants to be treated in such a way it leaves him breathless and begging for more.

The crowd gasps, and the final defeating blow lands. His chest expands and contracts in heavy breaths, sweat trickles and shines his skin, and he stands above in steadfast victory.

“Yield,” he says.

Kraters does not scowl in defeat. He does not clench his hands in indignation. He merely sighs, closes his eyes, and says, “I yield.” Then quiet enough for only the two of them to hear— “I had no chance in victory when I spotted the very same look upon your face Queen Gorgo once had when she beheld King Eurypon. Your face was a mirror of hers when I first approached you about this ordeal.”

And his heart thuds not from the exertion of battle, but from the reality he walks into with open arms.

“I will never approve of this folly.” Krateros stands and dusts himself.

“I know,” Mydei says, and finally understands why Phainon ignored his disapproval.

For this is the most right he’s ever felt. This action, this deliberate act of discord sown from his selfish needs trumping all what a crown prince should be and do. He gazes to the crowd, witnessing their scowls, crossing of arms, and shaking of their heads. Hears their disapproval and scorn. And even through all of their criticism he cares for them still. Their visions are clouded with expectations of what once was, and cling to the days of yore.

They have not come to the land in which he wishes for them to see, and perhaps he has failed as their shepherd in his binding hesitation. He swears to guide them better, for his chains have broken, limbs released from his shadows of doubt.

And his spirit roams free.

☼

Mydei returns home every few quints, checking on Phainon who slumbers throughout the day before returning to his duties, free of worry and fear. Castorice remarks on his upbeat demeanor, prodding him with questions, and in response his answers are short and sweet.

It isn't until the next Lucid Hour when the strangeness begins.

He goes about his routine like normal, making breakfast—though this time cooking an extra portion in case Phainon wakes—and cleansing himself. But when he approaches his room to check on the alpha's wellbeing and gather his royal attire, he comes upon a sight which halts his breathing: Phainon, stripped of his clothes, face and shoulders flushed a feverish red, baring his fangs at him, and a low, dreadful growl rumbling in his chest. He splays about the bed as if it belongs to him, hoarding the pillows close.

And all Mydei can do is stare, too stupefied by what he beholds.

"Deliverer? What is wrong with you?" he asks, but the response is another growl. He huffs and approaches him, unafraid of this strange mood. "I don't recall you ever acting like a hissy chimera."

The closer he gets, the thicker the air becomes and clings to the back of his throat. The growling increases and increases until he stands a foot away. Only then does Phainon blink, a hint of clarity sparking through his visage. "M-Mydei?"

"It is me," he says and crosses his arms. "Have you come upon a bizarre fever?"

"N-No," he stutters as he buries his nose into a pillow, clutching it tightly as he helplessly gazes upwards at him, sky-blue eyes eclipsed by the sun of his pupils. How cute. "My rut— Early."

Oh.

Mydei backs up. But the second he does Phainon shrivels into himself, hurt by the timid action, as if he hoped for something else. Then, as if infused with the spirit of Nikador, he bares his fangs again and snaps at him.

“You do not instill fear into me, Deliverer,” says Mydei.

“Leave,” he growls in a voice so deep a shiver runs down his spine.

“This is my room,” he incredulously responds.

“No, mine.”

Of course, leave it to Phainon to continue his petulance even in the throes of a rut induced fever. “Contestable. But I will go for now.”

He takes a step away.

“Wait— No—” Phainon whines in desperation, rolling his hips against the mattress. “Stay.”

“I will be back,” he assures.

Mydei spares no more seconds, and hurriedly exists, ignoring how Phainon cries for his return. His travel takes him to the kitchen of his abode, then towards the living room, and back again. Pacing about, he gnaws on his lip in his ponderance of how to proceed.

From what he understands, the length of an alpha’s rut lasted from person to person and he had vague memories of the Deliverer excusing himself because of it. Though, whenever he did mention his predicaments, it was always with hurried words and a flushed face. Then, he disappeared and Mydei never observed or cared for how long.

Now, he curses his past self’s willful ignorance. If he heeded any bit of attention to this, he would not be so confounded on what to do. The books he has read have spoken of heats and ruts able to be shortened by going through with lascivious activities their instincts call for. And he did not know much aside from that, for he always skimmed such texts as embarrassment clawed away at him with every word and turn of the page.

He swallows. A red heat of his own climbs up his visage as he drums his fingers against his chin.

Hypothetically, he could help him out and ease his woes. How much of the alpha he could physically bear is uncontestable, for he is an immortal, but if regarded in a spiritual sense he did not know.

But the thrums of his desire beats through his veins at the prospect. An easy way to lay with Phainon—one that did not bring much scrutiny, for the occurrence of having a partner to help ease through heats and ruts is widely known; the knowledge he gained much to his chagrin.

Ah, how wrong it feels, he thinks as he wraps his arms around himself, to use such unscrupulous means to get what he desires. Perhaps Krateros is right in some regards of his ways being influenced. He's never heard of Phainon taking in a partner before, but that could be because he never bothered to ask. It's not as if that man lacks popularity and appeal. The creeping sensation he realizes now as jealousy returns at such thoughts, making him purse his lips.

If Phainon doesn't want to take him in such a way when offered, he can always decline the advance. Yes. He could decline. Such an easy thing it would be; he can prepare himself before entering his room, say his piece, and allow the Deliverer to make his choice.

Though, he is no omega, he does not produce slick. The thought troubles him, and he is lost on what to do. He has half the mind to pull out his teleslate—the screen scratched up from his gauntlets—and peruse the World Wound Web for information.

The second his fingers tap into the search, he slams it upon the kitchen countertop. No, he can't look up something so indecent on his teleslate. It leaves him too exposed. He glances across the counter and notices a bottle of olive oil resting upon it. Maybe he can oil himself up? But what sort of oil would work for him?

He is no pan or tray to be lathered, his body is a weapon. So, the best option he decides upon is weapon oil. What better lubricant is there for him?

With bashful steps, he walks to procure a container from the living room, and steals away to the bathroom. He stands there, staring at it in his hands, embarrassment flooding through every facet of him as his grip upon the jar twitches.

Is he really going to do this?

He tries to convince himself of being a good friend, and fails in acquitting the thoughts of his selfish desires to feel Phainon's weight upon him. How it would be like to be held by him. Perhaps not in the tender manner he so wishes given his predicament, but it shall suffice.

His hand trembles as he coats his fingers and reaches downward, treading carefully between his ass. It's slippery and weird against the delicate skin, and his face scrunches at the oddity it brings. His fingers brush against his rim, and it puckers as he clenches. Instead of probing deeper, he rubs against it, unsure of what he should be doing. This feels right, so it should be right.

…Right?

Mydei avoids looking at the mirror in front of him, and turns his back to it. Titans, he shall never speak of this to anyone. For good measure, he lathers his fingers again, and repeats the motion one more time. He will help Phainon get through his rut, and when he is more lucid they can continue on as they always have.

Satisfied, yet utterly embarrassed, he deems himself dressed enough. Thick shame curdles through him, and his ass is slippery. What has he come to? Pretending to create a nest is one thing, but oiling himself up as a pretense for slick is another. After taking in a heavy breath to steady himself, he gathers his bravery, and returns to his room.

Phainon, who had been rubbing himself against a pillow, perks up at the noise. He growls at his approach, as if Mydei threatens to take him away from his bed, then winces when Mydei opens the curtains for warm light to shine through.

“Phainon,” he says, and the alpha doesn’t relent in his anger as he rubs his eye. It takes all of his effort to continue on in a steady voice. “Given your disposition, I have returned to offer myself up to you should you so desire me in such a way.”

He gets no response, only a sneer exposing his fangs. Mydei sits beside him, and grasps his chin, forcing him to pay attention. “I will not repeat myself again. I will help ease your burdens since you are so plagued with them as of late. You can accept this invitation, or decline and I will leave you be until you regain yourself.”

The hazy look does not retreat from his eye, but the snarl dissipates. Phainon grasps his hand, and presses his nose onto his wrist, inhaling deeply and darting his tongue across the weak scent gland.

And all of Mydei’s bluster vanishes the moment the wet muscle glides and presses across his skin. It’s an odd sensation to be tasted in such a way. Before he can think any more on it, Phainon yanks him onto the bed with his tremendous strength and he fights no moment of it.

An arm wraps around his lower back, and a hand cradles his head as Phainon presses onto his neck, repeating the same gesture with his tongue. The heat of his cock presses against his stomach, and he shivers from the sheer size of it. A keen whine escapes from Phainon as he teeths and licks at his neck, fingers digging into his flesh.

Mydei bites on his lip to prevent any noises from escaping, and his arms lay limp against his sides, unsure of what he should be doing. He’s held, his neck devoured in such a way his breath hitches and his brow pinches together. Even if they are of a similar build, he is dwarfed by Phainon’s voracity. And he likes it. Oh, does he like it.

Never once does Phainon let up. Pressing his tongue, teething against the sensitive skin, bullying out whatever his scent gland has to offer with unsurmountable eagerness. The growl dips into a heady purr, and back to a growl at even the slightest shifts of movement, as if he threatens to leave at a moment's notice. Phainon undoes the wrapping of his chiton—tossed to the other side of his room—until all of him is laid bare.

A wetness soaks his stomach, and the thick consistency of cum spreads. It gathers against him, pooling into the dip of his stomach, sliding to the creases of his thighs, dripping down his pelvis and onto the mattress beneath him.

And when the Deliverer humps at his leg, he catches his thick cock between his thighs, that searing, swollen knot at the base pressing against his muscles. A gasp and whine escapes Phainon as he thrusts more, his hips gyrating at a frantic pace, clawing at his back, pulling on his hair.

The pain elicits a response from him he never knew stirred within him—he gasps, arms flying to grasp his back, and a groan of his own breaks out of him. Phainon's fervor increases.

"My-Mydei-!" he practically weeps out his name, fangs nicking the sensitive skin of his neck and a sliver of blood oozes down.

"Ngh-!" Mydei bites on his lip to stifle the moan, then breathes out a haggard, "Take… what you need from me."

"You," he groans, biting and leaving bruising marks. "You."

Phainon's cock pulses, throbbing with heat, and coats Mydei's ass and thighs as he comes, hard. He breathes heavily, chasing that elation coursing through him as his thrusts lose their strength and grow frantic. Even more spurts of hot, sticky come covers Mydei while his fingers dig into his flesh followed by a cry so strangled Mydei almost worries for him.

He licks carefully at his neck, as if apologizing for the violent bite he instilled upon it, and a shiver travels down his spine. It doesn't matter. It will heal in a few short moments. But it feels far too nice for such a simple gesture.

"This…" Phainon mutters as the cloud of lust dissipates enough for a moment of clarity. "You're real?"

"Why wouldn't I be?" he gruffs in response, his own chest heaving as well.

“I thought— A dream…” he stumbles over his words. Yet, despite his awkwardness, he continues to cling.

“Hmph.” A haughty smirk grows. “You’d dream of me in such a state?”

“Hah, don’t make fun of me,” Phainon says with a touch of odd shyness, as if the question is his confession.

“I’m not,” Mydei assures him, and relaxes as Phainon lets go of his hair.

“I…” Phainon hesitates, struggling between his words while his cock continues to remain fat between his thighs.

“Do you not want me here?” Mydei voices a thought he is afraid to hear the answer to.

“I don’t know— I mean. Yes. No.” He stuffs his face back into his neck and inhales deeply. In his exhale, he says, “I don’t… want you to think less of me for this… I want…”

The sensation of his warm tongue tickles him again, cutting off whatever Phainon refuses to say. He grasps his face, and forces their eyes to meet.

“Take what you need from me,” he says with stern conviction. “I will hold no judgements of you.” To make his point clear, and fulfill a selfish desire of his own when he sees those sky blue eyes round with apprehension, he leans up and presses a kiss against his forehead.

Phainon’s chest expands in a sudden inhale, pressing them more together. “So…” he murmurs, pressing an affectionate kiss upon his cheek, then jaw. Warm breath ghosts against his tender skin. “This is alright?”

“Y-Yes,” Mydei breathes as he scrunches his eyes shut, the pads of his fingers biting into Phainon’s shoulder.

“Here?” On the curve of his neck.

“Mhm.”

“And here?” Towards his shoulder.

“Yeah…”

Too much. It’s too much already. The heat rising to his face, the soft caress of lips against his skin. His heart beats to an unknown rhythm and he yields to it in submission, laying like puddy as those very same affections trace down his collarbone, towards his chest. Strong hands hold his hips, helping him steady as Phainon tests and nips what he’s allowed.

And he’s allowed to all of it. Whatever he so desires, it's all his for the taking. He squirms and presses into the mattress as Phainon continues on. It feels so, so different than when he builds himself up on his lonesome. To have the one he cares deeply for lavish him with such attention, worship the red curves of his tattoos, every plane of his chest, squeezing the thick muscle of his sides. His own cock twitches with interest, thickening as it crowds between their stomachs.

A jolt of pleasure lances through him as Phainon bites his hardened nipple, and, as a reflex, he pushes hard against his shoulders. But Phainon growls something deep and possessive, refusing to budge as he latches on. Teeth sink harder into him, staking a claim, and an unbidden moan erupts from his throat.

He likes that. He likes it far too much. And Phainon knows. Gods does he know based on the sharp glint in his eye. Emboldened, he bites and suckles once more, and Mydei struggles to clamp down the embarrassing sounds threatening to spill from within to without.

“Don’t be shy, Mydei,” Phainon purrs in dark delight—a lustful hunger permeating through. “I want to hear it all.”

“N-No,” he refrains from whimpering in response, but he fears his failings. “As if I’ll permit such a thing so easily.”

The cock between his thighs rolls again. In and out. Phainon delights himself to the friction slickened by the amount of cum sticking to him. His

free hand works his other hardened rosy bud, twisting and pulling, groping the thick of his muscle and kneading into it.

Mydei throws his head back as his breathing shudders, stifling down the errant moans threatening to escape. Even in this, the two challenge one another to a game of who can win. Who can best the other and take what they want. Nails bite into Phainon's reddened shoulders. His cock throbs and dribbles his own white mess. Is there truly a loser in this? He does not think there is.

His loss comes swift when Phainon pulls his nipple far—stretching it to a distance he never knew it could be—lets go, and dives back in for a painful, greedy bite. And his moan comes with the tangling of his hands through those soft white locks, tugging as desire flushes through him, and his own hips shift in desperation to chase the throbbing of his cock.

Though, no quip comes from Phainon. No chortle of his victory, and no teasing. Instead the ever consuming hunger courses through him. He wants more. He wants and wants. Such a rare sight for him to behold—this indulgent greed of his. A rough hand grips his cock, pumping him in tandem with his thrusts. And Mydei welcomes it with an eagerness he's unwilling to admit he possesses.

Between the spurts of biting pain peppering his chest, and the friction upon his cock, the pleasure builds and builds until it erupts. So unlike all the times he's experienced on his own. Never in his life has solitude ways made stars dance behind his lids as ecstasy ebbed through him. Unwinding him like yarn. Stress melts off his shoulders as he lays atop a soft cloud. And he swears he drifts through a blissful sky.

When he comes to, he peeks through his lashes, and spots Phainon busying licking his hand clean. The hunger in his eye not once faded. A rut, he thinks to himself, quite a frightening thing to witness his dear companion so out of his mind.

And that familiar sense of guilt creeps through him. Has he taken advantage of his friend in his weakened state? He offered an easy rejection, but now

he worries Phainon never had a proper choice when he presented his body upon a platter.

“Phainon,” he says, leaning up on his elbows.

And the way Phainon brightens as if he himself becomes the sun at the utterance of his name, wags his tail in the revelling of being called, he finds it terribly endearing, and impossible to shame himself further.

“Did you like that?” He leans above him, resting his hands on the sides of his body. The glimmer of feral voracity shines through his eagerness. “I did good, right? You came so hard and swift.”

Mydei pauses as he awkwardly beholds the alpha. Then, with a gentle hand, he rubs Phainon’s head, tangling through his locks. “Yeah. You did well.”

He expected a reaction at the compliment. What he did not expect is the full body shiver racking through his body, and his ever-stiff cock leaks a spurt of come.

“Say that again,” Phainon pleads as he hangs his head low, the tips of his bangs tickling his collarbone.

The awkwardness returns tenfold. What is he supposed to say in this situation? Phainon always fancied the indulgence of compliments, and he gave them when earned in combat. But never in these types of situations. Never has he folded in regards to complimenting his attire or his supposed great antique purchases.

“I am pleased,” he decides to say, scraping his fingers down the back of his head as a pleasant massage. Then, finding confidence, he kisses the crown of his head in ways he has desired so greatly.

A whimper and another spurt of heat upon his thigh graces him as a response. He does not need to glance down to know he’s drenched in fluids.

“Mydei, I want you.” Phainon noses at his neck, inhaling his muted scent.

“You have me,” he says.

Strong hands grip his thighs, pushing them apart, and Phainon nestles himself between them. “I can have you like this?”

Mydei dares a glance below, and swallows. He’s big. Never in his life did he think a cock could be so grand. The tip grazes just above his belly button. The swollen knot at his base might as well be the size of a peach. Is it even possible to fit inside?

“I… did what I could to prepare myself beforehand,” he says, nails digging into his shoulders in anticipation.

Phainon spares no more moments, and presses his enormous tip against his rim. It manages to claim a slight intrusion, but he inhales and clenches, forbidding its passage.

“You’re too tight,” Phainon says in bemusement.

“Have you ever thought you are too big?” he grumbles in response, wrapping his arms around his shoulders. Though, if he were an omega, he’d have no issues with such a feat. His body would work and loosen itself up, welcome the alpha into him with graceful ease.

It twists and hurts him to know such a thing. Their bodies are incompatible, and this is proof. A childish notion to think he can ever stuff an alpha’s cock inside him. To hold Phainon in such a way is already a cruelty to both of them.

“Hey— No, stop.” Phainon’s palms press flat against his back, brushing against his weak spot by sheer happenstance, and he wants to give himself over entirely in that moment. He pulls him onto his lap so they both are seated. “Stop thinking whatever you’re thinking.”

He huffs in protest, but Phainon interrupts, “I can smell your scent souring.”

“I have no scent,” he says, and his insecurity wins over. “I’m no omega.”

“No, you’re not.” Phainon nips at his shoulder then neck, collecting the copious amounts of cum between his fingers, and probing his rim with one.

“Relax, I’ve got you.”

And, oh, that sweet tone is all he’s ever wanted to hear. To be regarded with such a soft tenderness. It saps him of all his strength, relaxes the tension straight out of him, and he clings. Clings and clings as that finger works its way inside of him, the other hand rubs and scratches down the wide expanse of his back.

Words are lost upon him in this daze. Lost when Phainon’s lips press sweet kisses upon his neck and shoulder, and the scratching turns to tender circles against his skin, tracing his most vulnerable area by happenstance. If he were an omega, he undoubtedly would purr. But as a beta all he can do is melt into the touch and hitch soft breathes.

But the softness Phainon holds succumbs to his hunger, and he finds himself laying flat on his back once more.

“I’ve got a better idea.” That grin of his—fangs and all—speaks to his haze.

Before Mydei can question, Phainon dips his head low, tongue gliding down his abandonment, and he sucks in a stuttering breath. “Wh-What are you doing?”

Thumbs rub circles into his hip bones, and his cock rests against Phainon’s cheek. It twitches unbidden, hardening back to what it once was moments ago, and leaves a smear of cum against his forehead.

Phainon’s answer comes not in words, but in the envelopment of his cock with his mouth. The wet heat of his tongue flattens against the underside, and he sucks with a lascivious eagerness.

Mydei hisses and pushes the side of his head into his pillow. How absolutely indecent, yet he can’t bring himself to demand the Deliverer to stop his crude actions. The amount he enjoys this frightens him. A mouth should be nowhere near his cock, but here he is, thrusting into his. Seeking that wet warmth. Delving as far as he can inside his throat.

And when he tangles his hands into his hair, the probing sensation of fingers against his hole returns. This time, the single finger is accompanied by another, but he can hardly pay attention when Phainon is determined to suck him dry.

A sharp yelp rings throughout his room—low and unusual. And he finds it is his when Phainon does something with his fingers and presses in just the right angle, and the pleasure combines into another heady moan from him.

And Phainon looks far too proud of himself, never letting up in his ambitions. Mydei grips his shoulders, nails biting into his skin, and wraps his tensing legs around him, shoving himself further into the pillow as he pants and moans, restraint broken further and further. He throbs with every bobbing of Phainon's head. Gasps for air and twitches with every curling of fingers.

He can't—!

Climax hits him once again, tender than the last, and he spills deep within Phainon's throat. His vision blurs as he heaves, legs and cock twitching, drool slipping from the corner of his lips and pooling onto the sheets beneath him.

And Phainon laps it all up. Eagerly extracting everything he can from his overstimulated cock. He feels his legs lift more so than sees it, knees kissing the sides of his ears, and that voracious, relentless tongue drags across his balls, giving a small suckling there, down to his rim and pressing inside.

"Phainon… What…?" he asks in a daze, unsure if the sensations against his body were a fabrication of his bliss.

Strong fingers press into his thighs, massaging his inner thighs—there are scent glands there, his traitorous thoughts remind him—as if trying to soothe. And that warmth against his hole continues to eat him.

Something so scandalous should not be happening. The crown prince of Kremnos cannot be bent in half, and have another man between his legs

devouring him in his most private region. Yet, the very same man is Phainon—the one he trusts above all. Even if he is far too tender for such affections.

His eyes slip shut, and he chases such nagging thoughts away. He worries too much. He should not worry with Phainon. Phainon who he wishes to entrust everything to. To stay by his side until the final days have come and prophecy comes to welcome them to their destined paths.

Even if he does go about doing such absurdities! He'll have to reprimand him later. But, not now. He can't fault him for his rutted haze. And he will forever argue over how pleasant it feels to experience that warm, wet muscle, accompanied by fingers abusing that bundle of nerves within him; never admit to how much he truly enjoys it, for Phainon will always tease him over it.

Another climax dawns upon him before he even knows it. Though, it is dry. His muscles tense, the heat coils within his groin, his cock throbs and aches, yet he weeps no cum.

"There." Phainon looms over him with a grin he can hardly see. "You're all prepped now."

He holds his legs apart, propping him partly up on his lap before he gropes for an errant pillow and tucks it underneath his hips. Though the tip of his cock presses against his stretched hole, Phainon hesitates. He stares and stares instead, and a shyness grows upon him.

"What are you waiting for?" Mydei rasps, unable to lift a hand, for his arms are heavy as lead.

"Just—" Phainon shakes his head, licks his lips, and, with a trembling hand, he rests his palm flat against Mydei's stomach, trailing it upwards, watching as his knuckles bump up and down along the muscles in its path. "You are too beautiful. I could eat you."

"Idiot," he grumbles and squeezes his eyes shut when his nipple is pinched and tugged. "You'll be doing no such thing."

Phainon tilts his head to the side, and amusement quirks his lip. “You’re right. I already have, and you taste as divine as I have always imagined.”

Mydei grits his teeth as heat floods his cheeks. He refuses to meet Phainon’s stare. He can’t even begin to process his words. Imagined it? He’s thought of such situations before? To find himself between his legs, mouth upon places a mouth should not be.

An intrusion fixes itself into his hole—the tip of Phainon’s cock—and he gasps a breath. Phainon hitches a whine. “You’re still so tight.”

But he does not relinquish in his insertion. His cock stretches him apart. It’s so thick—too thick. How can any omega find this enjoyable? Pain sears through him and he swears his teeth crack from how hard he grits. This is no cock inside him, but a third appendage equal to an arm.

“Mydei,” Phainon softly gasps, unaware of the tribulation he experiences, lost in the sensation of pushing himself further in.

Good. It should be this way. He can handle this temporary pain to relieve Phainon of his rut. His body is a weapon, and pain an old, welcomed friend. He’s been impaled before in ways far more destructive. This thickness splitting him apart is nothing.

Golden blood drips from the point of their joining onto the sheets, spreading out against the linens, and he mentions nothing of his pain. He bears it in silence, gripping the sheets so tight his knuckles turn white. Heaves haggard breaths as every inch deeper pulls him asunder. Phainon delves in his steady pace until his swollen knot presses against his ass.

“Mydeimos,” he says his name with a touch of reverence. A whimper slips out of him.

And when Mydei finally looks up at him, he sees the flush of his face, the daze in his eyes, yet beneath it all, beneath this rut fueled haze, the very same Phainon he fell in love with shines through like a ray parting darkened, rain-soaked clouds.

So he holds out his arms for an embrace. And, as true to his Phainon, he leaps into it, wrapping his arms tightly around his waist and burying his face into his neck.

“Mydei-!” Phainon gasps, and rolls his hips, the threat of his knot pressing up against him and his tip stirs his insides.

“*Haikas*,” he strains, scratching at his back with desperate talons and leaving lines of trailing gold, “Stop being so pathetic and hurry up already.”

If Phainon held himself back, the thread completely unravels, snaps, and his hips shift backwards and slams back in. Mydei winces from the sheer stretch, gasps from how deep it goes, and lets out a strangled groan.

Emboldened by the sound, Phainon does it again. And again. And again. Every thrust spears him with a new array of pain so deep inside it reaches his throat and webs to his skull. But, he’s used to such things. He can bear it. His body is meant for pain. Whatever the Deliverer gives him, he can endure.

But the pace increases, and he finds no salvation in attempting to bend into the mattress beneath him. No matter how he squirms, which angle he shifts his hips to, that tremendous stretch tortures him. Continues to tear at him. A strangled cry of pain rips through him as he claws into Phainon’s arms.

His lower half falls to numbness, and reconstructs itself around the intrusion, forming to shape around this cock which should be classified as a weapon instead. Tears prickle his eyes, and pour down his cheeks, mesmerizing Phainon who laps them up with long strokes of his tongue.

“You’re doing so much for me,” he hears Phainon say above the obscene slapping of skin against skin. His hot breath ghosts across his face as their foreheads press together. “Titan’s above—” he gasps as a surge of heat rushes through his core in a climax, yet the thrusting of his hips never ceases. “Mydei— I can’t stop.”

“Did I say you could?” he says with the fiercest scowl he can muster, grasps Phainon by his hair, and yanks his head back. “Or do you think I’m

incapable?”

Phainon winces, and the grip on his hips tightens hard enough to bruise. He’s lifted up higher and angled inwards, and his cock plunges even deeper in, as if it were somehow possible. Mydei lets Phainon go, and buries his face into his neck.

Because he knows, *he knows*, he is incapable. Their bodies are incompatible, and every thrust brings such a tearing pain it reaches with its claws and tugs at the threads of his heart in tandem. If he were an omega, all of Phainon—all of this—all of him—would be groaning in joy and not pain. The fluids pooling underneath him would not be of his blood, but of slick. And they would be side by side in all things, not just in battle, but in bed as well.

So, when he wraps his legs around Phainon’s waist, and chokes out a quiet sob into his neck, it's for the sorrow and not the suffering. This longing to be what he is not continues to ache and pull at the seams. The tantalizing closeness between them breaks and batters his ego, making way for these unbecoming tears of his.

If Phainon can tell, he shows no signs of awareness. He continues plunging in and out without a hint of stopping. Mydei hopes, prays, he remains unaware until his grief washes through him. For his eyes to dry and shed no light upon his turmoil.

And, somehow, this unimaginable pain begins to bleed into pleasure, giving him a false hope of compatibility. Raises his spirits until he soars again against the clouds. That sweet spot inside him pulses with raw hedonism as Phainon snaps his hips back, and the tip of his cock leads forward, rubbing against it down his full length and fixes himself back inside where he belongs.

Mydei throws his head back once again, hitting it against the headboard with a painful crack, shoving against Phainon’s shoulders as he squirms and pushes. Phainon says something—he can’t tell what—and holds him still as he enters at the same exact angle, and the same burst of pleasure jolts, rips, sears, down his entire being and exits out his throat.

They claw at one another in their tussle, Mydei unable to handle the sudden intoxicating pleasure, and Phainon who wants to give all he can. Both unwilling to compromise, and wrestle one another until Mydei finds himself restrained on his stomach, his ass high in the air as Phainon pounds into it, and clamps his fangs down upon the nape of his neck.

His legs are numb. His body hurts all over. His throat is raw. Perhaps, he should have known better than to fight an alpha in the prime of his rut. Yet he can't help this joy spreading through him. Can't help but fantasize how if he were an omega, he would be experiencing a mating bond—a perfect bond to tie them together. And such thoughts bring upon yet another dry, tearful climax from him.

He grips his sheets, twisting them into his fists, and he has no moments to catch his breath as Phainon fucks him hard, and even harder still. Another spilling of come loosens inside him, searing his scrambled insides with another layer of heat, and Phainon continues in his thrusting. The pillow collects the tears dripping from his eyes as if it were made for soaking in his ecstasy and not sleep.

Fine. He can admit his defeat this one time. Though, it was a battle he never wanted to win in the first place. His vision blurs and he frays. No longer will he pay mind to his reactions. Phainon can have him in any way he desires.

And so, Mydei succumbs to submission, and ceases his thinking.

How much time passes, he does not know. But, clarity returns when the thrusting finally ends, and his insides stretch further. A slick, wet squelch echoes through his room, and he can feel it. That swollen knot resting comfortably inside him, its searing heat and pulsations making itself known, lathering his insides with a torrent of cum.

His body aches, and his hole itches as the torn muscles desperately try to stitch themselves together. The sheets beneath him are stained with both the gold of his blood, and the white cream of cum. It’s a mess—he’ll need to clean it soon.

Phainon collapses on top of him in a sweaty, disgusting mess. Panting, purring, so pleased with himself. He curls into Mydei, resting his head against his chest. And, even in this delirium, Mydei knows this is right. This is where Phainon should be. With a weak, trembling hand, he lifts and rests it atop his head, intended to card his fingers through it, though his strength leaves much to be desired.

Ah, it frightens him how much he has wanted this. Yet who else would he ever want? His eyes slip shut, and darkness consumes him.

When strength returns to him, he stirs. His insides cramp from fullness and he feels swollen. Judging from the loud purr emanating from Phainon, he’s not asleep.

“I know you’re awake,” he says, finding the scratchiness of his voice startling.

“Mm.” Is his response.

Mydei sighs and opens his bleary eyes. The blurry mosaic decorating his ceiling appears and he tries to blink it back to clarity, and he wishes to cleanse himself. However, Phainon still does not pull out of him. The pain has dulled to an ignorable ache, and he needs to leave before things become awkward. They will need to discuss this later, but he has neither desire or energy for now.

“I need to wash myself and these sheets,” he grumbles.

Phainon stirs, and answers with a weak, “Huh?”

“I can’t lay in a pile of… fluids.”

He shifts to slide off Phainon, to get off his bed and bathe. Yet, when he does so, Phainon yelps and follows after him, unwilling to part.

“What are you doing?” Mydei says with irritation.

“What are *you* doing?” Phainon questions in offense.

“Leaving to wash myself.”

“You-You can’t just do that!”

Mydei tries to move again, but this time Phainon wraps his arms around him and holds him still. It is only now does he notice his stomach bulging, and it unsettles him.

“I am covered in both of our filth. I don’t have time for your childish behavior,” Mydei sighs. “Quit it at once.”

“You’re going to rip my dick off!”

“What?”

“What do you mean ‘what?”

Mydei stares at him in confusion while Phainon returns one of panic.

“Deliverer, speak plainly.”

“I— You can’t leave when I’m knotting you!” The flush on his face intensifies.

He blinks.

“You know—” Phainon huffs, and pulls him back in, “You have to wait till this finishes completely.”

“And how long will that take?”

“Are you serious right now?”

Mydei glowers in response.

“Hours!”

“Hours?” A slow dread fills him as his face pales. “I… did not know.”

“You didn’t know? How can you not—I thought you knew!”

They stare at one another, heads rested against pillows, sweaty bodies pressed together, bound together by his knot.

Fuck.

Chapter End Notes

> so, i think i can finally admit the whole reason i wanted to write this fic is cuz i thought the idea of forced proximity via knot is funny, and now they have to pillow talk through all their feelings. i'm so lame LOL
>
> thank you for all the comments on the last chapter. I read all of them and they brought such big smiles upon my face, but i got a sudden bout of anxiety replying to them orz random writer insecurities struck me very hard :(
>
> i hope you all enjoyed this chapter! sorry for any mistakes, it is a bit of a long chapter
>
> i post wips/updates on my progress of this fic on my twitter. if you want to follow along and be spammed by myphaidei reposts check it out ^_^

Chapter 5

Chapter Summary

> “So,” Phainon forces down a helpless swallow, his fists clenching underneath the pillow. “I apologize for this. For something you didn’t want in the first place. I got too eager in my excitement, and thought you wanted my company in the same way and I—” He can’t bear his emotions any longer, and hides his face into the bed with a groan. Mydei’s hand lingers above his head, wisps of white strands tickling his fingers. “I’m sorry, for all this.”

Chapter Notes

> **Tags updated:** Comfort
>
> chapter count updated :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“You didn’t know…” Phainon says, and scoots enough away to look down between their bodies and see the dried cum and blood. “And I’ve hurt you.”

Mydei’s panic quells to a simmer, and the sudden smell of rust fills his nose, reminding him of every painful stretch and bite he endured. How it wracked his body in a way no piercing of a spear or slashing of sword ever did. Filled him up to the brim until he could bear it no longer.

“You did no such thing,” he says.

“Mydei, please, stop,” Phainon strains, then rests his forehead against his shoulder. “Don’t you dare try to soothe me when I did this to you.”

“Physical pain is a temporary frustration.” The fingers on his bicep dig into the meat of his arm, “Hardly a thing worth noting. I volunteered to assist you, and I do not need you acting pitiful for it.”

“I’m…” Phainon shudders out a breath and says through clenched teeth, “you are so frustrating to talk to.

“I am not acting pitiful for worrying I hurt you in such an intimate manner. Not when you didn’t know what it would entail. You are not some sort of body to be used.” Then with depreciation he continues, “Tell me, would you still have gone through with this if you knew?”

The question traps him as much as their physical bodies do. He can’t pull away, turn his head and cross his arms. Scoff away the vulnerability and submerge his head into comforting solitude. He is forced to lay there, stare into Phainon’s peering gaze, and answer.

And the truth wells within his chest, overflowing his chalice, dripping down to his fingers. Yes, he would have. Undoubtedly, for he loves him so. The answer rests on the tip of his tongue, but the flowing water constricts his throat and prevents him from voicing his confession.

“I see,” Phainon murmurs in response to his holding silence, and tilts his head low, shadowing his eyes behind a curtain of white. “I should have figured that to be the case.”

Of course he takes it wrong. Whenever there is a possibility he captures it within his hand. Phainon separates as far as he can, tucking his hands underneath the pillow, trying to create a shield of his own with this distance. Yet, they are joined. Bound by the thick cock buried in his pained hole and the inescapable warmth of their hips pressing together. No matter how hard he tries, he cannot go, forced as much as Mydei is to accept their circumstance.

“Phainon,” Mydei says with a sigh, brushing his bangs away and back then curls his hand behind his head, threading his fingers through snow-white locks. “I said nothing of the sort.”

“You showed it on your face.” His brow pinches together, and his pitch warbles. “And I thought that— that you—” He cuts himself off by biting his lip and he squirms in his dejection.

“That I what, Deliverer?” He grips his hair and denies Phainon’s meager attempt in burying his face to hide away.

When Phainon refuses to speak, he emboldens himself in this sensitive moment to whisper in a softer, gentler tone, “Phainon. Answer me.”

Phainon’s breath hitches as he squeezes his eyes shut. By now, he would have made some sort of excuse to run. His heart must be racing. In a similar vein, Mydei would’ve done the same. Vulnerability is a nasty, shameful thing for warriors such as themselves. To show weakness is to know he does not carry perfection or strength, sometimes even both. It frightens any man, beckoning them to cower in their shell.

Mydei releases his hair, and brushes his thumb across his cheek, the give of his skin soft underneath the pad. He cups it with his palm, relishing in the warmth it radiates.

“I—” Phainon starts, but hesitance overcomes him. The gentle stroking of his thumb continues, and his hand presses into his cheek for comfort. Phainon squeezes his eyes shut again, struggling to speak, his breathing becomes panicked and he clutches his chest in an attempt to soothe.

They lay in silence, time ticking on by, Mydei a steady rock for him to work through whatever his depreciation onslaughts him within. Forced by their proximity, Phainon finds his courage to continue after his surge of panic diminishes. “You are important to me. I don’t ever want to lose you,” he says. “The last thing I want to do is hurt you. Make you bleed I—” he interrupts himself with a sigh, his long snowy lashes kissing his cheeks in his slow blinks. “I’d fight one hundred… one thousand… ten thousand enemies to stay by your side. No matter what it will take.”

And Mydei bites the inside of his lip as he inhales through his nose. The air is thick and fogged with the pheromones he cannot detect, stained with the scents of his wound and sex, clogging the back of his throat.

“So,” Phainon forces down a helpless swallow, his fists clenching underneath the pillow. “I apologize for this. For something you didn’t want in the first place. I got too eager in my excitement, and thought you wanted

my company in the same way and I—" He can't bear his emotions any longer, and hides his face into the bed with a groan. Mydei's hand lingers above his head, wisps of white strands tickling his fingers. "I'm sorry, for all this."

"You…" He takes his hand back and clenches it, watching how the tendons flex. "You're ridiculous. I didn't realize how out of your mind you were. Don't blame yourself for your natural bodily functions."

Phainon lets out a hollow laugh. "No, I should've been better than what I was. I should've realized how much I was hurting you and stopped. I should've realized you were clueless and didn't desire me in such a way. After all," another mirthless laugh comes as his voice drops to that familiar teasing lilt, but toned in a sardonic tint, "you are the Clueless Crown Prince."

Mydei heaves a sigh, having enough of this self imposed condemnation, and grasps Phainon by his nape, pulling him back in. Phainon lies stiff beside him, paralyzed and arms at his sides. In an attempt to ease him, Mydei cards a comforting hand through his hair, scratching at the edge of his hairline.

"Pain is not this grand thing you make it out to be—" Phainon tenses further "—but fine. I accept your apology." And the tension dissipates.

"Thank you. And I'm sorry again. Once this is over, I'll make it up to you."

"If you keep repeating this apology of yours, I'll rescind my charitable decision."

"You are a cruel prince," Phainon says.

"I only wield cruelty when necessary."

Phainon squirms within his hold, finding some sort of discomfort with either the position or so his words, and so, in return, he tightens his grasp, wraps an arm around his waist to make him still. Phainon lets out an undignified squeak and his legs slip between his. And it feels so, *so* nice.

The skin against skin, the soft tickles of his breath ghosting across his collarbone. He can fall asleep to this with ease.

“Is this really alright?” Phainon asks as if he needs permission to be allowed to enjoy this.

“Shut up,” he grumbles, annoyed with his insecurity when he has made it so clear it is.

Nothing but the sound of his heartbeat in his ears breaks the quiet stillness of his room. Their body heat mingles together once more. Slowly, Phainon wraps his arms around him again, accepting that indeed he wants this, and Mydei's eyes droop closed, relief washing through him. Then, in this small window of calm, Phainon’s thighs tense and another torrent of warmth pools within him.

“I— ah, sorry. I can’t quite control that,” he sheepishly says.

“It’s fine,” Mydei says in response, though he feels terribly awkward.

“I suppose I should warn you, my scent will linger on you for a few days,” Phainon says with a bout of shyness.

“I can’t wash it off?”

“No, it’s more sticky than a normal scenting.”

Great. Fantastic. “Anything else I should be aware of?”

“You smell wonderful?”

“I see your spirits have raised enough for a cheeky response.” He tugs on his hair.

“Just trying to make this bearable for the both of us.”

“I said I am fine.”

“You’re saying that as if you’ve taken an alpha’s cock in a rut before,” he says playfully, then darkens. “You haven’t, right?”

“No. This is the first time.”

“The… first time?”

“Mhm.”

Whatever darkness clouded his vision disperses, and color drains from his face so fiercely he resembles a sheet of parchment. “Mydei, please tell me you’ve had sex before.”

And for whatever reason, a discomfort settles deep in his chest, weighing him down. Yet he still answers, “No, I haven’t.”

Phainon takes in a deep breath through his nose, releases it through his lips, and inhales once more. “This, *this*, is your first time? Ever?”

“That is what I said.”

And the Deliverer wilts as if heartbroken by such a fact.

“Does such a thing matter?” He tries to dismiss it.

The second he finishes his sentence, the room spins and he lands on his back, hips raised on Phainon’s lap in their bound state, the man himself looming over him, and he is caged between his arms. A position he has grown accustomed to given the many hours they’ve spent in it. Though, not with such dread.

“Yes, it matters. Of course it matters!” he cries, “Mydei you–! Ugh. I can’t believe you.”

Mydei stares up at him, lost as to why he’s so upset.

Phainon rubs a hand down his face, thumb and finger massaging his temples. “You are insane for such a thing. Have you really gone mad this

time? Is Nikador around making you lose your senses? I tore you apart in the worst experience you could have had."

He continues on, unleashing his torrent of frustration and guilt he must have held on to. Never wanting to hurt him. Always wanting the best for him. Hating how he never considers his own wellbeing. Mydei waits until Phainon finishes his outburst with a careful calm, and states, "If not you, then who else would I be with?"

His mouth shuts with a resonating clamp. The hands beside his face clench the sheets, pulling at them, and his eyes grow wide before he sharply turns his head to the side, hiding his expression. "Don't say that."

"Phainon," he says, and cups his cheeks, turning him to look at him. "You are my equal. If I am to do this with anyone, it will only be with you."

To emphasize his point, he grinds his hips down and clenches his hole, tightening around that tremendous knot within him, and it gushes with another round of heat spilling into him.

"Mydei," Phainon whimpers, losing his temper in an instant, and his eyes grow hazy with wetness, "how are you always so sure of everything? I-I hurt you and yet you speak with such confidence. You know exactly what you want to say."

"Hmph. I don't know what to say every single time. I'm no all knowing god. But," his voice dips lower, "some things are rather obvious, wouldn't you agree?"

Phainon seems lost between agreeing with his statement and wanting to argue more with him. He tries to blink back the tears gathering in his eyes —tries to speak but finds his throat lodged and he needs to clear it—and Mydei gently pulls him down, pillowing his cheek against his chest.

"You don't need to hurt yourself thinking so hard. Rest," he strokes his hair, his own heart picking up pace, "and the first thing we'll do is take a bath, then eat."

Phainon rolls his hips into him for both pleasure and readjustment. “Promise?”

“I promise,” he chuckles warmly.

Hands press into the mattress and wrap around his back, and it’s all Mydei really wants in this moment. This softness between him and Phainon as they hold one another close. After a bit, the soft purr returns—subdued but present—and he breathes a quiet sigh of relief. So many times has he thought of this, but now it is here and he relishes it. The warmth, the heavy weight atop him. Even the pain of the stretch which continues to fill him becomes a backdrop to everything else.

But when his fingers graze against his back, he frowns. The skin is tender and scratched. He pulls his hand to inspect the warmth against his fingers, and finds they are stained with golden blood. He almost scoffs. Of course Phainon raises a ruckus all the while he endured a suffering of his own and never speaks of it. As if his own pain is nothing while Mydei’s an unforgivable act of sin.

A sense of responsibility flows through him. When they finish, he’ll need to dress the wounds that he caused. But, right now, he can’t bring himself to fret and worry. Not when Phainon holds him so close, just like he desires. The rumbling purr against his chest hypnotizes him. Every blink becomes heavier and heavier until his eyes can no longer open.

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In his slumber, he dreams a sweet dream. Of a place surrounded by golden wheat and a sky so clear only the sun decorates the expansive blue, warming his skin with its tender rays. Home it says. A home he has never seen or been, yet his core knows it is his.

In the distance, the dark waters of a lake sing and call him forth. And Mydei walks along the dirt path, bushy heads of wheat tickling his skin as he passes by, and over the aged wooden docks. The water is dark, and monsters roil beneath. The long limbs of krakens swirl about, the terrifying lengths of leviathans entrance him with their sparkling scales. He remembers them well, the monsters of the deep which kept him company in his familiar home of pain.

And a hand grasps his own, tugging him away and free from the asphyxiating grip. Phainon grins in his delight, pointing towards the expansive fields of wheat where smoke from a far off chimney makes itself known.

Perhaps this is the Era Nova, the next life he so desperately craves. It has to be. Otherwise, how can an unburdened smile grow upon his visage? How can he hold Phainon's hand in his as they walk side by side? How can they sit together and eat a meal in a home they call their own?

In this dream he knows peace, and Phainon, the promised Deliverer, leads him to it. They sit together. Laugh together. Behold one another with such great affections it makes his chest ache in the absurd sweetness of it all. Phainon, in his eagerness, places a gentle kiss upon his forehead.

It's so warm, tender, and everything he ever wants it to be. It crushes him with unabated happiness. In this dream, he can wrap his arms around his waist, and move in for a proper kiss. But the world around him blurs before he can, and the serene Phainon says, "See you tomorrow."

And he swears the kiss follows him into the waking world. He blinks his bleary eyes, and Phainon's blurry image overlaps the Phainon in his fantasy. He blinks again and it sharpens, yet the tender smile remains.

"Hey sleepy head, I think it's finally over," Phainon says, his voice resounding and clear. "We can separate."

He stares as his senses return, the swell of happiness rises within his chest until it reaches a crescendo and drains to the reality of this world. The one where he is prince and not yet king. He falls from the heavens, and a sorrow

fixes itself within him, and he wishes for the waking serenity to have lingered for a little while longer. Wordlessly, Mydei moves to disjoin them, eager to stretch out his stiff muscles.

“Wait,” Phainon says and wraps his arms around him before he can pull himself out.

“What now?” he grumbles in his frustration, voice hoarse from sleep.

“I doubt you’d want to make more of a mess on your sheets,” he says with an airy laugh, and runs his hands down his muscular thighs and Mydei shivers at the touch. “Wrap your legs around me. I can carry us to the bathroom.”

Mydei drops his head back to the pillow with a groan. “Fine.”

With a bit of shyness, he secures a hold around his waist with his legs. Phainon runs an encouraging hand up his arm while the other wraps around his waist. Mydei sighs as he wraps his arms around his shoulders, careful to avoid his wounded back.

“This is embarrassing,” he says into Phainon’s neck after he hoists them up into a stand.

Phainon hums in response, securing his arms underneath his thighs, then says as he begins the journey, “Less embarrassing than having my cum torrent out of you in your bed and have it drip down your legs as we walk.”

“Quit it with such foul language.” His grip on him tightens.

“What? I’m merely speaking the truth. Or, are you perhaps feeling shy?” he teases.

Mydei says nothing, and hopes the Deliverer can’t see through him.

“You are!” Phainon gasps in his cursed revelation.

“Shut up.”

“My sweet, dear Mydei embarrassed over simple words,” he coos into his ear.

And he hates how the affectionate way he refers to him causes his heart to race. He says nothing, merely tucking his face into the crook of Phainon’s neck whose breath hitches at the gesture and his hold tightens.

Once they enter the bathroom, Phainon carries him towards the bench and says, “Ready?”

“Yes.”

Without any further hesitation, he pulls Mydei down, biting down a groan, and, true to his words, the cum sealed inside gushes out with his removal. He hears Phainon inhale sharply, and lifts his head to see the intense dilation of his pupils—similar to his rutted haze.

“W-Well,” Phainon clears his throat and glances away, “lets get you cleaned up, shall we?”

“Yes.” He curls his lip in disgust as even the slightest shift causes more to ooze out. “And grab the disinfectant and bandages while you’re at it.”

“What for?” He tilts his head, eyes round in their innocence.

“Don’t give me that vacant stare. For you. You are still injured, unlike me.”

A flush colors his pale skin rosy and he scampers to fetch the supplies and a basin of water.

Mydei lifts his leg and grimaces as more globs ooze out of him. How can there be so much? With a curious hand, he presses his fingers down against the soft bulge of his belly, and his hair raises on end over the amount of cum exiting his body. The bulge barely deflates.

When Phainon returns, his eyes flicker between the pool on the bench, and the cum dripping down to the floor, accumulating there in a tiny pool of its own.

“Wow,” he stupidly says, mesmerized by the mess he is responsible for.

“Hurry up, and get over here,” Mydei snaps.

Phainon shakes himself free of his stupor and approaches. After kneeling, he says, “I’d tell you to spread your legs, but you’ve already done so. Move your hips forward closer to the ledge.”

Mydei has half the mind to kick him for such a statement. “Can anything normal leave your mouth?”

He shoots him a grin accompanied with a giggle, and says, “So, can I?” Gestures with a cloth in his hand towards the unsophisticated mess of his groin and ass.

“Does it look like I’m denying you?” Mydei hides his fluster by crossing his arms.

“No, I supposed you aren’t.”

The cloth presses against his knee first, the soaked cotton scratching at his skin, and rubs up his thigh. The stubborn dried blood must continue to cling, for Phainon takes another pass and applies more pressure, and Mydei bites down a pleased sigh. He hates to admit it, but it does feel rather nice; likes the attentiveness in which Phainon has while he cleans. He dares to sneak in a glance, and finds his expression to be one of utter focus. Nothing matters to him more than this.

More sounds of water sloshing as he rinses the cloth. More wet warmth climbing his leg and cleaning off the gold and white. Mydei continues his focus on the wall beside him, knowing if he were to watch, he might do something he’d regret. And Phainon would tease him over it forever.

“You smell nice here,” Phainon murmurs as he cleans his inner thigh. “It’s stronger than your neck. Are you trying to lure me in?”

“No,” he says flatly. Then in curiosity, “Does it really have a different smell?”

“Yeah.” He rubs against his scent gland while also cleaning up the mess. “I wouldn’t say sweeter though. More earthy. And dare I say more enticing.”

“What an odd thing,” he muses, and finds the tension in his shoulders dissipating with conversation. “Is it the same for you?”

Phainon flicks his gaze up then playfully smiles. “Somewhat. It’s not as potent on an alpha, but we do have scents down here as well. Maybe you were meant to be an omega after all.”

“Perhaps I should have been one,” he says and covers the wistfulness of his desires to share the perfect bond with an air of nonchalance.

He jolts in surprise over the statement, then laughs heartily, washing the cloth again and moving on to his other leg. “You are more than a secondary gender. You don’t need to say such things.”

Mydei scoffs at the bold proclamation, and will never admit how much he enjoys hearing those words.

“You know, I do have to say it is rather adorable how red your face gets when you’re flustered.”

This time, he does shove Phainon’s shoulder with his foot, who laughs as he catches his fall with a hand. When his attention returns to cleaning, Mydei has become more relaxed, brave enough to watch his focus. It is sweet, given all things, how much Phainon wants to make amends.

“Deliverer,” he says once the creases of his thighs are being cleaned. “What is that thing you did a while back?”

“You’re going to have to be more specific than that, my sweet Mydeimos.”

He swallows down a grumble, and snaps at him with his teeth like he has witnessed before. “That.”

“Oh.” A flush grows upon his visage, and he uses the excuse of wetting the cloth to glance away. “That’s a flirtation.”

He blinks. “Huh?”

“Like… you know…” Phainon gestures with his hands.

“No, I don’t,” Mydei says dryly. “Which is why I’m asking you.”

His entire attention focuses on scrubbing away at a spot where his skin is already clean. “It’s a way to show interest. A way to…” he hums as he tries to find proper words. “A way to say you wish to bed someone.”

His mind makes the connection to how Phainon’s fangs clamped around his nape in his rut. And how he did the gesture when they were wrestling in the baths naked.

“You are a pervert,” he deadpans.

“What?! It’s not as if you knew!” His scrubbing becomes rigorous, staining his skin red. “You know, it was easier when you didn’t listen and asked questions about these things.”

“From what I recall, you were the one who was stunned when I returned it,” he says, a smirk tugging at his lip, enjoying Phainon’s fluster. “Is that you want? To have your nape bitten and be claimed by me?”

“Okay! It’s time for the next step—!” Phainon’s face scorches as he scrambles and wrings out the cloth to the point it almost rips. “It might be a bit uncomfortable, but I have to do this unless you want to have a swollen belly.”

Mydei chuckles at the overreaction, pleased with turning the tables in this whole ordeal. “Do what you must.”

Phainon places a palm on his stomach, long fingers covering the expanse, and massages down. Mydei shivers and goosebumps travel across his back as the warm mass inside his belly shifts, and the trickle of leaking cum out of his hole expands into a gush. Phainon does it again, and he tenses in discomfort. It drips down and collects at the floor beneath him.

“You alright?” Phainon asks, rubbing a comforting hand against his thigh.

“Yeah,” he breathes out and clenches his hands into fists. “Keep going.”

And perhaps because Phainon is the one who does this, he can relax after the initial surprise. Because it is Phainon who is caring for him. The one person he considers his equal. Tension seeps out, unbinding his muscles and softening the flex of his abs. He discreetly rubs a hand across his chest, trying to quell the fluttering of his heart.

Mydei dutifully sits still, ignoring the heat gathering in his belly. His cock twitches, yet Phainon makes no note of it. He concentrates on his duty, focused on what he promised to do rather than distract himself with perversions.

He stares and stares at the top of Phainon’s head, watching as the tufts of his hair swish from side to side. The fixation upon his body, to help soothe and ease. But, Phainon has always been this way in regards to him. He can hardly recall a time where the man did not fret over his health.

And his kindness makes him want to do and say so many things. He wants to kneel down, and hug him. Kiss him so sweetly until he has his fill. Feel skin upon skin. See how Phainon would react now that he is sane of mind and himself. He wants to speak of his feelings, speak of how much he cares and cherishes him. He wants Phainon to regard him with endearment again and hold him with such a tenderness he knows his hardened exterior would melt underneath his arms.

But that clamp of restraint prevents him from his indulgence. It cools his simmering heat, schools him back into indifference, yet his desires continue to churn beneath the surface. He does not know why he is this way, simply that he was and is. The hand continues to press cum out of him, and his stomach has flattened by now.

“Deliverer,” he says, and the alpha beneath him looks up, his sky-blue eyes shining and eager to fulfill any of his requests. He swallows down a lump.

“What’s that look on your face for?” Phainon asks with a tender laugh. “You look like you’re going to hurt yourself.”

“Let me dress your wounds.” Yes, that should be enough to indulge his desires.

Phainon presses his lips into a line. “My wounds are not that bad. Let me finish you first.”

Mydei glares in his disapproval.

“You may pout, but you don’t scare me,” Phainon says as he continues his duties. “Besides, I’m almost done.”

The water in the basin has transformed from clear to murky, and it needs to be changed. The pool of cum underneath him needs to be gathered and wiped. Phainon continues to press down on his stomach even though barely anything comes out of him now.

“I am already cleaned.”

“But—” Phainon begins and Mydei silences him with a flick against his forehead.

“You worry too much. My skin has no tears, all of the blood has been cleaned, and nothing else is coming out of me. This is fretfulness overtaking reason.”

Phainon pouts and rubs his forehead. “At least let me refill the water and wipe this mess away.”

“Fine,” he rolls his eyes in acquiescing.

While the other diligently goes about it, Mydei stands and stretches out his stiff muscles. He glances down, and, much to his frustration, still sees the excitement upon his groin. Even though his immortality allows for his body to be ready, he has no desire for pleasure from his body after the previous whirlwind of lust.

Day? How long has it been? He had no mind to check his teleslate for time until now. When he turns to ask Phainon, he is silenced by the sight of mauled back. Lines of gold from his shoulders to waist litter and redden his

skin as if mauled by a real lion. There are too many, and he has no memories of marking his body in such a way. Mydei turns away to gather his bearings.

“You know,” he hears Phainon say and the thumps of his feet stepping in their approach, “Your body is truly a remarkable thing. I know I’ve said it before, but I am always amazed.”

“What are you on about?”

Phainon places the basin of water on the bench, then runs his fingers across Mydei’s nape, and the touch sends shockwaves of goosebumps in its wake. “I bit you here, and it's already gone.”

“Hmph. Perhaps I should scold you for such a thing,” Mydei says, and slaps his hand away. “From what I know, that was a rather intimate thing you did.”

And the blaze upon Phainon’s face is worth it. He stammers over his words, flapping his hands about as he desperately tries to form any sort of coherent sentence.

Mydei retains his cool composure for as long as he can before a smile cracks across his lip, and hides the bubbling chuckle behind a hand. “Relax, Deliverer. I’m no omega for such a thing to matter.”

“And thank goodness for that!” he squawks.

A burn of disappointment sears him. It must show upon him for Phainon panics and grasps his hands and squeezes tight. “I didn’t mean it like that!”

Mydei gazes at their joined hands. They are of equal size. Thin white lines of old scratches and scars decorate Phainon’s while his are clear. Phainon palms are rough from the gripping of his sword, while his soft for the gauntlets and regeneration. They fit so perfectly. Unlike how they were a few quints ago.

Phainon must mistaken his prolonged silence as continued disappointment for he stammers out his confession, “I-I simply meant it as in if you were to have a secondary gender, you would fit an alpha better.”

Mydei lifts his head, and Phainon looks off to the side. “You would think me an alpha?”

“Of course. Some people in Okhema still do.”

“I don’t understand.”

“Must you make me spell it out for you?” Phainon groans and his grip tightens.

“Here I thought you liked the sound of your voice.”

“Weren’t you going to take care of my back?” He throws his hands and takes a seat upon the bench, back facing towards him.

While his behavior annoys him, and he wishes to know the reason, he prioritizes mending his wounds. Mydei takes the fresh cloth, and dips it within the warm water of the basin. With a scrupulous hand, he wipes at the dried blood, careful not to irritate the healing scratches further. A flush reddens Phainon’s shoulders, and he doubts it comes from the warmth of the bathroom.

And when he dabs the cotton soaked in disinfectant against a particularly nasty scratch Phainon yelps and straightens out his back.

“Is it really that bad?” Phainon squirms in his pain as he applies more of it.

He’s thankful Phainon cannot see the embarrassment gracing his features. “I should’ve paid more attention to my strength.” Another pause hovers between them, and he then asks, “What were you saying about me being an alpha?”

“You aren’t going to let it go, huh?” Phainon grumbles, bouncing his leg in his anxiousness.

“No.”

A sigh. “Fine. I… I can’t say I have a preference for omegas, is all.”

The world comes to a screeching halt and he almost drops the bottle of disinfectant.

“What?”

“I know, I know, how bizarre, right? An alpha having no interest in omegas,” Phainon drawls, then imitates the voices of strangers, “What about the bond? What about the sweet scents? How could you give up on a perfect match?” He hunches forward, resting upon his elbows. “I didn’t really know what to think of it either until I spoke with Coretta.”

Mydei has no idea who he speaks of, but assumes he means one of those two omegas from before. Who else could it be? She was the one who told him of such non-traditional values, and mentioned Phainon speaking to her about the same topic.

He fidgets with his hands as he continues, “They showed me there is no shame in being different, and having a preference outside of the norm is nothing to be ashamed of.”

“So… You have a preference for alphas?” Mydei says as he tries to make sense of his words.

And Phainon lets out an embarrassed laugh. “Maybe? I don’t know I…” he quiets.

“You what?”

“Your scent is the only one I’ve ever liked,” he says. “I know you dislike it, but it reminds me of home.”

He stills, taken aback by his statement. Everything becomes too much all at once and his mouth dries.

“When I was little, I used to help mill wheat, and my mother would take the flour and bake it into bread,” he chuckles. “I still remember how the whole house would smell of it for an entire day. And perhaps, my memory of it perseveres because of you.”

“I am a beta, I have no scent,” he numbly says, his tongue too big for his mouth.

Phainon turns, and he bears a shining grin upon his visage, his cheeks flush and his eyes closed. “You can keep saying that, but it doesn’t change the fact you are wrong.”

“I am no omega,” he says.

“That is correct.”

“We do not fit.”

Phainon opens his eyes, his smile softening. “Well, maybe if you weren’t so brazen, and took me in my rut, the results would have been different.”

His eyes are so painfully blue and piercing. They see through him with ease, through all of his armor, through all of his stubbornness. They are akin to an unclouded sky, yet also similar to the calm waters of a lake. Maybe that is why Phainon can understand him, for he is as much of the sky as he is the river he once drowned in.

“I don’t think I’ve ever seen you show a face of guilt to me before,” Phainon states.

Mydei grasps the top of his head, and turns him away. He can’t bear to maintain the gaze, and the important work of bandaging must continue. “I took advantage of you.”

“That you did,” Phainon hums in his agreement, “but I’m more unforgiving of your recklessness.”

The scratches have been cleaned, and he takes the bandage wraps and winds it around his shoulders first. “It’s entirely your fault for entering a rut.”

“You’re the one who threw me on your bed! Need I remind you again that you possess a scent?” He can hear his pout. “Do you know the things it can do to an alpha?”

“Perhaps you should have better self control then, it was not my intent to drive you to perversion.”

“What a way to phrase that.”

“Enough. Can you stay quiet and let me bandage you?”

“Fine. Fine.”

And with that, the Deliverer is finally silent. Mydei can relax and cover up the wounds he left. In a way, he can understand Phainon’s frustration with him. Hurting a dear companion always leaves behind a heavy, uncomfortable feeling. And it is entirely his fault for bringing him this emotion. Guilt eats at him, and his experienced hands wrap bandages around his torso, as if his diligence here can serve as an apology for his recklessness.

“I think you went a bit overboard,” Phainon says as he picks at a bandage once he finishes.

Mydei doesn’t deign it a proper response, unwilling to admit remorse. “I’ll be soaking in the bath. Do whatever you want.”

“If that’s the case.” Phainon grabs his wrist. “There is one thing I want to do. It’s been on my mind for quite a while.”

“Then I’m sure it’s nothing good,” he says with an almost despondent sigh. “What is it?”

“You said you haven’t had sex before, but what about a first kiss?”

And he hates how Phainon’s face lights up in his question. It makes his heart thud painfully against his chest, and he wants to refuse answering him.

“I… haven’t,” he says with a tremendous reluctance and he tries to tug his hand free. The grip on his wrist tightens, much to his disapproval.

And he hates even more how Phainon glows in his excitement.

“Then we should do that,” he beams. “I mean, if you want to.”

Of course he wants to. Has Phainon missed every word he has said before this? All of his convictions were laid bare, and he still dares to tack on his insecure delusions.

“Hmph. If that is something you desire, then you should be the one to make the move.”

Phainon scoots towards his front, buzzing with energy as he leans and prods again, “Then it’s okay?”

“Yeah,” he exhales, fighting the warmth creeping up his face as he glances off to the side. Of all things he hates most, it is how his entire being breaks into a fluster over his romantic feelings—unable to maintain his normal self when it comes to tender persuasions.

A hand gently grasps his chin, and moves his head back to look back at him.

“Remember to breathe through your nose, and don’t be too tense,” Phainon instructs in such a gentle manner his hair raises on end.

“*Haikas*. Kissing can’t be that difficult.”

Phainon bites his lip to hide his laugh. His eyes skim across his face, drinking in every detail, memorizing to remember forever and more. The thumb underneath his chin ghosts down his jaw then he cups Mydei’s cheek. He leans further in without any hesitation, planting a sweet kiss upon his furrowed brow.

And Mydei clenches his hands and sucks in a breath as the warmth of his lips permeates down to his cheeks, and his heart beats to a now accustomed rhythm. He squeezes his eyes shut, unable to bear the Deliverer in such a

close way. Especially not when he feels his bangs be brushed aside, tucked behind an ear, and the next kiss presses to his forehead without any barriers.

He is naked, yes, but now even more terribly so. The warmth of his lips against his skin consumes all of his thoughts. Not in how ravishing he can bite or lick, but in the sweet adoration layered behind it. In a way he was never beheld before. It buzzes every single nerve of his, lights his skin with a fire. Phainon tilts his head to the side, pressing another savoring kiss onto his cheek, hard enough to feel the give. Hard enough for him to raise his hands, and grasp onto his forearms and squeeze.

Such a simple thing threatening to crumple his legs. Hah, it is almost unironic how he found more comfort when Phainon pinned him down with teeth and nails. Faced with the potential of a fight and harm against his body, he finds strength; yet in a moment so normal for everyone else he bends to fragility.

Phainon chuckles, his warm breath puffing close to his ear. In amusement he says, “I told you, remember to breathe.”

“I—” he starts, but the constriction and burn of his lungs denies his desire to claim he is.

So he does. Inhales and exhales through his nose, glancing off to the side to avoid his knowing smile. The heat upon his face is undeniable; stretching down to his shoulders, and deeper into his belly where embers are kindled by these soft affections.

“You are quite worked up, aren’t you?” Phainon says as he strokes a reddened cheek. “It’s almost unfair how adorable you can be.”

“A Kremnoan is anything but adorable,” he hisses in response, though the ire of it is lost in his daze. “Don’t speak as if you are unaffected.”

Phainon laughs softly, and instead of deeming him with a verbal response, he tilts his head and kisses the other side of his face. “How can I not be,” he says as he presses their foreheads together, inhaling a deep breath, “when a man such as yourself lets me do what I’ve only dreamed of.”

The swallow he forces down is almost painful. How strange, he thinks as his trembling hands find bravery to rest upon Phainon's chest, that there are no fluttering butterflies racking through his stomach. No queasy sensation to make him sick. Instead, a comfort wraps itself around his being, blanketing him with a sense of ease and want.

"Then why haven't you kissed me properly already?" He means to bleed irritation through his intonation, but it descends low to a whisper bordering on the edge of supplication—a command becoming beseechment.

And the way Phainon's chest expands underneath his palms, and the rhythm of his heart pounds against his chest, he knows it affects him greatly.

"If that's what you wish for," he murmurs, and wraps his arms around Mydei's waist, bringing him in close. "I will not deny you."

And Mydei braces himself. Closes his eyes to quell the sudden nerves which threaten to overcome him. Phainon leans in too slowly for his liking, stretching time to an excruciating eon. Their warm breaths mingle, and lips gently brush together. A spark jolts through him at the touch, and his breath hitches. His fingers dig into the soft bandages he wove around Phainon. Then, ever so carefully, Phainon presses and seals them into a proper kiss.

He remains tense. Mind both blank and racing. The hand upon his back scratches a gentle cue, and it breaks him from his stupor. Right. He can't just stand there paralyzed. He needs to return it. Mydei parts his lips ever so slightly, just enough to capture Phainon's in his, remembering to breathe, and follows his lead.

A heavy purr vibrates against his chest, and he feels the upturn of Phainon's lip against his own. He smiles in return, drinking in every moment of this closeness; a tenderness he always desired and here it finally is.

Everything about this is right. He knew it before, but now he understands what he never had—and that he craves it so. They separate from their first kiss, and he is not ready for it to end.

“Mydei,” Phainon says in a quivering voice laced with such heavy affection it strikes him with the ache of love.

And for once the smile cresting his visage is unhindered by restraint—earnest, dazzling and glorious—for Phainon to see. Mydei travels a hand up his neck, and threads it through snow-white locks, bringing him in for another kiss. Their teeth clack in his swift eagerness, but he cares little for such mistakes. It takes little effort to readjust into another sweet and wonderful kiss he craves.

The arms wrapped around him tighten as if he threatens to be taken away. Mydei finds himself not minding this possessive hold, enjoying how much the alpha craves him in this vulnerable moment. To know he is not alone in such desires.

They kiss. Again and again. Crumpling down to the floor, unable to separate, ignoring the hardness of the tiles beneath them. How many quints pass he does not know, and he has no reason to count their passings. His cock grows heavy in his desire, yet he has little interest in paying it any mind, for he is far too lost in the sweetness of his lips. In the sweetness of the Deliverer’s arm. In the cocoon of peace from the consuming world just outside the threshold of home.

He wants to enjoy the soft touches grazing his skin, the soft gasp from Phainon as he brushes his hands against his sides. That moment their kisses develop from simple affections into brushing of tongues.

Mydei chuckles over Phainon’s eagerness, and clumsily tries to follow along and learn. Learn how to return his feelings. What it means to be more than a weapon of war. Unravel the layers of his armor and steel to where that tender fire of love resides and grows.

It’s perfect. It really, really is. He couldn’t ask for anything more.

Phainon nips at his neck as he lays on his back, resting his head on the side, allowing him access to what he desires. No fangs breach his skin, no golden flow of ichor drips down to the tile. The bites are gentle in their reverence, as if asking for forgiveness for what he did the day before.

And Phainon’s stomach protests in a hideously loud groan, breaking all of the built up tension between them.

“I—” He jolts up, face searing red from embarrassment instead of passion.

After the initial surprise, Mydei breaks into a smirk. “Has nibbling on me worked up your appetite?”

“I didn’t realize how hungry I was,” Phainon says as he palms his stomach, cursing it for ruining the moment. “I think I’m actually starting to feel faint.”

“You are ridiculous,” Mydei says, but it is told with a fondness he does not need to keep within anymore. And that lightness in his chest breaks his smirk to a grin, then into an unprecedented small laugh of joy.

Phainon blinks, surprised over the sudden laugh, before he bows his head and joins in his mirth, laughing at himself.

They both stand, Phainon offering a hand to help which he takes, and rinse themselves in the bath. Mydei glares at his erection, trying to will it down, and glances towards Phainon who does not share in his troubles.

“Is your cock broken now?” he petulantly asks.

Even though his cock is flaccid, it's quite a remarkable sight. He never bothered to stare at it so brazenly before, but now he has the freedom for it without question. It hangs proudly between his legs, encompassed by curls of white hair trailing upwards towards his belly. The base of it is a darker shade of red and the skin around there is more wrinkled. The spot where his knot inflates—his mind so helpfully supplies and flashes additional images of how big it was and the painful stretch it gave.

Hm. Is it wrong to miss the pain? He can already hear Phainon’s anguish over such a question so he keeps it to himself.

“Mydei, need I remind you I emptied everything I had inside *you*. I’m quite alright for the time being,” he says with a playful raise of his brow. “If

anything, it is absurd you are ready to go already.”

“Hmph. I suppose my immortality stretches even to that front.”

“Then it’s a really good thing you were born a beta. You would have been an absolute insatiable menace otherwise.” He presses the tip of his finger against the head, pushes down, and watches it spring back up and bounce.

Mydei elbows him in the stomach, muttering curses underneath his breath.

“I can help you with it,” Phainon says as he clutches his torso and wheezes.

“No. I do not wish to be touched.” He turns around, lathers himself with soap, and gathers water to rub it off.

“Is it because I teased you?” Phainon hovers in his worry.

“Don’t be so full of yourself,” he says, and wants to leave it at that, but Phainon’s continued hovering makes him heave a sigh. “Even if I am excited, it does not mean I have the desire to be touched.”

The answer seems to satisfy him. They finish cleaning themselves, Phainon ever so careful with the bandages wrapped around him, and dress for the outside. Before they depart Phainon stands beside the door, and closes it when Mydei tries to open it.

“You forgot one last thing.” He grins, one hand pressed against the door as he leans on it and the other points to his lips.

Mydei grumbles in his exhale then gives a kiss to cease his childishness. And, much to his annoyance, Phainon lets out a satisfied hum.

“So you can listen,” he says, and Mydei shoulders him out of the way, neutralizing his countenance once he steps outside the threshold of home.

Curious gazes peer at them as they make their way to Marmoreal Diner. Kremnoans murmur to one another, gesturing with their heads, no doubt discussing what must have gone down. Even if Phainon’s pheromones

weren’t all over him, their joined seclusion undoubtedly would have raised questions.

And he cares little for their disapproval now. Not when he has experienced the joys of what it means to be held and gazed upon with such a reverence. No longer does he only know the touch of pain.

The Okhemans are effortlessly more nosy, given how the Deliverer regards them with an open smile. They know he is safe to approach, and some do. They come with smiles hiding their true intentions. The way their gaze flits about the two make their intentions quite known. Mydei bears a permanent scowl in their presence, and Phainon quickly excuses them.

When they finally make it to the diner, he makes his way straight towards the table wedged into a corner in the back; hiding away from curious onlookers who want to know too much. Phainon sits across from him, grinning all the while. All the tension from his shoulders has disappeared, and the darkness underneath his eyes vanished. He looks like a new man, glowing in a brilliant dawn.

The waitress comes by to take their orders, and Phainon orders his rocklamb ribs. Mydei, in a competitive bout, orders the same meal but with an additional helping of dromas meat. Phainon narrows his eyes, and requests to add an additional portion of ribs. Not to be outdone, Mydei orders a serving of three. The waitress nods all the while, scribbling their ever increasing order down.

And that is how they end up with two additional tables joined to theirs. Plates upon plates of food stacked high, they tear through meats and bread, competing to see who could eat the most. A crowd gathers around them, placing bets between the Prince and Deliverer.

His cheeks are stuffed with food as he vigorously chews and inhales it down—he cares greatly to win—but there is a sense of calm which prevails. The people around cheering them on for such a menial thing, not caring for politics or him reeking of Phainon’s pheromones. A sense of comradery and joy. Some even go as far as to refill their cups with juice when needed.

By the end they lay face down on the table, clutching their aching stomachs as the crowd hoots and groans over the winner and loser. Mydei peeks through his lashes as he wills his stomach to digest faster, and spots Phainon peering at him with a smile.

He chuckles at the sight, and that fond smile grows larger. Underneath the table, Phainon hooks his ankle around Mydei’s foot, and the closeness leaves him happy.

Maybe everything will be alright. Maybe this will work.

Chapter End Notes

> i pushed myself to get this out by the morning because i'm gonna be at a con all weekend and not writing! guess who's gonna drop mad money on phaidei merch at the artist alley? MEEE!! I apologize if there is any funkiness this chapter for that reason. i really wanted to get it out for you guys so I did almost all of the editing in one day.
>
> thank you for all the lovely kudos and comments. i re-read them so often to gain a boosts of strength T_T this chapter was quite difficult to write. i had ideas of how it should go that weren't working. I wanted to write one more smut scene before i finished off the fic, but it just felt too fast and i didn't want the chapter to take forever and be 20k words long. so between erasing and moving some stuff towards the next chapter, i decided to extend this scene and take my time with it. i hope you all enjoyed it!
>
> i post wips/updates on my progress of this fic on my twitter. if you want to follow along and be spammed by myphaidei reposts check it out! i'll probs also take pics of the haul i end up with fnsdlfsd

Chapter 6

Chapter Summary

> The way Phainon brightens as if he handed him the sun makes him flush and glance away. A pleasant tingle courses through his skin when Phainon closes the distance and their shoulders press together. He leans against him in return, rests his head against his and closes his eyes, feeling the rise of Phainon’s body as he inhales deeply in contentment.
>
> It is nice. No, that’s too simple of a word. It is a closeness he craved for as long as he remembers. It is quiet and sweet. Where strain and doubt bleeds out of him like river streams and dilutes into the water, cleansing his body and soul and filling him with tender joy. Now, he can savor the weight of the one he considers his equal in all things.
>
> For once Phainon has nothing to say; too lost in his own enjoyments for a long while, but peace can never last with his running anxieties.

Chapter Notes

> Oh my gosh we're finally at the end!! Thank you all for reading and making it to the last chapter. It is the longest one yet so get comfortable :D
>
> **Small disclaimer for this chapter:** Canon typical violence. Discussion of Mydei topping, but he has no interest in it.
>
> **NSFW specific for this chapter:** Dry humping, nape biting/biting, anal fingering, anal sex, light dom/sub undertones

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Frustration soon builds at his newfound predicament when he returns home after their outing. The two parted ways on amicable terms—Phainon saying he had business to attend to with Aglaea—and he took one look at the

soiled bedding and stifled a groan. Ruined, absolutely ruined. The dried mess of cum and gold stuck to the sheets, soaked down to the mattress. Blurry memories of the night invaded—how his body pressed down into the mattress, Phainon on top of him lost in his haze of lust.

Mydei fights them away, trying his best to not let them disturb his peace as he tugs the sheets free. To his dismay they crinkle from the excess amount of dried fluids, more than he realized at a glance. Given the amount, a part of him wonders if he died from blood loss. After all, there is a suspicious chunk of memory missing, lost to the dark recesses of his mind, but he never woke in the river of souls so such a thing must be out of the question.

A shiver runs down his spine, tingling around his tenth thoracic vertebrae, as a sick part of him wonders how such a sensation would feel; to die and awaken to penetration. Though, Phainon would never indulge him in such acts, much less entertain even caressing the idea. He can already hear his disgust and shock over it, see the dismay creep upon his countenance.

But, he must have lost consciousness at some point—be it from blood loss or over overstimulation—and the alpha never noticed. Better to keep this knowledge to himself, lest Phainon bursts a vein from worry and self flagellations.

The light crunch of the ruined sheets underneath his grasp bring him back to reality from such musings. How disgusting. He might as well burn it all. Buy everything new and never raise awareness of this.

Even when he congregates with his advisors to catch up on the latest news, his recollections of the heated night never let up. They slip into his vision, cloud his gaze, and the voices around him buzz into incomprehensible murmurs. The memories flicker from raw lust of penetration to the sweetness of when Phainon regained his clarity. Such idle daydreams let him ignore the sting of his people’s disapproval, their disgruntled mutterings of how he should never fraternize with the Okheman alpha.

His alpha advisors find the most disdain over his disposition. Here he sits at the table, seeped in the alpha Deliverer's rut pheromones for all to know, his demeanor pulled into careful neutrality to let nothing slip, but his gaze is

distant and blinks back to focus whenever his attention is called for. Their lips curl into poorly contained sneers while whispering disapprovals to the betas seated beside them. No one pretends it to be anything else, they all know what happened.

Krateros, as his closest advisor, sits beside him and eyes warily from his profile, yet he holds his tongue. They discuss what to bring up in the next council meeting to ensure the prosperity of their people. He tries to focus, he really does, but his treacherous thoughts keep wandering off to that blasted Deliverer. Remembering how hot his skin felt against his. The searing pain ebbing into confusing pleasure.

Having never experienced such a thing before, how can he bring himself to think of anything else? How he can have it again at a request now that the lines of camaraderie have crossed to something more.

When they break for lunch, he strides off to the side to sit in his lonesome, and they are happy to give a wide berth, undoubtedly because of the Deliverer’s pheromones clinging to him.

They are upset, and he cares little for it. After the single challenge from Krateros and witnessing his loss, they understood the message and their place. Violence being the utmost value of their traditions became his sword to wield, and he is glad for it. Might trumping all is their creed, and they will listen. Accept the bitter medicine he forces down their throats and have it dissolve in their systems to cure them of their unjust prejudices.

One day, they will let go of this hatred of an outsider. Until then, he will appreciate the few who support him and his actions. It is a soothing balm to know there will always be those who back him.

“Mydeimos,” Krateros greets in a stiff approach.

He regards him with a single nod, tensing as he prepares himself for an unkind conversation.

“You are distracted,” he says.

“Nothing escapes your notice, teacher.”

“Yes, if it did I would’ve made a poor General.” He stands at his side, eyeing him in disapproval. “I see you have decided to bed that boy.”

A discomfort cinches his chest and he clenches his jaw, grinding his molars together in minuscule motions. The scrutiny leaves him exposed, and he curses the alpha pheromones clinging to him, making his embarrassment more pronounced than it should be.

“I have,” he says with as much conviction as he can muster.

“And here I thought you were passed the stage of youthful rebellion,” Krateros says with a shake of his head.

“This is no rebellion,” he retorts, though his tone wavers. “I simply did what I thought was right.”

Krateros hums in response. Then after a moment he says, “At least soothe my soul with knowledge you did not submit.”

“I did not,” he says, a bit confused over what he means.

And Krateros, knowing him for a majority of his life, picks up on this queue of innocence. “Please tell me you were not the receiver of this... transgression.”

Mydei stares at him, dumbfounded over the plea. Did such a thing truly matter? He did not think it did, yet his grave visage made him second guess his opinions. Nowhere in his knowledge of Kremnoan history has such a thing come up before, but never has a beta decided to bed an alpha.

“I…” Mydei swallows. He can already see what will happen if he speaks the truth. Krateros will grow cold in his anger. Find Phainon in the middle of gods knows what he’s doing and take his frustrations out on him. And, like the good Deliverer he believes himself to be, he will respectfully take on the anger, take on the blame for something they both agreed to and add to his burdens.

But the greater painful truth is how it will wedge a further divide. The fist of tradition will clench tight around them and constrict until their heads pop. Cold sweat prickles his skin. He can't have that be. He won't allow it.

“I was not,” he lies. It tastes odd and unpleasant against his tongue.

Krateros presses his lips into a thin line, the crease of his furrowed brow deepens. “I see.”

And the way he speaks, Mydei doubts he believes his words. Yet, he has no way to confirm this falsehood, and lets himself believe his statement. Without any other words, Krateros takes his leave towards the idling advisors.

Mydei stares at his retreating form, questioning the sudden call to lie. He could have told the truth, taken the brunt of his increased disapproval and allowed Phainon to maneuver around it. Yet, he took the cowards way out, avoiding confrontation for an indiscernible reason. And for what, to ease his own life? How pathetic he has become. But he can't deny the heaviness lifting from his chest, letting him breathe easier, and he despises such a thing. It should not be so.

He tries hard to lock such thoughts away, toss them to the wayside, yet for the very first time he finds he cannot. Phainon delivers many firsts for him, whether he knows it or not, and he curses his name for it. He’s becoming less of himself, less of the hardened weapon he knows himself to be. A sharp metal edge breaking into brittleness.

Krateros speaks to the other advisors, and even from this distance they visibly relax. It squeezes his chest. Did it really matter that much? Perhaps he should give an apology to Phainon for lying about their bedroom activities. And doubt begins to overtake his virtuous intentions. Did he truly do it for his sake, and not for his cowardice and insecurities of this soft new love?

He’ll need to apologize.

☼

“You said what?” Phainon laughs in his face the moment he finishes his confession, much to his displeasure.

They walk through the streets down to Marmoreal Palace. Phainon nabbed him away from his duties during the fourth quint of Action Hour and he is grateful, even if his companion always manages to evoke frustration. The stares from both Kremnoan and Okhemans were beginning to make his skin crawl.

“Must you make me repeat myself?” he grumbles as he rubs a gauntleted hand down his face.

“Yes, please. I must hear how my dear Mydeimos lied for the very first time in his life about *sex* of all things,” he laughs again, clutching his stomach as he folds forward.

“It is not funny,” he huffs, crossing his arms to shield himself from embarrassment. “I panicked and I did not wish for you to be harassed again.”

“You know I can handle glares and ill words thrown at me. I’m not a delicate flower who needs to be coddled,” Phainon assures, wiping away the tears clinging to his lashes. Then he smiles in such a smug way it irritates him.

“What?”

“Nothing, nothing.”

“Does it annoy you? I know alpha’s tend to care about the most minor of things,” he spits his words with heated venom.

“No, not particularly,” Phainon hums as the curtain of water parts for their entry, and they both bow to the statue of Phagousa as is customary during

entry. “If it makes your life easier to have people think I take it up the ass then I don't mind at all.”

Before he can sputter a response Phainon jogs towards the receptionist, and leans on his elbow against the counter as he grabs the attention of Xenia, breaking her out of idle day dreams. Mydei shakes his head. Of course he'd say something ridiculous.

“ — a reservation for Curtain-Fall Hour for two please,” he hears Phainon gleefully say as he approaches, frowning at how the Deliverer has already made up his mind for dragging him here so late in the night again.

The receptionist nods along, and pulls out her tablet to plug in the reservation. After a moment she says, “Oh. This is weird.”

“What’s wrong?” Phainon asks with a tilt of his head.

“It’s erroring out on me. Let me try again.”

Phainon sends him a shrug. Her fingers tap away on the screen, and they wait.

“It says you are banned from Curtain-Fall Hour reservations.”

“What?!” Phainon slams his hands on the counter in his dismay as he leans forward to catch a glimpse of the monitor. “Surely that must be some sort of error. I have received no such warnings before.”

“It’s what it says.” She tilts the screen far enough for them to see. In bolded letters it unmistakably reads: banned. “Sorry, I can’t help you passed this.”

Phainon’s face twitches.

“Am I banned as well?” Mydei asks out of sheer curiosity.

Xenia types his name in and after a pause says, “Yep.”

He snorts in amusement while Phainon anguishes.

“There must be some sort of mistake—a mix up,” he cries as his desperate gaze turns to Mydei. “I’ll speak with Aglaea on this and it will be all fixed before we both know it.”

Before Mydei can respond, he races inside of the building, his coat tails flickering like wind-whipped fires in his haste. He bites down a laugh and follows at a leisurely pace after grabbing the provided robes for them. From a distance, he sees the elevator wind down then up with the familiar sight of the Deliverer pacing about.

A few curious glances are thrown his way in his stroll, and his ears twitch over hushed whispers. The beta prince bedding the alpha Deliverer. How unusual for the crowds to hear and behold. An alpha with a beta. No shared bond between the two. How scandalous it is for him to not be a female beta. The pleasant perfumes of the baths mute the clinging rut pheromones, and none dare approach to learn if the rumors are true, for his menacing stature and glare scares them away.

By now, he has accepted he will not escape these rumors and pointed glances. So, he holds his head high and keeps his back straight; walks with proud steps and appears unbothered over their commotions, as if they never existed in the first place.

In the Hero’s Bath, Phainon animatedly talks with Aglaea, his arms waving and arcing in distress while Aglaea stands stoically, taking in his grievances. Quietly, he approaches the one sided argument.

“ —aid before. I promise to keep my hands to myself. Mydei never takes care of himself, and the golden waters here heal. To take such a thing away would be to deny a Chrysos Heir their health.”

When her gaze shifts above his shoulder, Phainon turns and purses his lips into a pout before saying, “Surely you agree it is ridiculous to have us prohibited from entry during Curtain-Fall Hour.”

“Depends on why we are,” he says and tosses Phainon his change of clothes, then proceeds with the task of unclasping his armor.

“It is now common knowledge the two of you are more of an intimate item than before,” she states as if she's learned such a thing through conversation and not her golden threads. “Not that I blame you for any potential mishaps, Mydeimos, but Phainon here has an aptitude for rebelling to see exactly how much he can get away with.”

Phainon’s face scrunches as if he has eaten a lemon. “That is a degradation of my character.”

“If that is the case, then perhaps you could explain to me why I must always chastise you for nudity in the baths when night is upon us? Adding in the reservation restriction hasn’t stopped you from indulging in these whims.”

“I— Well,” he clears his throat and tries to regain his composure. “You see, Lady Aglaea, bathing in the nude has quite the list of benefits.”

Aglaea indulges him in his long winded explanation while Mydei finishes with his armor and changes into the provided robes, storing his royal attire and armor neatly away to the side. Phainon continues with his ramblings the entire while—perhaps his passionate speeches bring joy to Aglaea for she lets him go on and on—and he slips inside the golden waters, exhaling in relief as the warmth laps at his skin, unwinding the tension of his muscles.

“Deliverer,” he says over his shoulder, and Phainon jolts in place as his head snaps to look at him. “Are you finished yet?”

He whips back and forth between Aglaea and him as he struggles between continuing on his fervent explanations or join him in the bath. It is cute, Mydei finds himself thinking as his heart grows with fondness. Aglaea herself bears a hint of a smile, and he figures her to think the same.

“Phainon,” he repeats, dipping his voice into an irritated command, “Quit your stalling and come.”

“Right— Right.” Phainon exhales as he nods, then to Aglaea he says, “I’ll continue on making my case at a later point in time.”

Aglaea waves him away and continues about her duties, summoning her golden threads and touches them with delicate fingers, feeling what the city of Okhema provides and needs. As she does so, she steps far enough away to give them privacy. In the meanwhile, Phainon strips off his clothing and bandages, tosses his heavy attire next to Mydei's and carefully enters the water, being careful to not irritate the scratches on his upper back.

He sits stiffly beside Mydei, hands clenched atop his thighs and back straight, as if building his courage to ask something inconceivable. But his desires are simple, for they lead him to request in a strained voice, “Can I lean against you?”

Mydei holds back a chuckle, and says, “Sure.”

The way Phainon brightens as if he handed him the sun makes him flush and glance away. A pleasant tingle courses through his skin when Phainon closes the distance and their shoulders press together. He leans against him in return, rests his head against his and closes his eyes, feeling the rise of Phainon’s body as he inhales deeply in contentment.

It is nice. No, that’s too simple of a word. It is a closeness he craved for as long as he remembers. It is quiet and sweet. Where strain and doubt bleeds out of him like river streams and dilutes into the water, cleansing his body and soul and filling him with tender joy. Now, he can savor the weight of the one he considers his equal in all things.

For once Phainon has nothing to say; too lost in his own enjoyments for a long while, but peace can never last with his running anxieties.

"Mydei, does it bother you?" he asks in a timid manner.

"Does what bother me?"

"Will it become an issue if you speak of being the receiver in sex?"

"No, because I won't make it an issue. I made a cowardly mistake. That is all."

Phainon hums in thought, his gaze drifting towards the fountain spilling water across from them. The golden water flows at a steady pace, almost in a hypnotizing pattern as the gold reflects the light and glistens.

"I don't want to cause you trouble."

"You already have."

Phainon stretches out his legs underneath the water, then deflates against him. "I apologize."

"For what?"

"I can't help this feeling that I did something wrong."

Mydei opens his eyes and sends him a sideways glance. "There is nothing to fret over. What's done is done."

"Do you want to switch our roles and have me actually be the receiver?"

Mydei presses his lips together. The thought never occurred to him, and the more he delved down that route, the more he found himself disinterested with the notion. Displeased even. "I don't have a desire for it, no."

"But it would be easier," Phainon says, "At least, in that way, I won't be hurting you."

Now irritation pricks at him. The words remind him of his insecurities, and he doubles down in his indignation. "That should not be a concern of yours. My body is a weapon that can handle any amount of pain. Don't go on speaking as if you possess something I am incapable of receiving when I survived the burden of death many times over."

"I wish you'd stop thinking of yourself in such a way," Phainon's voice softens into a gentle murmur. "You are more than that. You are Mydei, a person who deserves to be treated as more than a tool." His hand wraps around his shoulders, palm gripping at his arm, and tugs him inwards. Mydei's head cradles into the crook of his neck, and he breathes in deep. "My dearest companion and rival."

"Hah," Mydei throws in a small laugh. "You are a fool then."

"Perhaps I am." He plants a kiss on the top of his head. "But if it takes a fool to convince you of your senselessness, then I will gladly be a jester in your court."

The fingers on his shoulder begin to trace soothing patterns, following the tattoos upon his skin, and it's nice. A fuzziness grows in his head, and he finds it difficult to rebuke his sentiment. Not when butterflies flutter in his stomach, and all he wants is to indulge in this closeness.

"I have no need for a jester. That is an Okheman thing to want."

At that Phainon laughs. "Oh, we're going there now are we? How else am I supposed to tell you are human like the rest of us then? That you're not someone who should be relegated to fight and die for the sake of everyone else. That you can also enjoy these tender moments between us without thinking of yourself as a tool." Phainon cups his cheek, thumb tracing the red diamond. "Even a touch like this makes you flush. Besides, you know I'm not from Okhema."

He has no strength to summon his will and push his hand aside, to not allow himself to bask and indulge in this weakness of his. Restraint usually clamps itself down with a great force and he can shrug it away. But when he stares into the blue expanse of his eyes his tongue twists upon itself and his breath catches in his throat. They are so close, and he wonders if Phainon will kiss him. The way his gaze flits about his face he must be thinking of it. He must. What else could be on his mind? It's all Mydei can think of. It's all he wants.

Yet Mydei stays still. He can't bring himself to lean into his desires. Can't bring himself to accept the softness his heart possesses. It's crude and unlike his vicious self. He's never known such a life, and can't bring himself to cross the distance, even when it's right before him. Even when his yearnings beg for it. Even when it is welcomed.

"There's no need for restraint, my beloved," Phainon murmurs in a low gentle voice, and Mydei squeezes his eyes tight at the endearment.

"Shut up," he says through his fluster and tries to shift away, but it comes off as a twitch instead, his body rooted in place, unwilling to part. "Don't call me that."

The alpha hums in amusement as he tilts his head. "I didn't think you'd have such a strong reaction to a pet name. What about something classic like honey or— oh! My day? It's quite similar to your name."

And his heart pounds harder and harder with each mocking. Though, is it truly mocking when he likes it so? This softness aimed at him and only him. But he can hardly handle the sudden onset of affection—to hear such things from the alpha he considers his equal, it overheats him in a way he never experienced before.

He wants Phainon to stop talking. To not continue listing more endearing names. That traitorous mouth of his continues to go on and on—darling, baby, dearest—until he realizes he can do what he never thought of before.

Mydei grips the back of Phainon's head and surges forward, shutting him up with a rough kiss. His technique must work, for he can feel Phainon smile into it. Wraps his arms around him, and leans into it.

"You will call me no such things in public," he hisses once they part.

Phainon smirks in return. "But I can in private?"

His mouth clamps shut and his brows knit together. With reluctance he mutters, "... Fine."

"Then, I will have to keep testing to see what I like best, my dear," Phainon says with a grin too bright to behold, and kisses him once more, slow and sensual.

And he groans because Phainon is annoying. Irritating. Aggravating! But also because he hates to admit how happy it leaves him. To be a darling; a beloved. It's new in his life. So terribly new. What should burn his blood hot with irritation instead warms with affection.

"You should pick one for me too," Phainon says after they part, smiling in delight.

"I already have one for you," he leans in and whispers against his ear, "*haikas."*

"What does that word even mean? You keep using it." His arms drift to his waist, flustered by the warm breath ghosting across his ear.

"I'm likening you to a hyena. It is an apt way to describe you," he taunts, a playful smirk tugging at the corner of his lip.

"A hyena?" Phainon gasps, "Are the Kremnoans truly so dense as to have such an animal for their darlings?"

"You..." He tames his spark of irritation. "Are one of the stupidest men I know."

And Phainon laughs in such a playful manner. "I'm kidding. I know you meant it affectionately."

Perhaps when he originally called him that, he meant it with great distaste. After all, when they first met after their death match he wanted nothing to do with him. The mountain of responsibilities stacked upon his shoulders, the fresh wounds of his dearest friend passing, and this annoying alpha sauntered up to him, talking about his body and asking about his weaknesses. Back then, all he wanted was to remain in solitude and go about his duties as crown prince. It was his role. It was his safety net.

But, now he knows more; the softness of Phainon's cheeks, the give of his lips against his own, the slickness of his tongue brushing against his. And he deems himself lucky to have such things in his life. To be a beta and have an alpha within his arms. One who cares little for intended dynamics, discards the idea of a perfect bond. A bond he agonized over, for how could he ever expect anyone to disregard intrinsic biology?

He cannot scent him. Cannot smell him. Cannot mark him. But, he can put aside his hesitations to kiss him and show how deep his affections go, for

the crown prince never beheld anyone in such a way before and will not for anyone else. He allows his body to relax and melt into the touch of his alpha. Sigh in contentment against his lips as they kiss again and again by his lead.

Mydei hears the clicking of heels disappearing into the distance, and he glances around the chamber to note it is empty. But, before his pragmatism can consume him, warm lips press against his neck, teething and suckling, leaving a mark which will disappear in a few moments. Yet it does not stop the breathy sigh escaping and he cranes his neck to give room for more.

"You smell so nice," Phainon says in a reverent whisper.

"I smell like you." His breath hitches as Phainon bites into his muted gland, drawing out more of his scent, then licks at it.

"Exactly. Even if your scent is weaker, it still mixes with mine and it's..." A sigh, the pleasant sensation of fingers digging into his back. "So wonderful."

Heat blooms in his groin at the adoration, at the closeness. Uncoils in a way he never thought possible. He bites down a groan. "*Haikas.*"

Phainon laughs, kisses up his neck, to his jaw, and captures his lips once more. And he wants more. So much more. This heated desire roils within him, burning his skin, igniting a buried flame.

This burst of his cravings blinds him as he slips his tongue into Phainon's mouth. Rubs it against his. Licks at his teeth. Cuts it against his fangs by mistake and a tinge of copper spreads. More, he needs more.

But he can't give into his desires.

Not like this, not here. He'd make a fool of himself acting so recklessly in the baths. He disallows the growing fire to spread, extinguishes it before it can become a blaze. What they already shared is enough for him.

"Sweetheart..." Phainon breathlessly coos after he pulls away, nosing at his neck again, scratching needily at his back. Ah, he likes that name—it's everything a Kremnoan is not. "You don't need to tone yourself down when it's just us. I can handle you."

"It's not that," he says, feeling the scratch on his tongue mend. "We're in public."

"Semi-public."

"Public enough," he says and pushes Phainon off him.

"Alright, I'll keep my hands to myself." As if to make his point he dramatically lifts his butt and creates too much distance between them.

"Not that far away," Mydei grumbles in displeasure, and Phainon snickers.

He settles close to him again, shoulders pressing together, and conks their heads. "My picky prince."

Mydei mutters underneath his breath, but says nothing else, for he knows Phainon will twist his words and goad him again.

That, and he needs to calm his racing, thundering heart.

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His attention continues to drift to a startling degree of deterioration.

Here, in the middle of listening to his advisors dispute over the last meeting, he is hardly present. It's all topics he's heard before; which alpha offended a Kremnoan omega with their impotent backwards ways, which store has scoffed and turned them away, how many people try to harass them. There are even frustrated rumblings of having to teach others of their fighting techniques; a design he incorporated to build bridges.

But, how can he focus when there is a fresh new wave of love in his life? He wants to spend his time with Phainon, listen to his nonsensical yammering, feel the warmth of his hands on his body. In public spaces, they keep a cordial distance, permitting a casual arm over the shoulder as their greatest contact. Phainon argued for more, but he needed to acquiesce to the fervor of his tribe over this budding relationship. Phainon begrudgingly complied, knowing he needed to be patient.

In private, it is a different story. They can never keep their hands off one another. His roiling blood is soothed by arms around his waist, and lips upon his. When Phainon steps away for a moment, he finds himself following after him, immediately missing his presence. Much to his chagrin, Phainon teases him over it. But what else is he supposed to do? He wants him.

Much to his displeasure, Phainon still accepts challenging requests from Kremnoans. His people hide it behind wanting to test their strengths about their supposed savior, but he can see their discontent with their coupling still.

He hears how a male beta should not be with an alpha. Hears how they assume he's lost his mind after suffering too many deaths. How he is blinded by the poisonous opulence of Aglaea, and has become perverse for it.

And it saddens him, but he will prove them wrong for thinking in such a way. Blaming them for their naivety and impudence would be foolish of him. He can show them he is now whole. They should be thankful he no longer abides by the ways of Castrum Kremnos, for speaking in such a manner would have them beheaded by the first quint of Action Hour.

Phainon, always being one to please, indulges them in these requests; takes on their anger and hatred, wears it upon his person as if it were a mantle.

"You do not need to do such a thing," Mydei chastised him one evening as they laid in bed.

And Phainon simply smiled and kissed his forehead after brushing away his bangs. As if that action was a good enough answer.

At least he is no longer relentless in his pursuit, doesn't push his body to the absolute brink of collapse like before.

For one, Mydei is less lenient with his dedication towards this ridiculous cause. A stern glare is all it takes to get the Deliverer to wilt and cease his insolence. And Phainon rests better these days, this he knows for they often spend their nights together. On many of those nights they tangle with one another, but Phainon pulls away and refuses him when their touching gets too heated. Another frustrating cause for his daydreams.

He's fine with taking things slow. Really, he is. But it brews a precise irritation within him when he is rejected. It simmers beneath the surface, prickling at his skin, but he can handle it. No matter how many times ravishes his lips and desires more. Or sits on his lap. Or when he rubs himself against his tented pants. Mydei grits his teeth in agitation as he recalls Phainon pulling away again last night.

And Phainon had the gall to urge him to lift his restraint. The thickness of his cock pressed against his ass, yet he was the one to back away when it became too much. He whimpered in desire, breathed all ragged against his collarbone, and clawed at his back when he grinded down his hips, then his body tensed as if he remembered something awful and killed his own mood.

"—aying attention, Mydeimos?" Krateros sternness snaps him out of his thoughts. Right. He needs to stop idling. Phainon can't pull at his being when he isn't even present. How ridiculous.

"My apologies."

A few Kremnoan omegas giggle from a distance and talk in hushed tones to one another. The look of love they say, and he fights down the embarrassment which threatens to overtake him.

The most frightening aspect of this new relationship is how unceasingly it occupies his thoughts—unused to being an object of desire, let alone

desiring another. An anxious dread he never experienced creeps just below the surface, and he worries over losing his edge, over his blade becoming dull with fluttering thoughts and unneeded desires.

But he wants to sleep with Phainon again. Craves it, for this time Phainon will be lucid. That rut of his was never a proper experience, and he aches to see him come undone. Watch him break as he thrusts deep inside and fills him up.

Once Parting Hour arrives, he does as the name suggests—he departs from his duties and makes way to the Deliverer's house, ignoring the incessantly giggling over nosey individuals. The door is already unlocked, and pushes through. His dwelling is smaller than the one provided for him; a simple town house, the living area small and the bedroom half the size of his. The place is one his city guard salary could afford, not a gift of luxury provided by station.

Even if his home is small, it doesn't stop him from having antiques scattered about. A multitude of amphoras line his table—a section cleared for dining—smaller items taking up space on countertops and other tables. His alpha sits on the kline in the living room, inspecting yet another amphora.

"Hey," Phainon greets without turning.

"Hmph. Have you found your miracle antique you can sell to become rich?"

He laughs weakly and places it down neatly on his coffee table alongside two others he must have purchased today. "I'm afraid I've wasted yet another paycheck on duds. One day I'll be lucky enough and snag something worthwhile."

Mydei stifles his lecture on how if he saved all of his earnings instead of spending it on fakes for that one percent chance of luxurious wealth he would have been better off. Starting a stupid argument is not on his agenda tonight.

He stands in front of him, arms crossed and scowling.

"Hello," Phainon says, tilting his head to the side. "Have I done something to upset you, or is this a strange Kremnoan greeting I've never had the pleasure of experiencing until now."

"Let's have sex."

A pause at the sudden request. "You're very romantic, have I told you that?"

Mydei rolls his eyes and clamps a hand down on his shoulder. "I know you are running away from something. And I'm tired of pretending you're not."

Phainon rubs the back of his head, and glances away. "Whatever do you mean?"

"You know exactly what I mean." He narrows his eyes. "Quit pretending and tell me what is wrong."

He sighs and his gaze drifts to the floor between them. His hand reaches up, grasping the one on his shoulder, and gently pries it off him, urging Mydei to take a seat beside him on the kline.

"Nothing gets past you, does it?" Phainon says as their shoulders brush together. "I don't want to hurt you again. I still have a great distaste over what I did to you last time."

Mydei quiets at his admittance. By now he has repeated a multitude of times he has no issues with pain, assured him it was a mere backdrop of his life. A tiny footnote. Though, he can't reprimand him for not listening. This time it is not because of his disregard in combat, but in the most intimate of acts. He will need to approach this with grace.

"How much do you remember?" he asks.

Phainon hums as he closes his eyes, then tilts his head up and his gaze drifts between corners of the ceiling. "I don't need to have a perfect memory of what happened to know. I felt the blood on my skin, smelled it in the air, and the way you..." he inhales sharply, "gave up. I don't want to experience that again." And when he turns to him, a wetness dampens his eyes,

prickling Mydei with guilt. "You are already so reckless with your life. I don't want to add to your pain."

Mydei studies the hurt etched onto his features, and deems it not fit for the Deliverer. After a moment of hesitation, he grasps Phainon's hand in his, slotting their fingers, and squeezes. Bites down his explanation of how he is a weapon and how he should not worry. Instead, he continues, "I want you, that is all. I understand your concern, but any pain I endure is what I have decided to bear to be with you."

A tinge of pink dusts Phainon's cheeks as he lets out a small laugh, and his grasp tightens. "It's still odd to hear those words come out of your mouth."

His shyness emboldens Mydei to lean in and kiss his cheek in assurance. To which Phainon laughs a little bit more, blushing harder at the affection.

"Is the crown prince allowed to be so sweet?" he says while rubbing at his chest with his free hand.

"He is," Mydei smiles in return, voice low and tender. "And if he isn't, I'll make it into a new law. Then no one will say a thing about it."

It's nice to see his face so red. Makes him feel triumphant, as if he bested his alpha in a competition. He caresses the side of his face, turning his face to lean in for a proper, tantalizing kiss. The heat radiating from Phainon seeps into his skin, warming him in return.

"I really can't believe this is all real and not a dream," Phainon whispers, their lips brushing together. He shifts back, biting at his lip nervously. After a moment, he takes his other hand in his. Rubs his thumbs along the knuckles of his gauntlets. Breathes in deep, and says,"Mydei, you have to promise me you will not push yourself and ignore your own wellbeing. I know you better than anyone else. You will grit your teeth and say it is fine when it's not."

And, of course, the way his eyes glisten from unshed, gathered tears lances through his chest. Such a foolish man he is, to care for what matters little. His tongue lays heavy in his mouth as a simmering ache builds. Yet, at the

same time, he lightens from his care; cherishes how Phainon beholds him with such a tender gaze, even if it frustrates him.

"I can handle it."

"No, Mydei—" he huffs in slight irritation. "I know you can handle it. I'm not denying your capabilities. I want you to enjoy this as much as I do."

"I will," he replies with certainty. "It won't be like last time. Not when you are in full control of your faculties. You said as such the time we spent bound together, and I trust your judgement."

Phainon presses his lips together, searching his features for any deceit, but he knows Mydei always means what he says.

"Just promise me," he whispers, shoulders wilting as he gives in.

"I promise."

Even though he wears gauntlets, Phainon brings his hands up and kisses the knuckles of both his hands.

"I don't have any lubrication. I'll need to purchase some," he says.

"Why not use weapon oil? It should be the same."

"I—" He gives Mydei a hard stare. "I'm not even going to warrant that a proper response. Why don't you make yourself comfortable here while I go out and buy some."

"Fine, if you think it necessary."

"I do."

After one more kiss and a sigh, Phainon stands and takes his leave with promises of his quick return. Mydei slumps onto the kline, lifting one of the amphora off the table and inspects the intricate detailing. It must be another fake if Phainon didn't regard it with any interest. The painted patterns are

not familiar, and he guesses it to be one from Styxia after some more scrutiny.

He takes off his armor, and tucks it away neatly. Arranges the cutlery. Organizes his spices in the correct order. His boredom grows as he waits. He lays on the kline and pulls out his teleslate, watching videos of chimeras prancing about and making the cutest noises.

It is a little annoying that Phainon treats him so delicately, frustrating that he prolongs their mutual desire for one another to purchase something for his comfort. It is wrong for him to go through such lengths for him. He doesn't need it. Another chimera video flickers on his screen, one where they chase each other around. But, at the same time, it is nice to be cared for in such a manner. Only his dead companions tried to convince him to not tear himself apart in his warpath.

The door opens and shuts, and he continues to enjoy the chimeras chirping at one another. After Phainon declares his return, his loud steps quiet when he hears no response from Mydei, no doubt thinking the other fell asleep, and creeps into the living room. He takes a small moment to admire the crown prince resting on his kline and watching videos on his teleslate like he owns the home. Like he belongs here, and shouldn't be anywhere else.

Two strong arms scoop Mydei off the kline, and he lazily says, "You're back."

"That I am." Phainon grins, his mood improved since their last conversation.

"I can walk on my own," he says as he's carried off to the bedroom.

"But this is more fun," Phainon insists, pushing the door to his bedroom open with his back. "You're light as a feather."

"Tsk," Mydei pretends to not appreciate his words, simmers the heat in his gut over being so easily manhandled. "Did you get what you needed?"

"What *we* need, and yes, I did." He's placed on the bed, and Phainon procures a vial with a flourish. "Ta-da."

"Should I applaud you?" He rests on his elbows, and places his teleslate on the nightstand.

"Wouldn't hurt for you to sing me praises of my chivalry," he playfully says, crawling on top of him, and wastes no time to nip at his neck. "Though, perhaps I should focus on making you sing in a different way tonight."

"Where did that trepidation of yours go?" he grumbles, but wraps an arm around his shoulders and threads a hand through his hair.

"Must have left me on the walk," he muses, and sucks right on his muted scent gland, leaving a bruise which will fade.

Mydei gives a muted moan at the gesture, tilting his head so he can leave another. He adjusts his legs, spreading them and his alpha slots right in. His ass presses against his groin, and his cock twitches at the contact. Finally. *Finally.* Tension releases from his shoulders at the small rocking of hips as Phainon sucks again on his neck, leaving another temporary mark.

Even though it is temporary, he is his, just as much as Phainon belongs to him.

Mydei grips the sheets with his free hand and sighs softly, pulling gently on Phainon's hair by the roots, encouraging him. Phainon's arousal presses against him, and he feels how much it has grown, how big the cock he hides is. A hit of desire spikes through Mydei, and he so desperately wants to see it again. To have him inside once again. Feel his massive cock stretch him as he thrusts again and again. But he needs to quell that roiling desire, take his time for Phainon's comfort.

"Mydei," Phainon's concerned voice brings him back. "Don't forget our promise."

"I won't," he assures, kissing the side of his head.

"I don't want to hurt you." Phainon rolls his hips again, and he shivers as he feels his length press firmer against his ass. "I can't. Not again."

"I..." he begins weakly, too distracted by what presses against him. He pushes into him, arching his back as Phainon grinds in return. "It is difficult."

"I know." Phainon bites at his neck again, lapping at the skin and savoring his scent before continuing, "But I'm trying to not let my own worries interfere with this. So, try for me as well."

A wave of discomfort rolls through him. It settles deep into him, digging into his bones and nestling within the marrow. He grips into Phainon's shoulders, wishing his alpha didn't care so deeply for his well-being. Wishes he could ignore how their bodies don't fit together, force his way through and pretend there were no issues. If Phainon never made a big deal of it, he could pretend through the pain.

Phainon kisses his cheek, then the tip of his nose. "Don't make such a face. It pulls at my heartstrings."

"I'm not making a face."

A slow kiss on his lips, another rocking of his hips. "It's only us here, you don't need to keep things yourself. No one will know."

Hah, no one will know. Phainon has used this line on him before, and he remembers it well. That night when he first tried to forbid him from scenting. But, he is not wrong. Inside of the walls of his home, no one can see, hear, or know of what they do. And, like with so many other things, it is difficult to resist Phainon.

"I already made my promise." His nails dig into the back of Phainon's neck, where he would be bitten for a bond.

"Good," Phainon says and inhales sharply. He grips Mydei's hips, grinding fully into him with fervor.

And Mydei rolls his head back against the pillow, peeking through his lashes to see his alpha above him, giving into his desire. The rocking pace is a preview of what is to come, and the thought elicits a tiny groan of his own. He wraps his legs around him so that every inch of him is felt.

The waves of desire build and build, his heart racing, heat pooling in his groin. His cock pushes against the confines of his pants, almost painful from his arousal, neglected from any attention given their position.

And he doesn't care. The strings woven tight around him unwind and unfurl, and all he wants is to feel Phainon rutting into him. Mydei wraps his arms around his shoulders, and clings tightly with his legs.

"Just like that," he breathes. "You're doing good. Give me everything you have."

And Phainon's hips jerk at the sudden praise. A keen whine from his mouth as he pushes harder, tilting his hips forward, and leans down to bury his nose in his neck. This close, he can hear Phainon's soft moans above the shifting of their clothes and the gentle creak of the bed. The fingers on his hips dig into his muscles as his pace turns from sensual to frenetic.

Not to let up for even a small moment, Mydei pulls his head to the side by the roots of his hair and bites his neck, tongue slipping beneath that choker of his. Phainon gasps, freezing at the teeth digging into his jugular.

"Mydei," he chokes out and begs, "Bite me harder. Please."

Even though he possesses no fangs, can't go as deep as his alpha, he clamps down harder. A bruise is what he can impart, but he wants more. Wants to mark Phainon as his for all to know, just like how his alpha can mark him with his scent. He pulls Phainon's head to the other side, craning his neck, and clamps down on his pale skin again.

Phainon moans again, and ruts into him frantically again. Whispering his name with heated passion.

Mydei releases a heavy, pleasured sigh. The heat trapped within his pants is overbearing, straining and confining, and he knows he must be leaking precum. But such a thing hardly matters when Phainon is coming undone before him.

"What? Can't handle a bite? I thought you were better than this." He chuckles darkly.

"M-Mydei," Phainon gasps at another particular grinding of friction, moans needily right by his ear. Pride swells in his chest.

He takes his ecstasy and surges forward, a wild grin spreading across his face, pushing Phainon onto his back. Hands grip his hips as Phainon thrusts helplessly upwards. Mydei pins Phainon's chest down, palms digging into his muscles, thumbs rubbing over the nipples poking through the black fabric of his shirt. Grinds his hips down, pressing that giant cock right into his ass.

Phainon throws his head back into the mattress as he moans so openly, his face and neck a delicious deep red, sides red and forming swollen bruises.

"Mydei-!" Phainon pants in his throes, his chin tilting upward as he desperately tries to maintain his gaze on Mydei's body. Nails dig into his skin in desperation.

And that pride of his bolsters further seeing Phainon so lost in his haze, and this time he will remember everything. Fantasize over it for days to come, just as he has. Etch this memory into his being.

Phainon cries out his name more and more in his bliss. Sweat prickles his brow, his hair clinging to his forehead and temples. And he squirms. Oh, how he squirms as Mydei works his hips, thrusting and grinding down against his cock. Even underneath all the layers of fabric, the distinct swell of his knot presses into his ass. Excitement tingles all over him, leaving a wake of goosebumps down his spine. Remembers the painful stretch and craves it.

His alpha tenses, and in a single moment bliss overtakes him. His eyes roll into the back of his head as a punctuated groan resounds from his throat, and his fangs prick into his lip as he bites into it. His hips stutter as he pushes himself more into Mydei, chasing the last remnants of pleasure

The black cloth of his pants turns even darker as cum soaks through them. The wet patch spreads further, making a mess of him. Hypnotized by the sight, Mydei pulls his shirt up and his pants down, releasing his thick cock from its confines. It springs out, shooting another string of cum in its freedom. Splatters against his stomach as his knot pulses around nothing.

Mydei wraps his hand around the base, gently applying pressure on his knot. And he feels how hot it is in his palm, how it pulses in his climax.

Phainon lets out a sharp whine as his heels dig into the mattress, clenching the sheets and twisting them in his grip in his writhing. More cum splatters against his belly, decorating his pale skin.

"Mydei—! I can't— Please I'm too—" he chokes out, strangling out another moan as he shoves the side of his face into the mattress. His back arches, and he chases his orgasm with a helpless bucking of his hips. Caught in between the turmoil of sensitivity and pleasure as his body fights to either retreat or indulge.

The cascade mesmerizes him, how his cum slides in between the divots of his abs, drips down his sides. There is so much. All of this had been pumped inside Mydei. No, in his rut there was definitely more. In comparison, it is an appetizer at most.

Mydei moves his thumb, pressing it into the underside of his knot, and Phainon twists and moans in pleasure, knuckles lose their colors from how tightly he grips. Another rope of cum is released, the air thick with its slightly pungent smell.

But, something is off—he recalls the swell of the knot larger than what it is now. Perhaps his rut affected him in a way he did not anticipate. He releases him, and helps him out of his clothes before they make a further mess.

Phainon digs the heels of his palms into his eyes, panting as he collects himself. "You are the cruelest man I know."

He hums in response, and finds his hamper to toss his clothes into.

"Seriously. Relentless."

Mydei heads towards the bathroom, his gait awkward for he sports a painful arousal of his own, and plucks a towel to help clean the mess he helped create.

When he returns, Phainon reclines on his elbows and turns to him with a pathetic look in his eye. Cleaning him up should take little effort, but with how clingy Phainon acts, he struggles to contain the mess. He tries to reprimand him for acting in such a manner, and Phainon takes it upon himself to silence him with a kiss. Eagerly forces his tongue inside his mouth, and tries to drag him down by pulling at his chiton.

"You were bigger before," Mydei says after he tears himself away to finish wiping him down.

The taunt works, for he almost chokes on his tongue. "I was in my rut! I am still the same size thank you very much."

"Hmph, I know you like to create fanciful stories, but your knot was larger in your rut." Once he finishes cleaning the mess, he puts the soiled towel next to his ruined clothes.

Phainon huffs, and drags him back onto the bed, working on unbuckling his belt.

He glances down, noting Phainon's half hardened state in comparison to his, then flicks his gaze back up. "Are you ready yet?"

"Ugh. Incorrigible," Phainon groans and shakes his head. "What am I to do with you?"

"Quit your whining," Mydei grumbles in return, shifting his hips to help Phainon slip off his clothes. "I said I am ready for you, yet here you are

acting like a pup who doesn't know what to do."

Phainon pinches his brow, ignoring the obvious taunt, and works his deft hands to undress him completely. The sight of his erection makes him pause, then gently push him down onto the bed, making sure Mydei rests upon the pillow. With reverent kisses, he trails down from Mydei's neck—who has to bite the inside of his cheek to quell any embarrassing noises—all the way to the base of his cock then up to his tip. Phainon's noses at his inner thigh, and inhales deeply before he runs his tongue against it, pressing hard enough his muscle divots, and nibbles the skin in the very same way he does with his neck. It almost tickles.

"Titans above. I think I might come from your scent here," he whispers, biting down harder and groaning.

Mydei tries not to squirm as his cock throbs. Digs his back into the bed and screws his eyes shut. "Hurry up already."

"Patience, darling," he coos as he rubs himself against his other thigh, no doubt imparting his scent, and bites at his scent gland with another heady moan.

"Enough with the teasing." His breath trembles as fangs sink into his skin. Hard, but not hard enough to break skin. And in a not so confident manner, he says, "I-I command it."

Phainon grabs the vial he purchased earlier, uncorks it and pours the lubricant on his fingers. Warms it up by rubbing. He spreads Mydei's legs, whispers soft words of assurance as a single finger traces his rim. For all of his bluster, Mydei clenches instantly, squirming at the odd sensation, but takes in a deep, shuddering breath to relax. That finger eases itself in and he tightens out of reflex again. Phainon massages his thigh with his free hand, gently coaxing Mydei to calm. And when he does, eases his finger further in.

Soft kisses pepper his entire face. Endearing words of encouragement are professed. Mydei spares a glance down and sees him hardened back to prime. Titans, he wants Phainon inside him. Wants to bask in that sweet

intimacy between them. Wants to be given both love and have his insides rearranged. Perhaps there is something wrong with him, but he can't bring himself to care when Phainon gives him a kiss on his cheek, and whispers a gentle warning of adding another finger in.

His hole stretches further over the thickened intrusion. Another tensing of his rim before he manages to relax. His heart races from adrenaline and gentle assurances whispered against his ear. Even if the fingers inside his body continue to stretch and make him feel terribly awkward, it is easy to forget when Phainon expresses his adoration in such a sweet manner. Coaxing him through the discomfort to relax. Mydei's chest warms with love, and he chokes down his moans, much to Phainon's displeasure who encourages him to let them loose.

His body overheats from the affection, from being treated so delicately. As a weapon made for war he should be resolute and hardened steel, yet he crumbles from something so delicate. As if all of his grand stature means nothing underneath the press of lips, of sweet words, and of tender touches.

A third, final finger slides into him and his eyes widen as he bites down his tongue. He is so full yet empty. He can't stand it anymore. The hunger within him grows, uncontained in its voracity. His hand catches Phainon's shoulder, digs his nails into skin, leaving crescent shaped marks.

And an uncharacteristic whimper leaves him as he begs, "No more. I want all of you."

"Not yet," Phainon says, kissing his temple. "Be a little bit more patient, my love."

My love. *My love.* Those words echo. Resound within his head. Spikes a jolt through his body, and his hips buck of their own volition against his hand. He feels the smile upon Phainon as another kiss is placed upon his head. Ah, how he hates how his body runs hot from the simplest adorations.

"N-Now?" he almost croaks the word, and hopes he sounds normal. Hopes the desperation clawing through him remains below the surface.

Hesitation spreads across Phainon's visage, and his throat bobs in a heavy swallow.

"Okay."

The fingers slide out, leaving him empty, and Phainon rearranges himself so his tip presses against his loosened entrance. Phainon inhales sharply through his nose, purses his lips in his silent worry, and eases himself in. Mydei breathes in deep as well, though his is far more steady of a breath. Prays for no blood to be shed and quiet the voice inside which speaks of their incompatibility.

Inch by inch, his alpha's cock stretches him out, not as terribly as before, and he forces himself still, to not writhe underneath the thick girth. Mydei groans as his head hangs to the side, his steady breaths transformed into panting. Another inch, and that heat pushing into him blazes through, stretches that fire to his stomach. By the halfway mark, he lets out a quiet grunt and arches his back as the pain sharpens and spikes; lancing towards his throat and he grips the sheets. To his dismay, Phainon ceases his action, and glances between them.

The color draining from his face can only symbolize one thing: Phainon's worries are found true. A trickle of warmth drips from his ass, marking the white sheets with a petal of gold.

"Don't—" he begins to say, but Phainon's shuddering breath and the tightening grip on his thigh interrupts.

"I hurt you." Phainon grimaces as he pulls out, shaken by his own anatomy. "I thought that would be enough."

Mydei rubs his hands across his face, trying to quell his racing heart in the face of his fears being brought to reality. Phainon sits on the edge of the bed, back facing towards him, elbows resting on his thighs as he covers his shame.

"I do not mind such a thing," he says. And when Phainon does not respond, he carefully sits then crawls closer to him. Unsure of what to do, he places a

hand upon his shoulder and gives what he hopes is a comforting squeeze. "You tell me of abandoning my restraint, yet you cannot let go of your own worries."

"One is for pleasure," Phainon mumbles in return, running a hand through his bangs, "and the other is a concern for your wellbeing. Considering how much you like to disregard such a thing, I have to be vigilant in this duty."

"Phainon, I want this. I want you."

"And I want you to not be in pain."

Mydei traces his fingers across his shoulder blades, to the dip of his spine, and caresses upwards, fighting through his own fears. Right now, he needs to be strong for both of them. And strength comes easier when it is for who he loves most.

"I am as prepared as I can be. The pain—" he stops himself, knowing Phainon will continue to rebuke his claims of it not mattering. His palm rubs into his nape and he instead says, "It is pleasurable. I figure such a thing might be odd for you to hear, but it is true."

"Hah, now I know you're trying to convince me and make me feel better," Phainon lets out a hollow chuckle. "How can such a thing be enjoyable?"

He places a kiss on the notch of his spine, and Phainon shivers underneath the affection. "Because I know myself well. My upbringing was unnatural, and it carries forward in unnatural ways. My body will heal, and it will reshape around you." He gives a lick at his nape, slipping it underneath the choker, enjoying the tremble which overcomes Phainon the instant he tastes the salty tang of his skin. "Besides, it is you with the most unusual predilections as an alpha. You want to be bitten here."

"I suppose you can be right sometimes," Phainon says with an air of teasing, but he knows the jovial response is a means to comfort himself. "Though, not every time. What a ridiculous sentiment you are airing."

To prove his words, he kisses his nape, to which Phainon preens and curls his head down, and this time he bites down with his teeth. He may bear no fangs to puncture the skin or the intrinsic dominance of an alpha, but he can leave a mark of his own. By no means is the bite light, it buries itself deep, bruising the skin underneath the pressure, leaving it red and undoubtedly bruised in the coming hours. It should be painful by all means—unpleasant at the core.

Yet, the sound coming from Phainon is keen from pleasure; a high whine as he grips at the sheets and wiggles his legs in delight. He does not fight him, does not try to tear away from the claiming mark. His body becomes pliant, and he wraps sturdy arms around him. Splays a hand across his sternum and the other wraps around his torso to keep him steady.

Mydei swipes his tongue across his teeth once he lets go, feels how heavily Phainon breathes within his hold. His heart hammers so strongly it pounds both into the palm of his hand and the front of his chest.

"What sort of alpha enjoys submission?" he whispers teasingly against his ear.

"Shut up," Phainon says, clutching the arm across his stomach. "I do not enjoy such a thing."

"You may say one thing with that mouth of yours, but your body's reaction dictates otherwise," he gloats, biting gently at the shell of his ear.

Ah, the heat from his cheeks is felt rather than seen. Mydei leans forward, kisses that scorched cheek of his, and Phainon whimpers in return.

"It's because it's you," Phainon weakly admits, fingertips skimming across his knuckles. "Only you."

"Then submit to me," he grins, and holds Phainon's cock in his hand, rolling his thumb across the tip, "and give me what I want."

The second he releases Phainon and goes to recline against the bed, his attention snaps to him. He beckons Phainon over with the tip of his head, a

hand on his cock as he pumps it with a slow stroke. Spreads his legs to welcome his alpha back. Phainon gazes at his display, pupils blowing wide as lust overtakes his thoughts, face colored into a brilliant rosy hue. He crawls on top of him, slow and steady, hand tracing up from his calf, to his knee, until finally resting atop his hip.

Mydei grabs the vial of lubricant, pressing it into Phainon's hand, who proceeds to pour it on his cock time and lathers it with a quick hand.

Once he gets into position again, he hesitates once more. Seeing this, Mydei suppresses his huff, and slides his finger underneath his choker, pulling him close.

"Quit hesitating, *my love.*"

Phainon's lips part as his breath holds, eyes growing wide in his staring. Embarrassment flusters through Mydei over his confession, but dire words are needed to break his alpha from his self inflicted wounds. He rubs at his chest, glancing away from the amazed stare, and tries to ease through his discomforting fluster of speaking so delicately and true. Things like this come easy to Phainon, not to him.

Before he knows it, the tip of his cock presses into his entrance again, this time wetter. He eases in, and Mydei doesn't hide the groan, relishes in the feeling. If Phainon must work through his worries, then he must reciprocate and not hold his pleasure.

The open groan makes Phainon stutter, and he pushes in faster than he wanted. The feeling of fullness engulfs him again, rounding out his insides and splitting him apart. He wraps his legs around Phainon's waist before the alpha has any second thoughts, grips his shoulders as he chokes out, "More. Give me more."

A small nod, and he buries himself deeper. Slowly, steadily. His body protests the intrusion, but his mind and soul welcomes him inside. A groan escapes him, his eyes fluttering shut the moment the pain ebbs into more then calms as his body reknits itself. Exhaling deeply once his entire length fits in, his knot resting just outside his rim.

Phainon tries to glance at their joining, but he grips his chin tight, forcing his gaze towards his face.

"Look at me, not there," he orders.

Phainon's throat bobs in a swallow. His golden pupils wide as he pants. Another nod, this time accompanied by a peck.

"Hmph." Pride grows from his alpha listening to him. It swells alongside the warmth of love and heat of passion. His hand moves to cup his cheek, giving it a light pinch. "You're doing so good for me, Phainon."

He drops his head against his shoulder, whining at the praise, rolling his hips as he braces himself on his arms. That familiar nipping on his neck, alongside a deep, comforting inhale.

"I smell good, don't I?" Mydei breathes, tracing the length of his spine and kneading his back in encouragement.

"Yeah." Phainon's hot breath fans across his neck. "Really, really good."

"Do you understand I like this now?"

He whimpers as he nods again, shifting his hips and the thick cock within him stirs, pressing against the sweet spot in his body, and Mydei groans at the spark of pleasure jolting up from his groin.

"Now, give me all of you," Mydei nearly begs, maintaining his dignity the best he can underneath the sudden bloom of pleasure, and threads his fingers through Phainon's hair, tugging lightly. "And don't forget it."

"I will never forget such a thing," Phainon whispers, hands drifting with feather-light, ticklish touches across his sides before holding his waist firmly. "Tell me if it gets too much."

Mydei pauses, swallowing thickly before saying in painful honesty: "I'll never have enough of you. You leave no scars upon me, yet you are the one I will always carry within me."

Phainon shifts, and captures his lips in a savoring kiss, as if he can taste the sweetness of his words on his tongue.

He starts slow. Working his hips in shallow thrusts, pulling himself out by an inch then back inside. Mydei murmurs encouragement as he wraps his arms around his shoulders, tilting his hips in a way to allow for deeper penetration, eager to receive all of him again. By now, his body has grown accustomed to his size, healed and wound itself until the ache minimizes to a slight discomfort.

But when Phainon takes a deeper thrust, he inhales sharply as a sting prickles him once again. And he holds Phainon close, not allowing him to separate and look. Keeps his face buried in the crook of his neck. His encouragement continues, urging him to keep going. For him to give all that he can. This is an intimacy only they can share, and he needs it to work; for them to fit together.

Once the initial trepidation passes, and Phainon finds his confidence, he begins to thrust inside in searching angles, seeking what he knows to exist which will bring him pleasure. And when he finally rubs his cock in just the right way, the tip grazing that sweet spot all the way to his base, does Mydei throw his head back and releases a loud, resounding moan, eyes screwing shut from unabated pleasure surging through him, tingling all the way to every extremity.

And, if his eyes were open, he would see the grin spreading across Phainon's features, shining in his boyish delight to see his lover so unrestrained and coming undone.

His weakness for pleasure is found, the pain eases into pleasure, and the pace of Phainon's thrusts increases. His fingers dig into Mydei's hips, keeping him in place, and the sound of skin slapping fills the quiet of the night alongside his moans. And Mydei twists and writhes with his pleasures unmuted. Grasping at the bed, at Phainon himself, anything within his reach as he succumbs to this toe-curling ecstasy.

And when Phainon bites down on his neck, it becomes too much. He squirms as he feels his cock pulse. The pooling heat in his gut centers into

himself. His back arches into the thrusts. A final one pulls him to the peak.

Untouched, he comes hard with a gasp, coating both of their stomachs. Sparks momentarily fill his vision as his breathing turns haggard, clenching around Phainon as shockwaves course through him.

In his dazed, blissful state, he can't see Phainon gazing at him in awe.

But he can feel his cock still warm and thick inside him all the way to the hilt, and it is still.

He pulls Phainon into biting kisses and commands, "Don't stop."

And Phainon listens. Oh, how he listens. His pace increases in its fervor, pounding into him through his spasms. He groans and bites his shoulder. Even if he feels raw, he wants all of Phainon. To be filled with his seed to the brim. To never think their bodies are incompatible ever again. They can work through this—through anything. Never wants to see his eyes wet with tears over the potential of hurting him. Never wants him to blame himself for things he cannot control.

So, when that knot of his pops inside, locking them in place once again, he holds him close, dirtying their bodies with his sticky cum. Bites into his neck the same way Phainon does for his. It hurts. It hurts to have that bulge thrust inside the most intimate place of him. Stings the corners of his eyes with prickling tears. But he wants all of Phainon for himself. Have his sweaty body draped on top of him as his euphoria overtakes any sensibilities he may carry.

Phainon deserves to smile in such a way where he forgets everything. Such a silly thing needs to be kissed. So he does. Over and over again. Until he can feel the giggle on his lips and hear the joy in his purr as they hold one another. And it is impossible to resist that grin spreading across his own features.

Phainon needs to understand he will be here for him now, and wait for him in the next life. In the Era Nova he will usher them into as the Deliverer of

Amphoreus. For anyone in the world, he believes Phainon to be the only one capable.

☼

Phainon's high collared shirt hides the bite mark on his nape, layered underneath the choker wrapped around his throat, but Mydei knows of its existence. It is there, and it's all he can focus on. He tracks it every time he watches the Deliverer move about. Remembers the saltiness of his skin against his tongue, the give of his flesh beneath his teeth. Saliva pools in his mouth, and he has the urge to pull down his collar just to admire it.

His. Marked. He doesn't need to be an alpha to feel the satisfaction course through him. The claim over Phainon runs his blood hot, distracts him from all of his responsibilities; to push him against the wall, kiss him senseless and leave him breathless. Fantasies from before inhabited a great portion of his thoughts, but now every waking moment there is nothing else he can think of.

He wants to wrap his legs around Phainon's waist. Feel his thick cock ease into his hole. Thrust against that sweet spot inside him, again and again. He misses the rise and fall of climaxing. If he could have it his way, they would not leave the bedroom for a week. He would enjoy the way Phainon bites at his neck, claws at his skin, and whimper in his desperation as he pushes his thick knot inside him.

Many times does he need to remind himself to quit drifting off into daydreams. Even if his fantasies run rampant, his countenance remains as neutral as ever. He nods when appropriate, grunts at sentiments spoken at him, glares when needed. But, if he could, he'd prefer to be in the privacy of his room with his Deliverer in his arms. On top of him, underneath him; it did not matter.

And he knows it is wrong to crave something so selfish when he is prince and his people need him. They look to him for guidance, but he is a thoughtless shepherd distracted by perverse fancies.

In the late nights, he tries satiating his passions by having his alpha take him again and again, but it brings no lasting reprieve. Phainon, who has now forgotten his crusade of late night reservations at Marmoreal Palace, happily obliges to his needs, less anxiety ridden after their first real encounter. His thoughts quiet for a few hours as he lays in a blissful haze curled up in his alpha's arms.

But it brings no long term solutions to his plight. His fancies grow more intense with each passing day, as if everything they do together is never enough.

And unease builds within. Has he become broken in some way? Before this, he had absolute focus on the crisis of his tribe, always at the ready to deal with their woes and fight for their rights. Perhaps it is because he has been idle for too long in the city. Maybe traveling into the frontier lands can fix his addled mind, an expedition for eradicating monsters or saving outsiders from perils might hone his dull blade.

"There is a recent sighting of a black tide mass lingering relatively close to Okhema," Aglaea tells him when he requests to be sent out on a mission. "Go there, and free us from this worry. But do be careful, there might be a challenging foe considering the size of this congregation."

So he climbs atop Kokopo's saddle and rides east. He can spare a few days to clear his mind, recalibrate back into what he should be and not a daydreaming, perverted teenager. The ride over is peaceful, nothing aside from the usual copses, old broken down caravans, and long running rivers. Kokopo makes easy works of the terrain, weaving through with graceful ease once the roads become tattered.

The black tide creatures begin to trickle in, and he leaps off his mount, landing on top of one with a devastating crunch. It evaporates into darkness, and a grin stretches across his visage. He missed this. He runs across the earth, striking at another with reckless abandon, his fist piercing through its

blackened chiton, the creature's blades scratching at his arm and golden ichor drips.

A surge of adrenaline pumps through him, his tempered state devolving to ferocity as he swings and kills more. Lands a kick and kills another. Picks one up by its spindly legs and hurls it into a conjoined mass. Arrows penetrate his flesh, but he rips them out and tosses them away. Now this is living. In the precipice of combat he is alive. His blood runs hot, every distraction wiped clean from his mind.

There are no Kremnoans picking apart his every action, no pressure of the Flame-Chase mounting on his shoulders, no selfish perversions overtaking him. Just conflict and strife. It breezes in the wind, fluttering his clothes and hair, splotches blood as he trudges through the river of souls and comes back to life.

Every death he focuses on what matters, solidifies it into the core of who he is; crown prince and a tender lover. Both can exist at the same time, neither has to conflict with his desires until the wheel of fate turns and forces his hand.

He fights and fights. Never once letting up in his vicious assault. The Okhemans are right about one thing: he is an absolute monster when it comes to the fields of conflict, a barbarian who knows only bloodshed.

His path of destruction leads him on a gradual ascent of the mountain. The surrounding woods cease into a cleared plateau, and his eye was instantly caught by a figure sitting at the cliffside, gaze fixed upon the sky where dawn bleeds into orange hues of the dark night; the place Kephale's light cannot reach.

To his shock, it is Phainon he beholds.

“Deliverer?” he calls out, catching his breath and wiping the blood off his skin as he approaches. “What are you doing out here? I don’t recall Aglaea saying she would send anyone else out here.”

He does not move and Mydei is sure he heard him.

“Phainon,” he says and stands a few feet away from him.

“Mydei,” Phainon begins slowly, his voice lacking any of his usual mirth, as he turns to look over his shoulder. “This is new.”

His hair raises on end. Something is off. The look in his eyes is dead; the night bleeds into his visage and darkens his features. No carefree smile graces him, he does not bounce to his feet in eager excitement. No immediate declaration of a contest over defeating the black tide monsters in either strength or speed. But that is him, he wears his signature white coat, grand blue and golden cape pinned to his shoulder. Items tailored specifically by Aglaea.

“Why are you here?” he asks, wanting to take a step back but stands firm, fearing it to be a new trick of the black tide.

Phainon sighs as his gaze drifts to the ground. Then, in a somber, quiet voice he says: “Waiting.”

And yet, he can't bring himself to throw an attack at the double. Perhaps his mental degradation has indeed pulled him so far away from reality that even a miserable replica gives him pause. Because that look in his eye pulls at his heartstrings. His instincts demand a fight, but at the very same time bring him comfort.

“For what?” he says with an air of trepidation.

“Mydei… What year is it?”

He answers despite his confusion.

“I see.” Phainon stands, his actions lacking any haste, then approaches him with careful steps. “Three years then.”

The scent of ash, burning matches, and heat of fire licks at his lungs. This isn’t Phainon, but at the same time it is. This close he can see the same exact eyes, the angle of his nose, the chisel of his jaw. The same choker

wraps around the same symbol of the sun etched onto his neck. His countenance resembles him, the habits, the everything. It is him, but not.

The weight of his presence holds a heavy gravitas, pinning him in place and constricting his throat.

“Mydei,” he says in such a wistful manner, and he beholds him with the most tender gaze. This close the scent of ash and smoke engulfs him, but there are no blazing fires. “You only call me by my name in the cycles we are together.”

The statement is odd, and even odder still for him to be so depressed about it. Have his actions not painted the clearest picture of them as an item? How happy he is to be with him. They have bitten one another's napes, kissed and scented. Slept in the same bed many nights in an embrace.

“We are,” he finds himself saying.

Without another word, he listlessly raises his arms, and wraps them around his sides. Pulls him close until they are flush against one another. His skin searing hot and scorching, and the scent of destruction floods through him. The tension of his body ebbs in his course exhale, then he buries himself into the crook of his neck in such a familiar way his soul knows it to be Phainon.

If this were a trick of Zagreus, the illusions of the black tide, or even something else, it does not matter anymore.

“I see,” Phainon says. And that scent of ash turns to one with subtle sweetness, and Mydei blinks back the surprise of being able to smell it. The burning of cedar wood. It clogs his throat, catches his breath. Everything in him screams it to be his pheromones, and a part of him grows giddy over experiencing such a thing. To smell the rise of sweetness which indicates his emotional shift.

In the flux between apprehension and contentment, he wraps his arms around his waist, trying to figure out what could have happened in the short window of time between him leaving Okhema and now for Phainon to be in

such a state. And when that subtle scent of sweetness grows, he finds himself encouraged by it. How such a small, comforting gesture can soothe him.

"What's wrong, Deliverer?" he asks in a soft, tender voice, rubbing at his back, wanting to ease his woes.

Phainon's breath hitches, and the hold upon him tightens. Fingertips ghost across his back until the flat of his palm rests on top of his weak spot. He presses his hand down on it, as if protecting it, but then his thumb strokes the skin above it, as if apologizing.

"I'm so tired."

"Then rest," he says and squeezes. The weight of Phainon leans on him further, and he holds him steady.

"I can't," he whispers in a course voice. "I need to find a way to save us all."

"You will. If there is anyone who can, it is you," he assures, confident in his words.

Phainon breathes out a ragged sigh. His scent easing to a crackling hearth of home. "You always have such confidence in me. Never once do you doubt what I must do."

Mydei raises a hand, threads it through his snow-white hair, scratching down his scalp in a comforting gesture. It must work, for Phainon leans into him more. Sweat prickles and forms as the scorching heat of his body envelops him. "You are my equal. Whatever you are going through, I will not turn away."

Phainon begins to nip at his neck, his hot breath ghosting along the expanse, but stops himself. Disallows the pleasure of the gesture he uses for comfort. Instead, he pulls away. Smokey wisps trail from the corners of his eyes.

“Deliverer what has happened in the short time I left Okhema?” he presses, grasping his arms before he can pull away completely. "Speak to me."

“In three years we will meet again,” he says and pries his hands off no matter how hard he clenches. “And I apologize for such a thing.”

"What are you talking about?" Mydei asks, a crack of desperation seeping through.

"Go home, Mydei. Enjoy your people, your companions, and..." His gaze drifts away, leaving his final word unsaid. "Cherish what you can until the time comes. Do that for me. Please."

The Deliverer turns to the cliffside, and walks. Mydei tries to get more answers from him, but he remains silent as he approaches the ledge. His feet do not stop. He continues, and falls.

Mydei dashes.

"Phainon!" he yells as he grasps the edge of the cliff, steeling against the vicious vertigo as he beholds the empty air and tall trees beneath.

No sign of him remains. A subtle breeze rustles leaves as his eyes dart around in their search. Disbelief overtakes him. Perhaps it was an illusion, a trick from Zagreus to mess with his emotions he tries to convince himself again. But it felt so real. No magic could replicate his alpha to such a startling degree.

An arrow pierces the back of his chest, and he curses underneath his breath as he tears it through him to be free of it. He still has more cleanup to do and can't spare any more moments to ponder over Phainon's strange appearance and disappearance.

The next strike he lands against the black tide creature is particularly vicious.

When he returns to Okhema, he ignores the greetings of his people, the curious glances and glares from Okhemans. He races straight towards Treasure of the Ages and cannot find Phainon there. He runs to the baths, searching every pool and bench for the man. It is only by a spared glance

towards the rooftops does he spot Phainon sitting at his favorite spot in Marmoreal Market and relief floods through him.

He sits there, legs dangling off the roof, gazing at the distant Dawn Device with a rather bored expression.

He makes his winding way up towards the rooftop, breathless from his constant sprinting, and calls out to him.

Phainon turns, the brightness of the Dawn Device glimmering in his eyes. His lips stretch from a pensive purse into a wide grin. "There you are! You know, you should really check your teleslate more often. Did you seriously go on an expedition on your own for a couple of days without inviting me? I didn't take you to be so afraid of losing to me in a contest."

And in this moment, he sees the two images of Phainon overlap, yet their countenance tremendously differ. There is no misery etched into every facet of his being, no desolation coloring his words grim. Three years he said. Three years until what?

"Why are you looking at me like that?" Phainon asks in worry as he stands; the steady push of palms against the roof tiles, the way his back bends and straightens. It's all the same. "Is everything alright?"

Is it three years of time he can share with Phainon until the wheel of fate turns and prophecies take hold? One alone shall witness the Era Nova, and he knows he will not be there to witness it. They will not welcome the new world together. All he can do is pray they will meet again in a peaceful life.

"Sweetheart?" he stands close now, face to face, his sky-blue eyes searching his features for an answer.

And Mydei takes a hold of his face, surging forward into a messy kiss. Phainon stumbles a step back in surprise before wrapping his arms around him to hold steady. Mydei grips his hips, and leads him until his back presses against the wall, and he does not let up in his affections. He bites at his bottom lip, pulling at it before he opens his mouth and Phainon's tongue meets his.

A heavy ache weighs in his chest, and he finds no salvation in his desperation. Not even when Phainon cards his fingers through his hair, scratching at his scalp as he softly moans into the kiss.

"I'm fine," Mydei says as he pulls away. "I needed to clear my head."

"And did you?" Phainon says a touch out of breath, hair a slight mess as it splays against the wall behind him. If he believes his words, he does not know, but he is thankful he pressures for no detailed answers.

"Yeah," he sighs, though he remains tense. He brings himself to Phainon's neck, and smells nothing amiss when he inhales. It is still the same soft scent of floral shampoos and soap lingering in his hair and skin, nothing like the strange Phainon from before.

"I'm quite glad," Phainon hums, resting the side of his head against Mydei's.

They hold one another, and the dread clinging to his bones lifts bit by bit. Phainon's hand drifts up and down his back, nails tracing the length of his spine, palm rubbing at stiff muscles, fingers kneading, and he melts into him when he rubs against his weak spot. One day, he will tell him about it; share his deepest held secret. But for now, he will appreciate the gentle embrace, feel the warmth engulfing him as ice retreats from his veins.

Phainon must know something is amiss, but he doesn't comment on it. He reclines against the wall, keeping him in his hold for as long as he needs, and allows for Mydei's thoughts to simmer and calm from their maelstrom.

"I didn't realize the crown prince became such an exhibitionist in the short while he was gone," he says after a while and Mydei fully relaxed. "Have I been too polite with keeping a cordial distance in public?"

Mydei instantly prickles and rips himself away. A few people from distant rooftops stare, even some on the streets below have their gazes fixed upon them, and whispers are shared. Embarrassment sears all the way to his ears. With a huff, he pushes off Phainon and crosses his arms.

And he hears Phainon laugh and feels him tug on the cape fixed to his pauldron, telling him he must cleanse himself in the baths in a cheerful intonation. Mydei spares him a glance from his profile, any indignation lost when he beholds his cheer.

Phainon is the dawn, the sun that will always rise and shine down upon the world he will bear. If three years is all he has, he will cherish every moment. Phainon will know of his love and support, be his steadfast companion in this life and the next. He will always push him towards what is right.

Mydei promises this to himself as he takes Phainon's hand in his, threads their fingers together, and allows himself to be pulled along by his ever-bright sun.

Chapter End Notes

> WOWOWOW we're finally at the end!! Thank you all for reading my very self indulgent story, i hope you enjoyed it as much as I did! Man, writing the last chapter is always difficult, but i'm glad I managed to finish. Sorry if there is any weirdness, it's a long chapter and my brain can only handle so much editing without a beta. I might update the tags tomorrow... too fried rn
>
> Off to my next fic~ i'll probs be trying to stick to one shots, but we'll see hehehe.
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